



Tata Trusts cry foul as Chandrasekaran returns ▶ P1



India's utility vehicle exports zip past smaller cars ▶ P1

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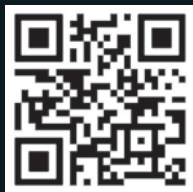
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Friday, September 18, 2026

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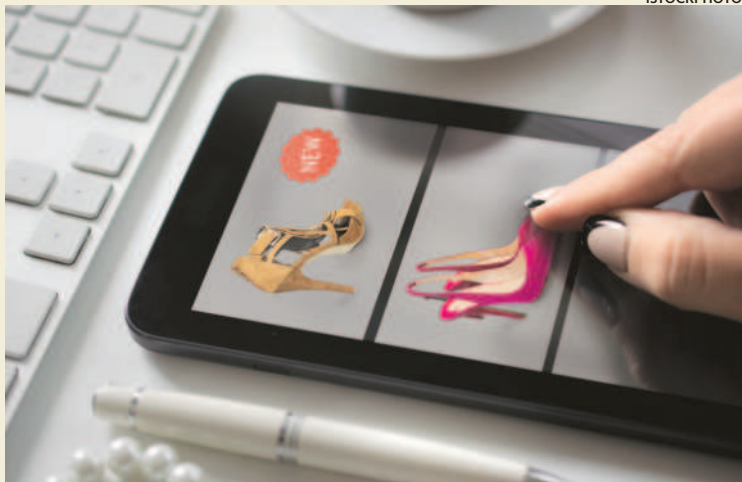
mint primer

Will new online shopping rules help customers?

BY RADHIKA P. NAIR

With e-commerce driving nearly 30% of national consumer helpline complaints in 2025 and India's online shopper base set to grow from 300 million to over 420 million by 2030, per BCG, concerns are rising over platform influence on buyer choices. The government has now tightened e-commerce rules but will this make online shopping safer?

ISTOCKPHOTO



1 What has changed in India's e-commerce rules?

The Centre's Consumer Protection (E-Commerce) (Amendment) Rules, 2026, effective 1 January 2027, introduce stricter compliance for platforms. To prevent misleading practices, platforms must show a product's lowest 30-day price during discounts, clearly label sponsored listings, avoid search manipulation, adhere to dark-pattern guidelines, and post annual self-audit compliance certificates. Marketplace platforms must disclose detailed seller and product information—including return terms, warranties, delivery, and origin details for imports. They must also join the NCH convergence process and provide buyers copies of recorded complaints.

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QUICK EDIT

Tata googly

In a dramatic twist at the Tata Group, the board of Tata Sons on Thursday voted in favour of another five-year term for N. Chandrasekaran as the group holding company's chairman. Controversy erupted over whether board member Venu Srinivasan had a right to vote. Redoubtably, assenting members based their decisions on earlier resolutions. Tata Trusts, with a 66% stake in Tata Sons, called the vote "illegal," baring a deep split in trying times. Noel Tata, as the Trusts' chief, was outvoted and Chandrasekaran asked to reverse his earlier decision not to seek an extension. The company whose leadership is being fought over may be headed for a public listing under a Reserve Bank of India rule for large financiers. Since at least a quarter of Tata Sons' equity would eventually need to float, the Trusts' stake stands to get diluted. Its minority partner, the Shapoorji Pallonji (SP) group, which owns 18.4%, needs cash to relieve debt and has been in a stand-off with Tata over an exit path. SP's shares are illiquid, since they need a Tata okay to sell off (or must be sold back to the group). Tata Sons going public would resolve that. But there might be space for a pre-listing Tata-SP deal too.

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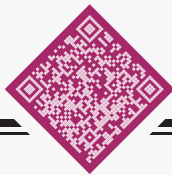
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PLAIN FACTS



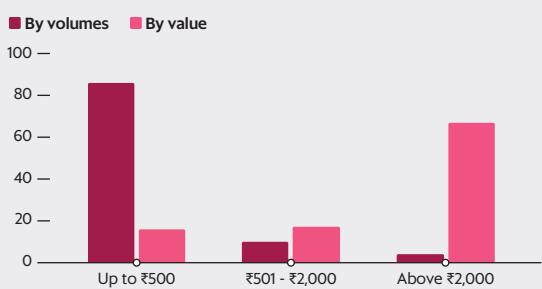
DATA RECAP THE WEEK IN CHARTS

CURATED BY HOWINDIALIVES.COM | feedback@livemint.com

From an impending levy on select UPI payments becoming reality to India's exports posting strong growth numbers in August, the continuing dispute over the listing of Tata Group holding company Tata Sons, the National Stock Exchange receiving a vote of approval from institutional investors and Formula 1 announcing a 2027 season that matches its longest—here are this week's news in numbers.

UPI CHARGES

Break-up of person-to-merchant UPI transactions (in %) by ticket size, 2025-26



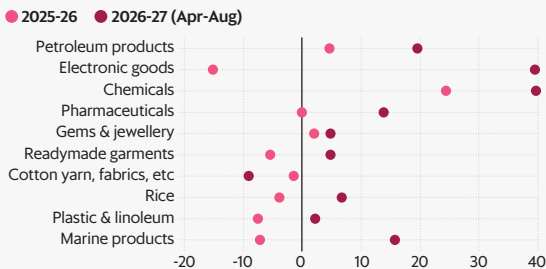
Source: Finance ministry



A DECADE after its launch, the unified payments interface (UPI) will see charges on certain merchant transactions from 15 October. The National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) said a 0.4% fee would apply to UPI transactions above ₹2,000 to merchants, subject to a ceiling of ₹300 per transaction. For fuel, telecom, railways and insurance, the fee will be a flat ₹5 per transaction. Finance ministry data shows 152 billion peer-to-merchant (P2M) UPI transactions, worth ₹91 trillion in 2025-26. Transactions above ₹2,000 were just 4% of P2M transactions by volume but 67% by value. Applying a 0.4% fee to this value would imply about ₹24,000 crore in annual fee revenue.

EXPORT SURGE

Year-on-year change in exports (in %), by value



Shows top 10 categories by share in India's good exports during Apr-Aug 2026, arranged in descending order.

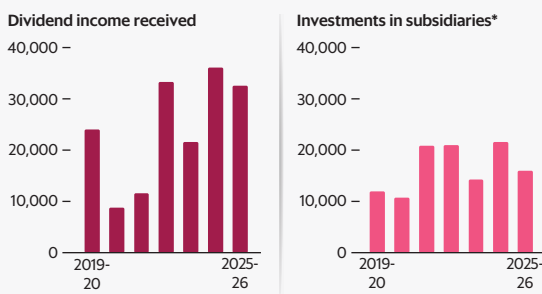
Source: Directorate General of Commercial Intelligence and Statistics



INDIA'S GOODS exports turned in robust numbers in August, lifting their performance for the five-month period from April to August. The total value of India's goods exports increased 26% in August year-on-year. For April-August, the increase was 17.8%; excluding petroleum products, growth stood at 14.4%. Of the top 10 sectors, accounting for about 83% of India's goods exports during the April-August period, nine recorded higher growth than in 2025-26, with five posting double-digit growth. However, for a clearer picture of the growth, these numbers should be adjusted for the rupee's depreciation from ₹88.30 to the dollar in 2025-26 to ₹95.11 during April-August 2026, a decline of 7.7%.

TATA IMBROGLIO

Key financials of Tata Sons (in ₹ crore)



*and associate companies.

Source: Annual reports



IT WAS another week of activity and intrigue at the top echelons of the Tata Group. Tata Sons, the group holding company, was said to be exploring options, including a legal challenge, to the central bank's directive requiring it to go public. On the other hand, the Tata Sons board voted in favour of N. Chandrasekaran continuing as chairman, reopening the question of succession. The developments also put the spotlight on Tata Sons' financial role within the group: over the last seven years, it has received about ₹1.67 trillion in dividends from group companies and invested ₹1.16 trillion in them. All eyes will now be on its annual general meeting, which is required to be held by 31 December.

NUMBERS TALK

● **25 basis points:** The quantum by which the US central bank increased its benchmark interest rate, to 3.75-4%. This is the first time it has raised rates since July 2023.

● **4.8%:** This is the year-on-year retail inflation in August, which rose to a 20-month high and stayed above RBI's medium-term target of 4% for the third consecutive month.

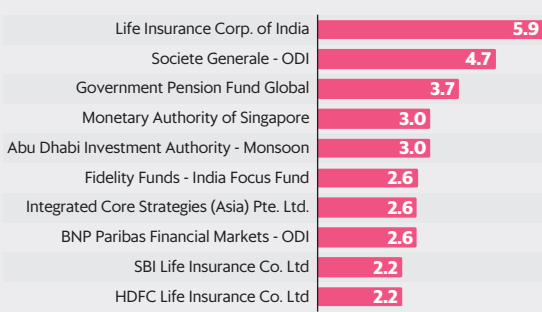
● **\$1.4 billion:** The funding raised by 281 companies in India's semiconductor industry, with about half of the total flowing in since 2025, according to Tracxn data.

● **150%:** The increase in daily charter hire rates for oil tankers to India, to \$250,000 from about \$100,000, in the past two weeks amid escalating hostilities in the Red Sea and Strait of Hormuz.

● **5.4%:** The year-on-year increase in the amount of freight loaded by the Indian Railways in August. Key sectors that saw an increase in demand were coal, iron ore, steel and fertilizers.

NSE ANCHORS

Share of allocation to anchor investors in NSE IPO (in %)



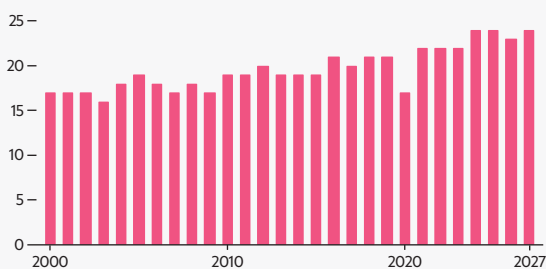
Source: Exchange filings



THE NATIONAL Stock Exchange on Wednesday allotted shares worth ₹6,746 crore to anchor investors, ahead of its much-awaited initial public offering (IPO). The shares were allotted at ₹1,785 apiece, the upper end of the IPO price band. In all, NSE allotted shares to 189 anchor investors. The top 10 anchor investors include three life insurance companies, led by LIC, which received the highest allotment, accounting for 5.93% of the anchor issue with an investment of about ₹400 crore. The list also included three sovereign funds from Norway, Abu Dhabi and Singapore. The NSE IPO opened to the public on 17 September and will close on 21 September.

PACKED CALENDAR

Number of races per Formula 1 season



The 2020 calendar was affected due to covid-19. Data for 2026 and 2027 shows scheduled races.

Source: statsf1.com



FORMULA 1 released its race calendar for 2027 on Wednesday, scheduling 24 races for the season. If held as planned, the next season will match 2024 and 2025 for the maximum number of races held in an F1 season. F1 had also planned for 24 races for 2026 season, but the US-Iran war led to the cancellation of two races in Saudi Arabia and Bahrain. These races are back on the 2027 calendar, kicking off the season. Other changes from 2026 include the return of races in Portugal and Turkiye, and an increase in 'sprint' events—additional races run over one-third the race distance—to 10 from 6. www.howindialives.com is a database and search engine for public data.

MINT BEST OF THE WEEK

UPI's MDR returns



UPI's merchant discount rate is back, but most users and small merchants will remain insulated. The charge applies selectively, mainly to higher-value merchant payments. The bigger question is whether MDR can fund growth without pushing merchants towards cash or costs onto consumers.



NSE's narrow path



NSE's ₹22,569 crore IPO looks tempting at a roughly 30% discount to BSE, but the gap comes with a catch. Its derivatives business is recovering after regulatory disruption, yet market share has fallen sharply. NSE has little room for earnings misses unless recurring businesses gain scale.



Inflation's second act



India's inflation climbed to 4.8% in August, with food and core prices also accelerating. Rising crude, weak rainfall and an unfavourable base effect could push headline inflation towards 6% by October-November. Economists now see the RBI potentially beginning rate hikes as early as October.



Friday, September 18, 2026

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Will Hyrox ooze money for its Indian backer? ▶ P12



Tata, Applied Materials boost India's semiconductor push ▶ P3

SENSEX 74,314.59 ↓ 21.86

NIFTY 23,270.6 ↑ 53

DOLLAR ₹95.89 ↓ ₹0.02

EURO ₹110.06 ↑ ₹0.66

OIL \$100.38 ↓ \$2.04

POUND ₹128.49 ↑ ₹0.74

Trusts cry foul as Chandra returns

Tata Sons boss back in 4-1 vote; board cites Trusts resolution

Varun Sood & Satish John
BENGALURU/MUMBAI

An unprecedented revolt at Tata Sons has plunged India's largest conglomerate into a critical governance crisis, after directors voted to grant chairman N Chandrasekaran a fresh five-year extension in the face of objections by Noel Tata, who chairs the charitable trusts holding a majority share of the company. Tata termed the decision a "legal nullity" and vowed to press on with the search for a successor, opening up a chasm between the holding company and its majority-owner that lawyers expect to play out in courts.

After a meeting that ran close to four hours, the six-member board reappointed Chandrasekaran for five more years when his term ends on 20 February. Four directors voted in favour, while Tata voted against. Trustee-nominee Venu Srinivasan sided with the majority.

Tata Sons said: "At the meeting of the board on September 17, 2026, Chandra acceded to the board's request to reconsider his decision. The board thereafter resolved by a majority vote to re-appoint him as executive chairman for a further

BOARD GAMES

Conflict has implications for Tata Sons' IPO mandate, SP Group's debt reduction plans, and relationship between Tata Trusts and Tata Sons

WHAT IS TATA SONS SAYING?	WHAT ARE TATA TRUSTS SAYING?
Tata Trusts backed reappointment in July 2025	Chandra's 12 Aug decision was his own, not due to a review
Chandra chose to leave as matter was not resolved at Tata Sons board meetings	Consequences of publicly communicating it can't be undone
Chandra agreed to board request to reconsider decision; reappointed on 4-1 vote	Reappointment legally null; it needs majority nod from Trusts nominees
Board has resolved to comply with RBI guidelines on listing	Ex-CJI DY Chandrachud has backed Trusts' stand
N Chandrasekaran	Noel Tata

Source: Press statements released by Tata Sons and Tata Trusts.

term of five years upon the expiry of his current tenure." The company added that "the board also resolved to initiate steps to comply with the applicable RBI Guidelines and will seek guidance from RBI, Tata Trusts

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Noel Tata submits SP Group plan for ₹25,000 crore >P5
Noel to veto IPO, says Chandra can't reverse exit plan >P5
Debt-free status can't avert listing, clarifies RBI >P5

Export reset

Utility vehicles gain the lead over passenger cars as India's overseas product mix shifts towards larger models.

	Total passenger vehicle exports	Share of passenger cars (%)	Share of utility vehicles (%)
FY24	672,105	34.9	63.9
FY25	770,364	47	51.8
FY26	905,200	49.6	49.2
FY27*	360,553	42.8	56.5

*Until August 2026. Passenger cars include sedans and hatchbacks. Utility vehicles include SUVs, MPVs and MUVs

Source: Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers

MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

India's utility vehicle exports zip past cars

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NEW DELHI

India's larger passenger vehicles, led by sports utility vehicles (SUVs), have raced ahead of smaller cars in the export market in the first five months of this fiscal year, paving the way for the segment to dominate annual overseas sales for the first time, according to two industry executives and analysts.

Higher exports of such utility vehicles, driven by India's largest carmaker Maruti Suzuki India Ltd, have helped the category keep a lead over passenger cars for 10 months now.

Exports of SUVs, multipurpose vehicles (MPVs) and mul-

ti-utility vehicles (MUVs)—classified together as utility vehicles—jumped 23% year-on-year to 203,582 units during April-August, comprising 56% of India's passenger vehicle shipments, the Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers said earlier this week.

Car exports fell 16% to 154,190 accounting for a 43% share. The remainder was made up by passenger vans. Put together, total passenger vehicle exports grew by 2% to 360,553 units. Maruti's exports grew 14% to 186,603 units, with utility vehicles making up 62% of the total.

"Maruti Suzuki not only is the leading player in the over-

Street braces for rate hike after Fed's hawkish turn

Subhana Shaikh
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MUMBAI

Indian markets are bracing for monetary policy tightening, with expectations of a half-percentage-point repo rate hike by December strengthening after the US Federal Reserve raised rates by a quarter percentage point and signalled another hike later this year.

Markets will closely watch the 7 October Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) meeting, where the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI's) rate-setting panel is expected to end its almost year-long easing cycle with a 25-basis-point (bp) rate hike, according to at least five market participants. One basis point is one-hundredth of a percentage point.

Market participants expect the central bank to raise the rate at which it lends short-term funds to banks again in December as the global policy mood turns hawkish.

On Wednesday, the US Federal Open Market Committee

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DII inflows fall short after US Fed hikes rate >P4

DON'T MISS



India on guard as US readies stiff levy for ties with Russia

New Delhi said it will take all necessary steps to safeguard its energy security, after the US House of Representatives passed a sanctions bill authorizing up to 100% tariffs on countries such as India and China over their Russia oil ties. >P2

Brookfield to invest \$600 mn in ACME's green molecules biz

Private equity major Brookfield will invest up to \$600 million in ACME Cleantech Ventures to support the development of an advanced pipeline of ACME's green molecule projects in India and West Asia. >P3

Advent to acquire 24.9% in Yatharth Hospital for ₹3,150 cr

Global private equity firm Advent International will invest ₹3,150 crore in Yatharth Hospital and Trauma Care Services Ltd for a 24.9% stake, the companies said on Thursday. The firm has nine multi-specialty hospitals with around 2,800 beds. >P3

Wild swings keep funds wary of large trades in CAS

Indian mutual funds are increasing their participation in the stock market's new closing auction—but mostly in trades too small to matter, several fund managers told Mint, wary of the sharp price swings that can occur within the 15-minute window. >P4



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- ✗ **No charge for all merchants on UPI payments below ₹2,000.**

A consumer awareness initiative by MobiKwik





The conference comes ahead of GST Council meeting. MINT

Centre to hold state finance ministers' conference

Dhirendra Kumar
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NEW DELHI

The Union finance ministry will hold a two-day conference of state finance ministers and finance secretaries beginning Friday to discuss financing priorities for India's development, including the implications of goods and services tax (GST) reforms, agricultural transformation and the energy transition, the finance ministry said in a statement released on Thursday.

The conference, titled "Financing India's Journey towards Viksit Bharat", comes ahead of the 7 October GST Council meeting and the start of pre-budget meetings for the Union Budget 2027-28 from 12 October. The meetings are scheduled to continue until mid-November.

The timing is significant for states as they prepare their own budgetary and financing priorities while the Centre works on the next Union budget. The conference will focus on policy complementarities between the Centre and states, as they balance development spending with fiscal consolidation, the ministry said in the statement.

The central government has pegged its FY27 fiscal deficit target at 4.3% of GDP, down from 4.4% in FY26, as part of its debt-consolidation path.

This conference also comes as inflationary pressures warrant closer attention. Retail inflation rose to a 20-month high of 4.82% in August, moving above the Reserve Bank of India's 4% target midpoint for the third consecutive month.

The meeting is not a pre-budget consultation, although states are preparing their own budgetary and financing priorities ahead of the next Union budget.

In the previous budget cycle, finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman held a pre-budget consultation with states and Union territories in January, where states raised issues including continued support for capital investment.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](https://www.livemint.com).

India on guard as US readies stiff levy for ties with Russia

The US bill allows Trump to impose tariffs of up to 100% on Russian energy importers

Banikinkar Pattanayak & Rituraj Baruah
NEW DELHI

India will take all necessary steps to safeguard its energy security and economic interests, the government said on Thursday, stressing that it had appraised Washington of the likely impact the proposed US law targeting Russian energy-importing countries could have on bilateral ties and the global oil market.

The development comes as crude oil topped \$100 a barrel amid the prolonged West Asia conflict, adding to concerns for India, which imports about 90% of its crude oil, more than a third of it from Russia.

The US House of Representatives late Wednesday passed a bipartisan sanctions bill targeting Russia over the Ukraine war, giving President Donald Trump the power to slap up to 100% tariffs on countries such as India and China for their energy imports from Russia. The US Senate has passed the bill. It is expected to be soon signed by Trump to become a law.

"India has noted the passage of the Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act in the US Congress and it is monitoring further developments on this matter," the ministry of external affairs said in a statement. "This issue has been discussed at high levels in recent months with various US interlocutors. Its potential implications for not just the



The US move could disrupt the oil market. BLOOMBERG

bilateral relationship but also the international energy market have been very clearly articulated by the Indian side."

Determined to take "all necessary measures" to protect its interests, the government said it will work closely with domestic trade and industry bodies to deal with the implications. "As stated on several earlier occasions, India remains firmly committed to ensuring energy security for its 1.4 billion people. It will continue to do so through diversified sourcing and on the basis of evolving market dynamics," the ministry said. Indian trade and foreign affairs ana-

lysts warn that Trump could use the new law to put pressure on India to give in to his demands in the trade deal that both sides are currently negotiating. India will look to further diversify its energy sources, they said. The analysts don't expect the US to slap heavy tariffs on China, as Beijing has leverage over Washington in critical mineral supplies, among other things.

Commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal will travel to the US later this month to attend the G20 trade ministerial in Milwaukee, where he may meet US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer, commerce

secretary Rajesh Agarwal had said this week.

The latest US move, aimed at forcing out Russian supplies from the global market, could disrupt the oil market and further push up global prices, inflating costs for net importers and developing countries such as India, analysts said. This could stoke inflationary pressure and balance of payment issues in these countries, even as India is on a relatively strong footing.

Currently, India's exports to the US face different duty rates—about 55%, including engineering goods, are subject to the usual most-favoured nation duties and a punitive tariff of 10% for alleged use of forced labour. Another 35-40% of goods—such as smartphones, pharmaceuticals and certain farm products—are exempted from the levy, while exports of steel and aluminium face a 50% tariff.

In fiscal year 2026, India exported goods worth \$87 billion to the US, its biggest market.

An Indian commerce ministry spokesperson declined to comment on the matter. Queries sent to the offices of the US Trade Representative, US commerce secretary and the US Embassy in New Delhi on Thursday afternoon were not immediately answered.

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For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](https://www.livemint.com).

Market regulator plans to look into UPI MDR concerns

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MUMBAI

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) will look into concerns raised by stockbrokers over the merchant discount rate (MDR) on UPI transactions, chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey said on Thursday, signalling a possible review of an additional cost that could affect the economics of digital fund transfers in the securities market. "I think there are some important issues there. We will certainly look into it and see how we can ease them," Pandey said.

The comments come after the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) on Tuesday introduced charges on UPI payments above certain thresholds. From 15 October, person-to-merchant (P2M) UPI transactions above ₹2,000 will attract a 0.4% fee. For transactions of ₹75,000 and above, the MDR will be capped at ₹300. Capital-market transactions, including those involving mutual funds, securities and brokers, will attract an MDR of 0.02%, also capped at ₹300.

The rules pose a challenge for stockbrokers who accept payments from investors using UPI. Sebi requires registered brokers to use valid UPI handles and display them on their websites so investors transfer money only to verified



Sebi chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey. MINT

accounts. Brokers are concerned that the MDR could exceed the brokerage revenue generated from the associated trades. A transfer of funds into a trading account does not necessarily result in a trade. A client may transfer money and leave it unused, which means that the broker will incur a payment-related cost without earning brokerage revenue.

The potential impact could be amplified by Sebi's quarterly settlement rules, under which brokers must periodically return unused client funds. Clients may then transfer the money back into their trading accounts, creating another UPI transaction.

Mint reported on 16 September that the BSE Brokers' Forum had urged Sebi to examine the issue, which could have a significant impact on discount brokers operating on thin margins.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](https://www.livemint.com).

Govt revamps cotton testing labs amid textile hub push

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NEW DELHI

The Centre has begun revamping the country's cotton fibre testing infrastructure, with the Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS) expediting the modernization of 21 laboratories across key cotton-producing regions, two government officials said.

The ₹38.72 crore project, under the Department of Consumer Affairs, will equip laboratories operated by the Textiles Committee, Power Loom Service Centres and the Cotton Corporation of India (CCI) with modern equipment to assess cotton fibre quality and impurities.

The aim is to strengthen quality assessment closer to cotton-producing regions, support fairer quality-based transactions and improve the competitiveness of Indian cotton and textiles in global markets. India accounts for about 23% of global cotton output.

Queries sent to the Department of Consumer Affairs remained unanswered till



India accounts for about 23% of global cotton output. AFP

press time.

The project will equip the 21 laboratories with modern testing equipment to assess cotton fibre quality and impurities, the officials said.

"The standards body plans to deploy 22 high volume instrument (HVI) testers and 44 trash analysers across the 21 laboratories under its testing infrastructure project," one of the two officials said.

The official added that 14 HVI testers and 28 trash analysers have been installed and commissioned across 13 labo-

ratories this year. Of these, 11 laboratories belong to the Textiles Committee and two to CCI, this person said.

HVI testers assess the quality of cotton fibres, including their length and strength, which affects the quality of yarn and fabric, while trash analysers measure impurities such as leaves, stems and other unwanted material in raw cotton. Together, they help ensure better-quality cotton before it is spun into yarn and made into garments such as shirts.

The laboratories span northern, central, southern and eastern regions, covering major cotton-producing states including Punjab, Rajasthan, Gujarat, Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu and Odisha.

The remaining equipment under the project will further expand the network's testing capacity. The upgrade focuses on two key aspects of cotton testing: fibre characteristics and impurities.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](https://www.livemint.com).

CESL eases PM E-bus Sewa tender terms

Manas Pimpalkhare & Ayaan Kartik
NEW DELHI

Convergence Energy Services Ltd (CESL) has added Haryana's demand for 450 electric buses to its third tender under the Centre's PM E-bus Sewa scheme, taking the total order size to 4,054 buses, while easing some conditions to sweeten the deal, documents reviewed by Mint showed.

The tender, whose closing date has been deferred at least five times, now allows a single entity to bid for 2,717 buses, up from 2,400 earlier.

Bidders can also include fresh equity raised in 2026-27 towards their net worth—a significant change given that electric buses cost ₹1.2-1.3 crore, more than twice as much as diesel buses, according to estimates by industry stakeholders.

"The equity infusion makes sense because half of FY27 is already over, so fundraising during this period can be counted. The aggressive bidders are largely new-age manufacturers that lack the turnover of incumbents and there-



CESL has added 450 Haryana electric buses, taking the total tender size to 4,054 buses. PTI

fore rely on equity infusions, said Shyamasis Das, who leads the electric mobility research vertical at the New Delhi-based think tank,

the Centre for Social and Economic Progress (CSEP).

CESL confirmed the changes in an email response to Mint, noting that they are in line with previous electric bus tenders.

Mint's queries emailed on 15 September to the ministries of

housing and urban affairs and heavy industries, as well as the Government of Haryana, remained unanswered.

Of Haryana's 450 e-buses, 100 each to be deployed in Gurugram and Faridabad will not qualify for PM E-bus Sewa incentives but will be covered by the central government's PM E-bus Payment Security Mechanism scheme, according to the tender documents.

The tender now allows a single entity to bid for 2,717 buses, up from 2,400 earlier

MINT SHORTS

Centre bars stem cell therapy for autism as routine care

New Delhi: The health ministry has said that stem cell therapy for autism spectrum disorder cannot be offered as routine or commercial clinical care and can be used only in duly approved clinical trials. The move seeks to prevent sale of unproven treatments and ensure that providers comply with existing framework or face penalties. PRIYANKA SHARMA

NaBFID targets \$4 billion in dollar funding by December

Mumbai: National Bank for Financing Infrastructure

and Development (NaBFID) is targeting a total dollar-fundraise of about \$4 billion by December through loans and bonds under the Reserve Bank of India's discounted hedging facility, its chief said on Thursday. NaBFID aims to raise as much as \$1 billion through its maiden bond issue with a 10-year maturity, its managing director Rajkiran Rai said. REUTERS

Central bank may increase debt sales to drain liquidity

Mumbai: Indian bond traders expect the RBI to step up bond sales for liquidity absorption, as policymakers likely seek to strengthen transmission of expected rate hikes, after the first such auction in nine years recorded strong interest. Excess liquidity can weaken monetary-policy transmission, reducing banks' need to borrow at the RBI's policy rate, delaying increases in lending rates and supporting demand for government bonds. REUTERS

Govt steps up monetization of land with RINL auction

ISTOCKPHOTO

New Delhi: The National Land Monetization Corporation (NLMC) will host a series of investor meets to attract potential bidders for the e-auction of 459 land parcels owned by Rashtriya Ispat Nigam Ltd (RINL). The meetings will take place next week across Visakhapatnam (23 September), Vijayawada (24 September), and Hyderabad (25 September). DHIRENDRA KUMAR

Steel exporters get wider EU duty-free access ahead of FTA

New Delhi: India's steel exporters could get significantly more duty-free access to the European Union (EU) than envisaged in the India-EU free trade agreement (FTA), with a new quota regime covering up to 2.8 million tonnes of annual shipments even before the FTA takes effect. HARSH KUMAR

RBI cancels certificate of registration of 5 NBFCs

Mumbai: The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Thursday said it has cancelled certificate of registration of five non-banking finance companies (NBFCs), according to a release. The central bank separately said eight NBFCs have surrendered their licences and exited the Non-Banking Financial Institution (NBFI) business. PTI

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Micron to scale up India chip facility

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NEW DELHI

India's semiconductor policy push has given the industry a strong foundation it didn't have, and the nation has moved from vision to execution now, Micron chief executive officer (CEO) Sanjay Mehrotra said on Thursday, as he announced the company's plan to scale up chip assembly and testing facility here by multifold next year.

"For decades, people have talked about India's semiconductor potential. I have been in many of those conversations. Potential does not ship products. What I see in India today is execution," Mehrotra said, speaking at the SEMICON India 2026 inaugural.

Micron has been here for seven years, he said, adding that the country employs more than 7,000 people in India directly and its work supports tens of thousands more jobs across the value chain.

"Earlier this year, we began commercial production at Sanand, Gujarat. It is the first semiconductor assembly and test facility here in India and the first project under the India semiconductor mission...finished DRAM and NAND products are now leaving Gujarat for customers around the world carrying a label this country has waited a long time to put on a memory chip - the Made in India," he said.

Mehrotra said that Micron designs memory chips in Bengaluru and Hyderabad, assembles in Gujarat, and ships them to customers in every continent.

Tata, Applied Materials boost India's semiconductor push

Tata Electronics signs 7 MoUs as Applied Materials commits \$5 bn to expand India operations

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A string of new agreements by Tata Electronics and a \$5 billion investment commitment from US semiconductor equipment maker Applied Materials were among the major developments on the first day of India's annual semiconductor event.

The announcements came as Union IT minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said that the second phase of India's national semiconductor programme, Semicon 2.0, had attracted investment commitments of \$11-12 billion, or about ₹1 trillion and that these are expected to be made over the next two to three years.

On Thursday, Tata Electronics signed seven memoranda of understanding (MoUs) with companies, including Dutch compound-chip maker Nexperia and Japanese semiconductor materials supplier Fujifilm, to expand India's semiconductor ecosystem.

While the value of all the deals was not disclosed, Fujifilm has committed ₹800 crore to set up a materials plant alongside Tata Electronics' chip fabrication unit in Gujarat's Dholera.

President of Applied Materials' Semiconductor Products Group Prabu Raja said that the company will invest \$5 billion in the country over 10 years to deepen semiconductor research and development, expand the local supply chain and develop talent.

Vaishnaw said the deals had expanded India's total semiconductor investments to \$12 billion. "The investment numbers that we are seeing today are of the order of ₹1 trillion, about \$11-12 billion."



India's sole chip fab by Tata Electronics, being built in Dholera, is expected to take until at least 2028 to operationalize.

REUTERS

"That much investment we are seeing among the people who have met us. Many others are looking to set up their bases in India. Now these bases will be of two different levels. There would be some who would just like to do design

announcement of Semicon 2.0 in July, New Delhi's ₹1.28-trillion incentives package to attract investment for a second chip fab and to offer equity-linked support to startups to build local chip design patents.

SEMICONDUCTOR RACE

VAISHNAW said Semicon 2.0 had attracted investment commitments of about ₹1 trillion

THE investments are expected to be deployed over the next two to three years

CONGLOMERATES have invested over ₹4,000 crore in semiconductor subsidiaries

THE government is targeting at least 200 chip-design startups and companies in Semicon 2.0

here. There would be many others who would like to do both design and manufacturing here. We will support both," the minister added.

Semicon India 2026 follows the

Meanwhile, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, speaking at the event, pitched India as a trustworthy location for building semiconductor capabilities. "When a country like ours suc-

ceeds in a critical industry, it strengthens the global supply chain—a fact that has become even more significant at a time when supply chains are being weaponized."

"International companies can now collaborate with Indian startups, Indian design companies, and local companies to build the semiconductor ecosystem," Modi said.

Vaishnaw added that of the 12 chip projects that have received incentives under Semicon 1.0, five have begun commercial production. All of these, to be sure, are chip-testing, packaging, and assembly factories. India's sole chip fab by Tata Electronics, being built in Dholera, is expected to take until at least 2028 to operationalize.

Among other investments, US chip equipment maker Lam Research said on Wednesday, ahead of Semicon India, that it would invest nearly \$1.1 billion (₹10,000 crore) over the coming years to establish its first silicon component manufacturing facility in India and expand its research and development operations.

Mint reported on 27 August that India's conglomerates have invested over ₹4,000 crore in semiconductor subsidiaries.

So far, India's investments have focused on chip assembly plants. With Semicon 2.0 under the ministry of electronics and IT (MeitY)'s India Semiconductor Mission (ISM), New Delhi hopes to have local chip equipment makers, materials, gases and chemicals suppliers, and even a first display chip fabrication plant over the next six years.

Under Semicon 1.0, more than 105 startups participated in chip design, with around 20 securing about ₹800 crore in venture capital funding.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Centre restricts selling chip plants

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Approved chip plants under the Semicon 2.0 programme will not be allowed to sell or mortgage any part of the project till the declaration of commercial production of the entire project, according to the scheme's guidelines issued on Thursday.

The government had notified Semicon 2.0 with an incentive outlay of ₹1.27 trillion.

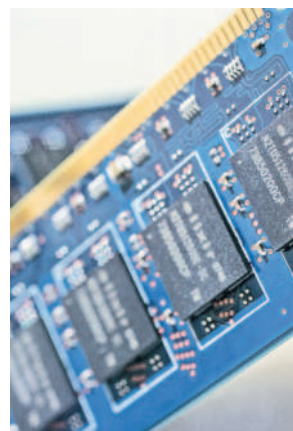
Till declaration of the commercial production of the entire project, the company shall not sell or dispose of the project assets or any part thereof or create thereon any mortgage, lien or charge by way of hypothecation or otherwise, except in the ordinary course of business, without prior approval of the nodal agency, the guidelines said.

The scheme has six pillars to boost the semiconductor ecosystem in the country com-

prising design, machines and materials, setting up more fabs, further strengthening the ATMP (assembly, testing, marking and packaging) and OSAT (outsourced semiconductor assembly and test) industry, research and development and talent development.

Out of the six pillars, guidelines have been published for three pillars—machines and materials, setting up more fabs, further strengthening the ATMP and OSAT industry.

Applicants under the machines and materials pillar can also receive produc-



The government issued guidelines for the Semicon 2.0 scheme on Thursday. BLOOMBERG

linked incentive (PLI) benefits under the scheme for domestic sourcing of components and subassemblies that are produced in India.

As per the guidelines, units receiving fiscal support under the scheme shall have to remain in commercial production for a period of at least three years from the date of commencement of commercial production of the entire project and provide an undertaking to the same.

Expenditure incurred on land and its development, temporary structures, site offices, temporary office space, and other temporary facilities created at the project site will not be considered as eligible capital expenditure or investment under the scheme.

As per the norms, cost incurred for technology transfer, interest during construction, and research and development will not be considered as part of capital expenditure or investment under Semicon 2.0.

The government had notified the Semicon 2.0 programme with an incentive outlay of ₹1.27 trillion

Brookfield to invest \$600 mn in ACME

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Private equity major Brookfield will invest up to \$600 million in ACME Cleantech Ventures to support the development of an advanced pipeline of ACME's green molecule projects in India and West Asia.

UK-based ACME Cleantech Ventures is a privately held entity within the ACME Group dedicated to the group's green molecules projects. The equity valuation for the structured deal is expected to be finalized by the end of 2026, ACME Group chairman Manoj Upadhyay told Mint.

Naval Saini, managing partner and head of energy for South Asia and the Middle East at Brookfield, said the investment marks Brookfield's entry into the green molecules sector in the region and combines its global scale and institutional capital with ACME's



Manoj Upadhyay, chairman, Acme Group.

operating capabilities.

Saini added, "Demand for green molecules continues to grow as companies and governments seek scalable solutions to decarbonize while strengthening energy security. ACME has an attractive project pipeline to capture the growing energy transition opportunity in India and the Middle East."

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New data centre clusters gain ground

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New data centre hubs such as Hyderabad are gaining ground in India, with established markets such as Chennai and Bengaluru expected to lose market share as newer regions add capacity by 2030.

Hyderabad and "other emerging markets" accounted for 10%, or 178 megawatts (MW), of India's operational data centre capacity as of 30 June, said real estate services firm Cushman & Wakefield's 16 September report. This is expected to rise nearly six-fold to 1.1 gigawatts (GW) by end-2030, accounting for 20% of the projected 5.65GW operational capacity and implying annualized growth of 58%.

Chennai, India's second-largest region for data centres, is projected to lose some of its market share and grow at a slower pace. It accounts for 12% or 215MW of active data centre capacity, according to the report. This is expected to rise



Companies have announced more than \$250 billion of data centre investments in India over the past 12 months.

REUTERS

to 582MW by end-2030, an annualized growth rate of 28%.

The shift comes as Indian states race to add capacity amid a data centre boom driven by artificial intelligence, cloud adoption and data-localization requirements. Conglomerates, standalone operators and big tech firms such as Google, Amazon and Microsoft have announced more than \$250 billion of investments in India over the past 12 months.

This has led to the emergence of new data centre hubs such as Dholera in Gujarat, and Visakhapatnam in Andhra Pradesh. While the report did not specify new regions, it mentioned that 232MW of new capacity will be added by these new regions in the next four years.

Visakhapatnam has seen a flurry of activity. Google, in partnership with Adani Group and Bharti Airtel, has announced a 1GW data centre

in the region, while Meta India is planning a 500MW facility with Sify Technologies Ltd.

"Hyderabad currently has greater momentum because of the scale of new capacity being planned. Large contiguous sites, prospective power availability and strong demand from hyperscalers and AI companies are supporting projects that are very large relative to Hyderabad's existing base," said Kashyap Kompella, analyst and founder of technology consultancy firm RPA2AI Research.

Vinish Bawa, partner at PwC, said Hyderabad benefits from a "strong technology and enterprise demand base, competitive operating economics and a growing hyperscaler ecosystem."

Government incentives have also supported the emergence of new hubs. On 1 February, the Centre announced a tax holiday until 2047 for foreign cloud operators to use Indian data centres. Most states, too, have brought out policies incentivizing data centre development.

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Yatharth operates 9 multi-specialty hospitals with around 2,800 beds and an announced capacity of about 3,250 beds. ISTOCKPHOTO

Advent to acquire 24.9% in Yatharth for ₹3,150 crore

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MUMBAI

Global private equity firm Advent International will invest ₹3,150 crore in Yatharth Hospital and Trauma Care Services Ltd for a 24.9% stake, the companies said in a statement on Thursday.

The Tyagi Family, the promoter of Yatharth Hospital, will remain its largest shareholder after the transaction, the statement added.

The company's shares surged nearly 9% to ₹1,070.45 following the news.

"This investment underscores Advent's deep and long-standing commitment to India's healthcare sector, which we believe is entering a decade of structural growth as access expands, quality improves, and consolidation advances," said Pankaj Patwari, managing director at Advent.

He added that the company will leverage Advent's global healthcare expertise and experience in investing in founded businesses to support and accelerate the company's growth. "Yatharth Hospitals has built one of North India's most differentiated healthcare

platforms—pairing clinical depth and disciplined execution, driven by the founding family's ambitious vision," said Atin Jain, director at Advent.

The company operates nine multi-specialty hospitals with around 2,800 beds and an overall announced capacity of about 3,250 beds. It operates in Noida, Greater Noida, Noida Extension, Greater Faridabad, New Delhi, Faridabad, and Gurugram in the National Capital Region, Jhansi-Orchha in Madhya Pradesh, and Agra.

Yatharth Hospitals has expanded its footprint through a combination of organic and inorganic growth, the statement said.

"Beyond capital, Advent brings deep healthcare expertise, global insights, and a strong value-creation mindset that will, we believe, help accelerate our next phase of growth," said Yatharth Tyagi, whole-time director, Yatharth Hospitals. "Together, we aim to expand our reach, strengthen our capabilities, and build one of India's leading healthcare networks."

With 17 offices across five continents, Advent oversees more than \$109 billion in assets under management as of June 2026 and has made 460 investments across 45 countries.

The Tyagi Family, the promoter of Yatharth Hospital, will remain its largest shareholder after the transaction

Orange Health bets on offline collection centres for growth

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Diagnostic and healthcare services startup Orange Health Labs is betting that its expansion into offline sample collection centres will drive growth in the short to medium term, even as it looks to enter radiology and wearables, according to a top company executive.

The digital-first company's offline push comes at a time when at-home healthcare, wellness and preventive care are fast becoming priorities in India. In June, the Bengaluru-based company raised \$30 million in its Series C funding round led by Iron Pillar. Existing investors Bertelsmann India Investments, Accel India, and General Catalyst also participated in the round.

"The 100 collection centres we have now, they contribute around 20% of the overall revenue," said co-founder Tarun Bhambra in an interview with Mint. "We do expect that to increase in the next 3-4 years."

Segments such as medicine delivery, therapeutics, specialized healthcare and elderly care have attracted growing interest from private-market investors. For instance, quick-commerce pharmacy platform Plaza raised \$15 million in July in its Series A round from Accel, Elevation Capital and Nexus Venture Partners, with existing investors All In Capital and Better Capital also participating in the round.

In August, private equity firm KKR announced that it would be acquiring the India operations of Sweden-based healthcare and diagnostics company Medicovert AB for



Tarun Bhambra, co-founder of Orange Health Labs.

\$1.4 billion.

Founded in 2020, Orange Health Labs started offline collection points in fiscal year 2024-25 (FY25), and currently operates around 100 of them. Of these, 45 are concentrated across Bengaluru, while the rest are spread across the

National Capital Region, Hyderabad and Mumbai.

"The plan now is to add around 80 more centres by the end of this fiscal," Bhambra said. "We're looking to add roughly 100 centres a year."

Since its founding, the company's revenue has risen at a

compound annual growth rate of 62%. Its revenue jumped to ₹143 crore in FY26, up from ₹88 crore in FY25, according to filings accessed through Tracxn. Losses also surged to ₹146 crore in the last fiscal, up from ₹87 crore in FY25.

Orange Health, which competes with the likes of Dr Lal PathLabs and Thyrocare Technologies, acknowledged that while it has begun setting up more physical collection centres, the expansion is capital-intensive. The company said it spends about three to four times as much as its competitors to set up and operate its own centres. Bhambra, however, declined to reveal the cost of setting up a sample col-

The Bengaluru-based company now plans to add around 80 more centres by the end of this fiscal

lection centre. "The collection centres take an average of 6-8 months to break even. The payback thereafter takes about two years to do."

Orange Health operates a hub-and-spoke model, with a central laboratory serving a 500-kilometre radius through 30 unmanned facilities where collected samples are dropped off and stored in refrigerated units before being transported to the lab.

Once enough samples have been collected, it transports them to the central laboratory for processing, where they are tested and analysed before reports are sent to customers.

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BSE Sensex			Nifty 50			Nifty 500			Nifty Next 50			Nifty 100			BSE 150 MidCap			BSE 250 SmallCap		
CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	
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PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN
74,336.45		74,182.62	23,217.60		23,195.25	22,532.00		22,518.75	70,368.60		70,374.40	24,282.95		24,264.30	16,505.40		16,492.88	7,043.79		7,037.55
HIGH		LOW	HIGH		LOW	HIGH		LOW	HIGH		LOW	HIGH		LOW	HIGH		LOW	HIGH		LOW
74,677.56		74,163.95	23,363.55		23,193.65	22,718.85		22,515.85	71,188.50		70,372.15	24,456.25		24,262.90	16,686.77		16,492.80	7,116.76		7,035.99

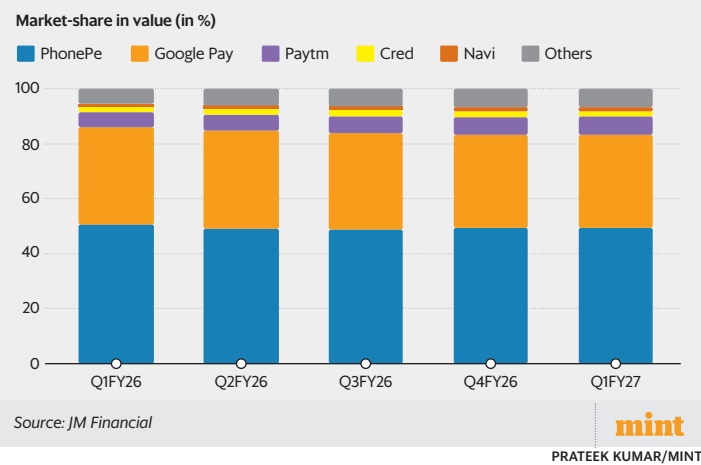
Paytm's UPI gain has caveats

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One 97 Communications Ltd's (Paytm) stock has gained nearly 2% since 15 September when the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) announced a new merchant discount rate (MDR) framework for UPI transactions. Investors celebrated the move from a largely subsidy-based model to a contractual and scalable revenue model. Effective 15 October, a 0.4% MDR will apply to eligible person-to-merchant (P2M) UPI transactions above ₹2,000, subject to a ₹300 cap. But the benefits accruing to Paytm will depend on how MDR is distributed, and how the eligible UPI pool shrinks with concessions and caps. The headline 0.4% is not Paytm's revenue, as MDR has to be shared across the ecosystem. NPCI has not yet specified the final distribution. JM Financial Institutional Securities assumes a 20% allocation to Paytm, translating into an 8-basis-point (bps) share of MDR, while Emkay

Inching up

Paytm has gained market share in recent quarters, but is still miles behind PhonePe and Google Pay.



Global Financial Services has pencilled in a 10-bps passthrough. P2M UPI transactions above ₹2,000 account for only 4% of transaction volumes, but they account for 67% by value. But the eligible UPI pool is expected to be much smaller. Here's why. Specified sectors such as railways, telecom, insurance, fuel,

pool is expected to be much smaller than 67%. JM Financial expects it at 20%, and Emkay at 35%.

Together, these two assumptions—passthrough MDR rate for Paytm and eligible UPI pool—can massively impact the actual benefits accruing to Paytm. Emkay, with its more optimistic assumptions, expects ₹1,120 crore in incremental MDR revenue in FY28 for Paytm, while JM's calculations show just ₹473 crore. The difference is a useful reminder that the headline 0.4% rate tells us little about what Paytm will actually earn.

Accounting for the loss of UPI incentive, JM expects ₹443 crore in net incremental MDR revenue, 100% of which is assumed to flow through into Ebitda. Paytm clocked ₹2,448 crore in operating revenue during Q1FY27, of which ₹1,384 crore came from payment services. Aided by a 31% year-on-year growth in merchant gross merchandise value to

₹7.1 trillion last quarter, revenue grew 28%, and Ebitda margin expanded from 1% to 8%.

MDR rates are comfortably below credit card economics, which carry 1.5-2.5% rates, according to JM Financial. This limits the possibility of high-ticket transactions being

migrated to cards. But competition is a big risk. While Paytm has gained market share from 5.6% in Q1FY26 to 6.7% in Q1FY27, it is still far behind PhonePe's 49.4% and Google Pay's 33.7%.

In a bid to capture a bigger share of the large-ticket flow, Paytm may be forced to pass some of their MDR share back to large merchants via discounts. For now, investors have no reason to crib, with the stock having gained 36% in 2026. It trades at 35x FY28 estimated enterprise value/Ebitda, per JM. The passthrough rate, shaped by competitive dynamics, and the size of the eligible UPI pool will drive investor sentiment from here.

MDR NUANCES

THE headline 0.4% is not Paytm's revenue, as MDR has to be shared across the ecosystem

CAPITAL market transactions attract concessional rates, and small merchants are exempt

Polycab stock may get relief in Q2 amid rising competition

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Polycab India Ltd is feeling the heat from Ultra-Tech Cement Ltd's entry into wires and cables (W&C), with its shares down 7% since the latter launched Ultravolt on 3 September. Investors are worried about what rising competition could mean for Polycab's 30-31% share of the organized market (in FY26) and its margins, though the immediate business impact may be limited.

Ultravolt aims to be the second largest player in wires

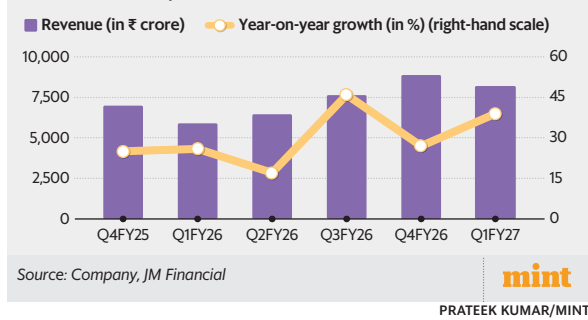
by capacity, backed by an investment of ₹1,800 crore.

UltraTech's initial push appears focused on wires, while cables, where entry barriers are higher, make a chunk of Polycab's mix. That offers some insulation for now, even as the Street keeps a close watch on Ultravolt's pricing and expansion.

"Power transmission and industrial cables may require 2-4 years for pre-qualification whereas wire sales (B2C) may not counter material entry barriers," said Jefferies India analysts, adding, "In this context, we foresee lower competitive risk for Polycab

Upbeat expectations

Polycab's revenue growth was robust in Q1FY27, and the trend is likely to continue in Q2.



(cables is 70-75% of its mix)." For now, Polycab's Q2FY27 results are set to benefit from strong copper prices, a trend

in Q2; quarter-end surge in copper which could drive pre-buying in anticipation of price hikes and result in slightly higher volume growth QoQ," said JM Financial Institutional Securities' analysts on 9 September. They said that the margin could trend flat to slightly higher sequentially, but lower year-on-year (y-o-y).

Polycab's consolidated revenue rose 39% y-o-y in Q1FY27 to ₹8,210 crore. The W&C business contributed 87% of Q1 revenues, followed by 9.2% from fast-moving electrical goods (FMEG) and the rest from engineering,

procurement and construction (EPC) vertical. However, W&C volume growth was in the low-to-mid-single-digit, which was a bit of a sore spot. Overall, Ebitda margin fell 70 basis points to 13.8%, partly due to weak exports. This means a recovery in exports in future, should support margin. Factoring recent losses, Polycab's shares have gained 11% over the last year. The stock trades at almost 38 times estimated FY27 earnings, as per Bloomberg consensus. Better-than-expected Q2 results, especially on the volume growth front, may bring cheer.

The company is currently focused on meeting internal revenue and profitability milestones

VVDN Technologies is weighing a ₹4,000-5,000 crore

fundraise through an initial public offering (IPO), with the electronics manufacturing services company expected to begin formal pitches to investment banks over the next quarter, according to four people aware of the development. The proposed IPO is likely to comprise a mix of fresh capital and an offer for sale (OFS), the people said on the condition of anonymity. "The company has already held informal discussions with some investment banks, with formal pitches expected over the coming quarter, following which it will appoint bankers," one of the persons quoted above said.

"The company is currently focused on meeting internal revenue and profitability milestones, and details around the



The proposed IPO is likely to comprise a mix of fresh capital and an OFS. ISTOCKPHOTO

have tapped public markets via secondary transactions. VVDN Technologies declined to comment.

VVDN has raised over \$129 million in multiple private funding rounds since its inception in 2007, according to data firm Tracxn. As of June 2024, the firm was valued at \$274 million. The company has two major investors, Motilal Oswal Private Equity and LV Holdings Private Family company's valuation and the eventual IPO structure are yet to be finalized," a second person quoted above added. Valuation discovery is still underway as the company firms up its growth plans, the person said.

The potential listing comes as India's public-market fundraising window has opened up, with IPOs, qualified institutional placements and block deals picking up. Several new-age companies, including Symbiotec Pharma-lab, Milky Mist, Shiprocket, Gaja Capital and Purple Style Labs, have listed in the past two months, while companies such as Billionbrains Garage Ventures, Physicswallah, Rubicon Research, Welspun Corp. and Viyash Scientific

manufacturing electronic solutions for customers. Within telecom manufacturing, it competes with HFCL Ltd and Dixon Technologies, while its rivals in electronics contract manufacturing include Foxconn and Jabil.

VVDN's revenue almost doubled to ₹3,864.6 crore in FY25 from ₹2,172.3 crore in FY24, while net profit was largely flat at ₹38.6 crore.

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For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

DII inflows fall short after US Fed hikes rate

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Domestic institutions are out buying foreign sellers, but Indian stocks are still sliding. With the US Federal Reserve raising interest rates for the first time in over three years—a move that would typically draw foreign money away from emerging markets—the question is: how much protection can domestic money provide?

History shows why domestic buying offers reassurance, but little certainty about market direction.

A Mint analysis of Bloomberg data across 21 Fed rate-hike months between December 2015 and September 2026 found that domestic institutional investors (DIIs) bought in all 10 months when foreign investors sold. Nifty, nevertheless, fell in seven of them.

That does not mean domestic support failed. The index could have fallen further without it. But the purchases alone were insufficient to keep the market in the positive zone.

As of 16 September, DIIs had bought a net ₹31,581 crore of equities during the month, comfortably exceeding foreign portfolio investor (FPI) withdrawals of ₹17,222 crore. Yet the Nifty 50 was down 3.6% since end August. The Fed's 25-basis-point rate hike, taking the benchmark to 3.75-4.00%, arrived after Indian markets closed. September data, therefore, shows the backdrop to the decision, rather than the market's response to it.

"Domestic buying can cushion

Domestic support

DII buying outpaces ₹17,222 crore FPI outflows in September.

Across the 21 historical Fed rate-hike months, December 2015–September 2026

Indicator	Number of months	Share of months (in %)
Nifty gained	9	42.9
Nifty declined	12	57.1
FPIs bought net	10	47.6
FPIs sold net	11	52.4
DIIs bought net	17	81.0
DIIs sold net	4	19.0

FPI: foreign portfolio investor. DII: domestic institutional investor
Historical figures cover full rate-hike months. September 2026 data is through 16 September, before the Fed announcement.

Source: Mint analysis, Bloomberg

SATISH KUMAR/MINT

ion a fall, but prices can still slip as buyers may only step in at lower levels," said Prasenjit Paul, fund manager at I29 Wealth and head of research at Paul Asset.

The events of September 2018 illustrate the limits. DIIs poured in ₹12,504 crore, exceeding foreign withdrawals of ₹10,825 crore, but Nifty slipped 6.4%, steepest among the hike-months studied.

Part of it lies beneath the aggregate numbers: domestic buyers and foreign sellers typically may not be trading the same stocks at the same time. "The divergence comes down to where the money is landing, not just how much," said Rajesh Singla, chief executive and fund manager at Alpha AMC. He said foreign selling during periods of risk aversion can

concentrate in heavyweight stocks, while domestic buys are staggered and spread across. Buying elsewhere may, therefore, do little to offset pressure on shares that exert the greatest influence on Nifty.

Ashwini Shami, president and chief portfolio manager at OmniScience Capital, pointed to a similar mismatch. Mutual funds have favoured mid- and small-cap equities, he said, adding that domestic funds were net sellers of large-caps in the past two months. That leaves some large companies exposed to selling from both sets, even as aggregate DII flows stay positive.

The two groups also respond to different influences. Domestic institutions draw support from recurring savings and fund allocations, while foreign

ones respond to global rates, bond yields and shifts in risk appetite, Shami said.

For domestic buying to provide stronger support, Singla argued, attractive valuations would need to draw larger lump-sum allocations, with more money put in large-cap stocks facing foreign selling.

The historical record also challenges the view that a Fed hike necessarily spells trouble for Indian equities. As a first reaction, Nifty 50 closed 0.2% higher on Thursday at 23,270.6 after the overnight hike.

Across the 21 rate-hike months studied, Nifty rose in nine and fell in 12. Foreign investors were net buyers in 10 months and net sellers in 11, while domestic institutions bought in 17. The tally includes September's partial-month figures through 16 September, before the Fed announcement. US Fed began its post-pandemic tightening in March 2022, after keeping rates near zero. It then delivered 11 hikes through July 2023. Over those hike months, Nifty rose in six and declined in five.

Even identical rate hikes showed sharply different outcomes. In June 2022, a 75-bps hike saw the Nifty slip 4.8%. Foreign investors withdrew ₹50,203 crore, while domestic bought ₹46,599 crore. The next month, another 75-bps hike coincided with an 8.7% rally, the strongest in the sample. Foreign investors turned buyers, pouring ₹4,989 crore, alongside domestic purchases of ₹11,658 crore.

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Mutual funds shun big CAS trades

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Indian mutual funds (MFs) are increasing their participation in the stock market's new closing auction—but mostly in trades too small to matter, several fund managers told Mint, wary of the sharp price swings that can occur within the 15-minute window. Introduced on 3 August, the Closing Auction Session (CAS) has struggled to attract sustained participation despite a gradual increase in trading activity. Mutual funds are limiting the trades they route via the auction, preferring transactions where an adverse execution price would have a limited impact on a scheme's net asset value (NAV).

The concern for mutual funds isn't whether the closing auction attracts enough activity—it's whether it can deliver a predictable price for large orders. A sharp swing during the 15-minute window could leave a fund buying or selling well off the prevailing market price, denting a scheme's NAV and leaving the fund manager to explain the trade to trustees. And the new system has already seen several instances of sharp price swings in the closing minutes.

"Mutual funds are avoiding CAS for trades that are substantial in value and volume, and hence important to the fund house. Trades that are not very important and do not impact P&L are being sent to CAS. This is largely because of the unexpected price swings and uncertainty during CAS,"



Trades that are not very important and do not impact P&L are being sent to CAS. ISTOCKPHOTO

said a mutual fund executive, requesting anonymity.

The system's early months have shown how volatile that price can be: on the very first day, the Nifty jumped nearly 200 points in the closing minutes while the Sensex barely moved. On 3 September, the Sensex plunged about 2,100 points within minutes during the auction on a weekly expiry day, before recovering most of the fall to close 417 points lower.

Under the new framework, the regulator has shifted the determination of the closing price from the earlier volume-weighted average price (VWAP) mechanism to an auction-based system. CAS covers 213 stocks available for derivatives trading. Continuous trading in these stocks ends at 3:15pm, followed by the auction, during which a

single equilibrium price is set by matching the maximum number of buy and sell orders.

The caution persists despite efforts by the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) to increase participation in the segment. The market regulator has asked mutual funds to

put through more trades in CAS, three executives said.

As a result, mutual fund participation in CAS had risen to nearly 25% of total volumes by mid-August, from about 5% when the framework was introduced, Sebi chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey said on 12 August.

Mint reported on 16 September that Sebi had also allowed arbitrage funds to maintain 1% of their assets under management (AUM) as unhedged positions, with the aim of improving their partici-

pation in CAS. Arbitrage funds seek to profit from price differences in the same security across the cash and futures markets.

Overall activity, however, has been uneven. Data from the National Stock Exchange shows that between 3 August and 15 September, closing-auction trading volumes increased 21.6% to 31.5 million trades, while transaction value rose 37.2% to ₹1,751.46 crore.

Participation was weak through most of August. Trading volumes during the closing session fell 24.3%, from 25.8 million on 3 August to 19.6 million on 28 August. Transaction value declined 26%, from ₹1,276.4 crore to ₹944.94 crore.

Participation recovered towards the end of the month following the MSCI index rebalancing on 31 August.

Dhirendra Kumar, founder of Value Research, said the reluctance was understandable from a fund manager's perspective. "Picture the dealer. Work an order through the day and he can point to VWAP. Put the same size into a 15-minute window and he has no cover. A print 3% off the market is his to explain to the trustees. Nothing rewards him for using the auction. So, he stays out. That is not timidity. That is sense."

For mutual funds, uncertainty around the final price remains a key concern because they trade on behalf of investors and must account for the impact of transactions on a scheme's NAV.

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Noel floats SP Group's offer

SP Group has offered to sell up to a 3% stake back to Tata Sons for ₹25,000 crore as an alternative to public listing

Varun Sood & Satish John
BENGALURU/MUMBAI

Tata Trusts chair Noel Tata presented a Shapoorji Pallonji (SP) Group proposal to the Tata Sons board on Thursday, wherein the minority investor offered to sell up to a 3% stake back to the holding company for ₹25,000 crore.

According to an executive close to the matter, SP Group has offered this as an alternative to making Tata Sons a publicly listed company—something the minority investor has demanded for long—and comes after the Reserve Bank of India ordered it to go public on Friday.

The Tata Sons board convened at the meeting room on the fourth floor of Bombay House at 10.30am, primarily to discuss two thorny issues: the course of action after the RBI order, and the tenure of its current chair N. Chandrasekaran. Tata presented the SP offer in the afternoon, the executive said on the condition of anonymity.

SP Group made this offer in a letter sent last week to Farokh Subedar, an aide to Tata, the executive said. Subedar, along with Ankur Verma, group chief strategy officer at Tata Sons, and a senior SP Group representative, forms a panel to resolve issues among Tata Sons, Tata Trusts and SP Group. The panel is believed to have met at least twice in the last 15 months but made little progress.

In its letter, SP Group asked for ₹25,000 crore for 2-3% of Tata Sons shares, which values the holding firm at ₹8.3 trillion at this price. SP Group expects this money over 18 months, the executive said.

The Tata group has not conducted any independent valuation exercise for Tata Sons, which owns stakes in 26 listed firms and also runs privately



Noel Tata presented SP Group's proposal to Tata Sons board.

held businesses. The executive dismissed concerns that SP Group might withdraw its offer, since it was made before the 11 September RBI order. He said a public listing would value Tata Sons at 30-35% below the total

everything it owns.

"Any planned IPO is an uncertain, complex and slow process. Also, we don't know how the value is decided or if there is a discount when Tata Sons goes public. So, you could say

buyout would be carried out in two tranches over an 18-month period. Tata Sons would initiate a selective capital reduction process through the National Company Law Tribunal. Valuation of Tata Shares would be done as per Income-tax fair value," said Tata Trusts.

But does Tata Sons have money to close this deal? The group executive said it earns about ₹30,000 crore a year from dividends, share buyback and fund from companies going public, and hence, paying this amount won't be an issue.

Noel, who became chair of Tata Trusts in October 2024, two days after his half-brother Ratan Tata died on 9th, faced many challenges, including helping SP Group, which owns 18.38% and is the biggest minor-

ity investor in Tata Sons, with an exit. SP Group's entire stake is pledged to creditors as the debt-heavy infrastructure and construction company must repay ₹3,500 crore by the end of September.

Across SP Group's promoter and operating entities, the total debt is estimated at around ₹60,000 crore, according to multiple media reports. Some Tata group executives believe that RBI's order to Tata Sons to take "immediate" action shows it may have considered the potential impact of risk to the system if group defaulted on debt.

Despite holding a substantial minority stake in Tata Sons, SP Group is unable to cash out and settle its crushing debt. This is because following the ouster of SP Group's Cyrus Mistry as Tata Sons chairman in 2016, it converted to a private limited company, where the board, with Tata Trusts holding wide-ranging powers, can block share transfers.

SP Group first became a shareholder of Tata Sons in 1965, under patriarch Shapoorji Pallonji Mistry, and over the next three decades, kept buying shares until its ownership reached 18.38%. Mistry rarely interfered in the affairs of Tata Sons, and his quiet, assured manner gave him power inside the House of Tata, earning him the moniker the Phantom of Bombay House.

Things between Tata and SP Group took an ugly turn after Pallonji Mistry's younger son, Cyrus Mistry, was sacked as Tata Sons chairman by Ratan Tata in October 2016, prompting a bitter legal fight over what the minority investor alleged was wrongful termination. The Supreme Court finally ruled in March 2021 that Cyrus's sacking was lawful.

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EXPERT
VIEW

NITIN POTDAR

Respond to this column at
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SETTLE THE MATTER AT BOMBAY HOUSE, NOT THE BOMBAY HC



Bombay House, the headquarters of Tata Sons, in Mumbai. MINT

On 17 September, the Tata Sons board approved a third five-year term for N. Chandrasekaran as executive chairman. For a group that has long set India's standard for corporate governance, the decision is hard to understand. It was taken in haste, and the Group's reputation will pay the price.

My concern is not the chairman's ability. It is how the board of India's largest industrial group has conducted itself.

What changed?

On 12 August, the chairman publicly said he would not seek another term. Five weeks later, the board has reappointed him. Shareholders, employees and the public have not been told what changed.

Nobody makes such a statement casually. A prudent board would have found out the reasons and addressed them before deciding. This board did the opposite.

The directors knew what would follow. They knew the Chairman of Tata Trusts was opposed. They knew the decision would be challenged and debated publicly for months. Knowing all this, can anyone say they acted prudently?

The duty under Section 166

Every director in India is bound by Section 166 of the Companies Act. A director must act in accordance with the company's Articles. A director must also act in good faith, for the benefit of the members as a whole, and in the best interests of the company, its employees, its shareholders and the community.

Test this decision against that standard. It was taken without the vote the Articles require. It was taken over the objection of the majority shareholder's representative. It invites litigation, unsettles employees and investors, and hurts a name the public trusts.

Prima facie, the directors who approved it have not met the duties that Section 166 places on them. Acting in a hurry is the smaller charge.

What the Articles say

Tata Sons' Articles require that board decisions carry the affirmative vote of a majority of the directors nominated by the Tata Trusts. With two Trust nominees on the board, both must agree. This is how the Trusts, which own about two-thirds of the company, protect the Group.

By all reports, Noel Tata voted against the proposal. If so, the resolution failed the test set by the Articles. On first principles, how could the board go ahead?

Even the rule that executives retire at 65, which Ratan Tata himself followed in 2002, was waived only with the Trusts' support. That support is no longer there.

What the board should have done

The answer was simple. Defer the decision. Sit down with the Trusts. Understand what led to the August statement. Resolve differences quietly, the Tata way. With the current term running until February 2027, there was no hurry.

Instead, an internal difference has become a public dispute. A governance model admired for decades is now in question, and the damage will take time to repair.

The directors who voted for this resolution owe the Group, and India Inc., an explanation. I hope good counsel prevails, and this is settled at Bombay House, not the Bombay High Court.

Nitin Potdar is a senior corporate & M&A lawyer.

RBI clarifies Tata Sons' debt-free status can't avert listing

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The Reserve Bank of India's (RBI's) latest frequently asked questions (FAQs) on non-banking financial companies (NBFCs) may have further weakened Tata Trusts' efforts to keep Tata Sons private, clarifying rules that underpin the central bank's decision to reject the holding company's application to surrender its regulatory registration and avoid a stock-market listing.

Tata Sons is registered with RBI as a "core investment company" (CIC)—a category for holding companies that mainly invest in their own group's businesses. Large CICs, known as "upper-layer" NBFCs, are required to list on

the stock exchange. Tata Sons had asked RBI to let it exit this category entirely, arguing that since it had repaid more than ₹20,000 crore in debt and was now debt-free, it no longer needed to be regulated this way. RBI rejected that request last week—and the new FAQs explain why.

RBI has clarified that being debt-free isn't enough to escape the rules. What actually matters is access to "public funds", a term far broader than a company's own direct borrowings. Public funds, RBI said, include money raised through banks, inter-corporate deposits, commercial paper and debentures—and, crucially, funds accessed indirectly through group and associate firms. So even though Tata Sons itself carries no debt, its group companies' access to



RBI's latest FAQs clarify the central bank's stance. MINT

bank financing and market funding still counts against it. Listed Tata firms, including Tata Steel Ltd, Tata Chemicals Ltd and Tata Power Co. Ltd, own stakes in it, making it an indirect recipient of public funds under RBI's definition. "Public funds are not the

same as public deposits," RBI said. The FAQ also spells out the criteria for a CIC. To qualify as CIC in the first place, a company must invest at least 90% of its net assets in group firms, with 60% of that in equity shares. It must clear what's called the 50:50 principal business test, under which financial assets must account for more than 50% of total assets and income from financial assets must exceed 50% of gross income.

RBI's latest clarification leaves Tata Sons with little room to rely on its debt-free status as a basis for deregistration. Instead, the company remains subject to the rules

applicable to an upper-layer NBFC, including enhanced regulatory requirements.

For the Tata group, the issue is significant because Tata Sons is the holding company of major listed and unlisted businesses across

technology, automobiles, steel, power and financial services. The company has sought to remain privately held, but RBI's rejection of its deregistration application and

the latest FAQs have reinforced the regulatory pressure it faces.

The FAQs comes at a significant moment for Tata Sons, with the company's board on Thursday approving a fresh five-year term for N. Chandrasekaran as executive chair-

man. His current term is due to end on 20 February 2027, according to a statement from Tata Sons. The decision reverses Chandrasekaran's position last month that he would not seek another term.

The reappointment comes against the backdrop of a debate over the future leadership and structure of Tata Sons. Tata Trusts chairman Noel Tata had favoured beginning the process of finding a successor after Chandrasekaran's decision to step down.

The fresh five-year term means Chandrasekaran is likely to continue leading Tata Sons as it navigates regulatory requirements applicable to an upper-layer NBFC, including the implications of a potential listing. He has been chairman since 2017 and was previously given a second five-year term.

Noel to veto IPO, says Chandra can't reverse exit plan

Varun Sood & Satish John
BENGALURU/MUMBAI

Tata Trusts chairman Noel Tata stood firm at the Tata Sons board meeting but was outvoted when the board decided to follow the RBI order to list its shares on the stock exchanges and extend the chairman's term.

Noel Tata arrived with a two-page note to address a doubtful board of directors. Expecting disagreement and interruptions, he decided to submit his written statement to be included in the meeting records.

Tata's main concerns about the company's structure, its obligations to the regulator, and the leadership of Tata Sons and the succession to the chair were the crux of his argument. "They have arrived together. They are not, however, of the same kind, and they do not answer one another."

Noel Tata referred to Chandrasekaran's decision not to offer himself for reappointment.

"On 12 August 2026, the chairman (Chandrasekaran) wrote to this board stating that he would not offer himself for a



Tata Sons board backed steps to comply with RBI's listing order and extend N. Chandrasekaran's term. PTI

further term upon the conclusion of his present tenure on 20 February 2027. That was his own decision. It was freely taken and clearly expressed. It was not sought from him by this Board, it was not the subject of any resolution of this Board, and it was not the outcome of any process of review," he said.

He added that the letter was thereafter placed in the public domain without prior deliberation with shareholders, particularly the Tata Trusts, which hold approximately 66% of equity.

"I raise this not by way of complaint, and I accept that a chairman is entitled to speak of his own intentions. I raise it because a communication of that character, once public, has consequences which this board cannot afterwards undo. The group's employees, its lenders, its counterparties and the market have all proceeded upon it. So, has the majority shareholder. The page has turned."

Tata also suggested Tata Sons ask the Reserve Bank of India for at least three years to meet the requirements if a listing is eventually necessary. His

statement challenged Tata Sons' claim that its board had decided to "start steps to follow the applicable RBI guidelines."

"If I am forced to vote, then I would have no option but to veto any such decision to list," he told the board, according to a statement later released by Tata Trusts. "A listing will destroy its character and strike at the heart of this principle," Tata said.

"Turning to the 11 September 2026 communication received from the Reserve Bank of India, it is important to first understand precisely what this communication says. It records that the company's request for voluntary surrender of its certificate of registration cannot be accepted to, and it advises the company to take necessary actions to ensure full compliance, immediately, with the guidelines and instructions applicable to a nonbanking financial company in the upper layer. It does not mention listing," Tata said.

He said the Tata Sons board,

led by the late Ratan Tata, had "unanimously" agreed that the company would stay "unlisted."

"The board should therefore seek a period of not less than three years from the date of the communication (i.e. till September 2029) and should state plainly why such a period is necessary rather than merely comply," said Tata.

Tata said the RBI's 11 September decision came "without warning" and asked management to update directors on the options it had considered. He also suggested that Tata Sons file a Right to Information request with the RBI for the full file and notes behind the decision.

He said chairman Chandrasekaran had assured the board in September 2025 and February 2026 that the company was taking all necessary steps to keep it private. "Today's meeting outcome will validate if that statement was sincerely given," he said.

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Chandrasekaran and the five directors on Tata Sons board

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The Tata Sons board has six members, including chairperson Natarajan Chandrasekaran and chief financial officer Saurabh Agrawal. Here is the full lineup: **Noel Tata:** The reticent Tata has long stayed on the sidelines. The economics graduate from the University of Sussex proved his business chops by turning Trent into one of the most valuable fashion retailers in the country. However, the 69-year-old is yet to be tested as the leader of a large conglomerate.

N Chandrasekaran: The Tata Group lifer started his career as a trainee programmer at Tata Consultancy Services in 1987. He rose through the ranks to lead the company as its CEO from 2009 to 2017. His performance at TCS earned him an invitation to the Tata Sons board of directors in October 2016. Backed by Ratan Tata to lead the Tata Group, he was selected as the



Tata Sons board comprises six members. BLOOMBERG

Tata Sons chairman by a committee in January 2017.

Venu Srinivasan: The chairman-emeritus of TVS Motor Co. was a friend of Ratan Tata. The two industrialists developed a relationship as leaders of Indian industry and their association with the Warwick Manufacturing Group. Srinivasan is known for his staunch belief in investments in research and development and in quality management.

Saurabh Agrawal: Chandrasekaran had hand-picked Agrawal to lead the finance

function at Tata Sons. He holds a bachelor's degree in chemical engineering from the University of Roorkee and a post graduate diploma in management from the Indian Institute of Management, Calcutta. He had a successful career as an investment banker. Agrawal joined Tata Sons in June 2017.

Anita George: A champion of sustainable finance, George has held senior positions at prestigious institutions like Canada's Caisse de Dépôt et Placement du Québec, the World Bank, and International Finance Corp. She joined the Tata Sons board in July 2022.

Harish Manwani: A former global chief operating officer for Unilever and the former chairman of HUL, Manwani joined as an independent director in May 2018. Post his retirement from Unilever, he joined Blackstone as an executive advisor in 2015. He holds a B.Sc. (Honors) degree from Bombay University and a Master's degree in Management Studies from Jamnalal Bajaj Institute of Management Studies.

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ALL YOU NEED TO KNOW CHINA WATCH

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Training hubs in Xinjiang help build digital bridges

By MA SI and MAO WEIHUA

In the desert near Karamay in Xinjiang Uygur autonomous region, Northwest China, where oil derricks have long punctuated the skyline, another kind of resource is quietly taking root. It is not crude oil that now flows from this rugged land, but data, knowledge and a growing web of human connections that stretch from Central Asia to the shores of the Indian Ocean.

The catalyst for the change is the "Tree of SCO", a digital technology training initiative incubated under the China-Shanghai Cooperation Organisation Big Data Cooperation Centre.

Since the programme's inception in May 2023 it has hosted training sessions for more than 1,000 participants from SCO member states, including Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Russia and Uzbekistan. Participants have included government officials, research experts and corporate leaders.

They are active contributors. The curriculum is deliberately hands-on. Rather than sitting through passive lectures, trainees enter industrial parks, walk into company data centres, deploy cloud desktops, configure cloud hosts and engage in real-time cybersecurity attack-and-defense drills.

The course content focuses on frontier fields such as computing power networks, artificial intelligence and the low-altitude economy. According to the organisers of the training sessions, half of the instructors come from top universities, and the other half are technical experts from leading companies, ensuring that what is taught is grounded in both theory and real-world practice.

Over the past three years, Symbat Ramazanov, an entrepreneur and adviser on international cooperation to the regional government of East Kazakhstan, said he has visited Karamay 10 times. These

visits included organising delegations from his region to attend the programme, during which participants discussed efficient practices and visited companies and other entities.

"China has demonstrated significant advantages in digital transformation," he said. "Technology companies in my region have signed memorandums of understanding with Chinese peer firms in fields including healthcare, education and tourism. Collaboration with China has yielded tangible projects that are executed swiftly, and ... flexibly prepared for introduction."

Wang Zhiqin, vice-president of the China Academy of Information and Communications Technology, said: "Digital talent training is a vital component of SCO digital economy cooperation. Strengthening such training not only aligns with the SCO theme, but also solidifies the human foundation for deeper regional technological integration and digital development."

T.R. Midhun, deputy secretary-general of the SCO, said digital cooperation within the organisation has entered a critical phase demanding substantial breakthroughs. He called for greater emphasis on converting ideas into tangible results.

At the heart of this strategy is clear government support. Xiong Jijun, China's vice-minister of industry and information technology, said the country is committed to building an open, inclusive and shared global digital ecosystem through collaboration with SCO members.

"Relying on the China-Shanghai Cooperation Organisation Big Data Cooperation Centre, we will continue to train digital technology talent for SCO countries, facilitate digital transformation through mutual learning and build a bridge for win-win cooperation in the digital domain."



A cloud service data centre in the Cloud Computing Industrial Park, Karamay, Xinjiang Uygur autonomous region.

JIA TIANYONG / CHINA NEWS SERVICE



Robots for export to Malaysia in action at Chery International Park in Wuhu, Anhui province, on July 30. XIAO BENXIANG / FOR CHINA DAILY

Robots join trade drive with AI and new drugs

Electric cars, batteries and solar cells take backseat as exports take on new contours.

Ren Qi reports

Driven by a leap in independent innovation, the value of China's foreign trade was a record high 25 trillion yuan (\$3.72 trillion) in the first six months of the year, propelled by orders for robots, artificial intelligence and innovative drugs.

The evolution of China's export portfolio tells a compelling story of continuous industrial upgrading. Decades ago, clothing, furniture and home appliances dominated shipments, later replaced by shiploads of new energy vehicles, lithium-ion batteries and solar cells.

Chen Yutao, deputy director of the standard committee of the China Enterprise Confederation under the State-owned Assets Supervision and Administration Commission, said this evolution is a demonstration of the shift from advanced manufacturing to an even more comprehensive innovation ecosystem.

This year, with the accelerated development of AI, China has exported algorithms, computing power and digital solutions, and exports of AI hardware have grown sharply. Amid the global AI boom, huge amounts of data are transmitted between data centres, with facilities that increasingly rely on advanced optical communication networks.

In a production plant of Yangtze Optical Fibre and Cable Joint Stock Ltd Co in Optics Valley of Wuhan, Hubei province, production lines are operating at full capacity.

"Special optical fibres used for AI intelligent computing centres are now in short supply because of the explosive growth of data centres," said Wen Xiaojiang, general manager of YOFC's International Company.

Securing these orders is the result of years of technological accumulation. Since China's first practical optical fibre was born in Wuhan in the 1970s, Optics Valley has built



A participant learns about fibre-optic products at the booth of Yangtze Optical Fibre and Cable Joint Stock Ltd Co in Beijing on July 8.

LI XIN / XINHUA

an industrial cluster encompassing materials, devices and equipment. Today more than 800 AI companies are located in the area, with the annual output of the optoelectronic information industry surpassing 660 billion yuan.

The rise of robots, artificial intelligence and innovative drugs industries is strongly supported by China's robust high-end manufacturing and industrial clusters. Backed by a complete industrial ecology, Chinese robotics has become a frontrunner in the global wave of intelligence. At a robotics company in the Zhongguancun technology hub in Beijing, a head of overseas business conducts a video call with a Thai agent, promptly finetuning technical solutions to customise the most suitable products.

Founded in 2014, the company has drawn on years of technological know-how to expand globally. Its robots are now deployed in more than 40,000 hotels, more than 200 medical institutions and numerous factories in more than 20 countries.

In the first half of the year, 12.9 million robots, with a total value of 24.9 billion yuan, were exported from China to more than 160 countries and regions. Chinese companies, relying on abundant application scenarios and comprehensive supply chains, are providing smarter, cost-effective robots worldwide.

While AI and robotics exports primarily involve products and system-based services, the pharmaceutical industry is increasingly characterised by the export of patents and foundational research capabilities. In the first half of the year 31 domestically produced innovative drugs were approved for market launch nationwide.

Two originated from the medicine port in Hangzhou's Qiantang New Area, a compact hub that has gathered over 300 innovative pharmaceutical companies over the past 10 years. Notably, even before achieving commercial sales, some pharmaceutical companies have already generated overseas revenue through drug patent licensing.

Qian Lili, chairwoman of I-Mab Biopharma, said that 10 years ago Chinese firms had to wait for products to be marketed abroad before marketing them in China.

"Currently, we are out-licensing the rights of our self-developed products to overseas companies."

This year I-Mab Biopharma completed a business development transaction with the US company Biogen for a self-developed anti-CD38 monoclonal antibody, with a deal valued at \$850 million and an upfront payment of \$100 million. Such deals allow Chinese pharmaceutical companies to jointly advance research and development and sales with global partners, becoming a crucial pathway to enter the international market.

In the first half of the year, China's out-licensing transactions for innovative drugs were put at \$100 billion, a record high, making the industry's scale the world's second largest.

The consensus is that robots, AI and innovative drugs represent a new systemic capability cultivated through decades of exploration in Chinese manufacturing, marking a qualitative upgrade of China's industrial logic heading into the 15th Five-Year Plan period (2026-30).

Hao Jianbin, a researcher at the Shanghai University of Finance and Economics, pointed out this transition embodies a comprehensive iteration of China's comparative advantages in foreign trade.

Hao said the growth driver has shifted from supply chain scale to original innovation, competing on foundational technology. Furthermore, patterns have diversified from physical goods to a composite trade of goods and knowledge-centric services, raising the ceiling of foreign trade added value. China's position in the global division of labour is also moving upward, directly targeting global frontier sectors.

Bigger role envisaged for services in GDP

By ZHANG CHENXU and LI JIAYING

Services consumption is poised to assume a more important role in driving China's economic growth this year, officials and experts said, pointing to a structural shift in domestic demand, with services accounting for a growing share of household spending.

As external uncertainties continue to escalate, policymakers are doubling down on efforts to build on the shift and steer the economy towards a more consumption-led growth model, they added.

"Consumers tend to spend more frequently on services, and such spending generates strong

spillover effects," said Wang Guanhua, spokesman for the National Bureau of Statistics. "Expanding services consumption will therefore remain a major engine of overall consumption growth."

The value of service retail sales rose 5 per cent in the first seven months of the year compared with the corresponding period last year, the bureau said, 3.9 percentage points more than retail sales of goods.

Luo Zhiheng, chief economist of the financial services firm Yuekai Securities, said the figures point to a continued upgrade in China's consumption mix, with services becoming an increasingly important source of growth.

Unlike goods, services are less constrained by diminishing marginal utility and thus offer greater room for spending growth, Luo said.

Tourism has stood out, with retail sales of tourism-related consulting and rental services rising 11 per cent in the first seven months compared with the corresponding period last year, the statistics bureau said.

The US financial services company Morgan Stanley has forecast that China's tourism revenue will be worth 12 trillion yuan (\$1.78 trillion) by 2030, with tourism's share of GDP projected to rise to about 6.7 per cent by then, from 4.8 per cent in 2024.

Yuan Haixia, dean of the research institute of China Chengxin Interna-



Tourists visit a night market in Nanning, South China's Guangxi Zhuang autonomous region, enjoying sightseeing and local delicacies on July 29.

LU BOAN / XINHUA

tional Credit Rating, said the experience of developed economies shows that consumption typically becomes the main engine of growth once a country enters the ranks of high-income economies.

Echoing this view, Xiong Yuan,

chief economist of Guosheng Securities, said the shift towards services still has considerable growth potential, with the share of per capita spending on services in total consumption spending rising 0.2 percentage point in the first half

of the year compared with the corresponding period last year.

At a meeting convened by China's top leadership in late July a high premium was placed on efforts to expand the supply of quality goods and services, and to tap the potential of services consumption. The meeting of the Political Bureau of the Communist Party of China Central Committee also called for improving fiscal-financial coordination to bolster domestic demand.

Other measures are in the pipeline. "We are working on additional fiscal-financial coordination measures, which will be rolled out in the second half," Liao Min, China's vice-minister of finance, said in August.

In addition to efforts to improve the supply of services, faster growth in household disposable incomes will be key to sustaining the expansion in services consumption, experts said.

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China's porcelain hub is a global kiln



Artists, designers and creators flock to the city honoured with a World Heritage listing.
Sun Meng reports

Pinar Baklan from Turkiye works on her porcelain craft. PHOTOS PROVIDED TO CHINA DAILY

sits a porcelain art piece. It is a spider with the body of a berry, which is part of her current project. The piece uses traditional Chinese white porcelain and has thick glazes from gas firing. "All the materials I used for it are purely traditional Chinese," she said. "Jingdezhen is an endless source of inspiration and pure, sophisticated materials that I can't get anywhere else. I have discovered many new techniques unknown to me previously."

The studio she shares with other resident artists is a microcosm of this global community. Three days earlier an artist in her 70s from the Netherlands had been working at the table next to hers for the previous three months. Age, like nationality, seems to matter little in this sprawling space.

"We are a multinational group of artists," K-Liee said. "We work here and enjoy not only the work, but the culture."

Apart from porcelain making, she has also become passionate about traditional tai chi, which she said she practises every morning at 6 o'clock, and acupuncture. "Even my sleep is really good here. It shows that my spirit feels really peaceful and happy."

Liliana Diaz, from Mexico, is working on a very different project. Her studio at Taoxichuan is filled with porcelain pieces shaped like brain scans.

"The printed piece is the hippocampus," she said. "This is the part of the brain that is in charge of storing memory."

She sees a connection between memories and the fragments of porcelain buried beneath Jingdezhen.

"I have learned that there are many fragments of porcelain and ceramics buried underground, and now they are reaching out and becoming part of the history of the city. So I'm trying to link that with how we search for our own memories."

Cultural exchange was at the heart of her decision to come to Jingdezhen, she said.

Pinar Baklan, a ceramics artist from Turkiye who has worked with porcelain for more than 20 years, said this is her first time in Jingdezhen.

"I'm happy to be here because we have a very similar culture to China. We have blue-and-white art like in China but use a different technique."

The blue and white she refers to is Iznik ceramics, a Turkish tradition born from the influence of Chinese blue-and-white porcelain that reached the Ottoman Empire via the Silk Road. The two are visually similar but technically distinct. The Turkish word for ceramic is "cini", which means coming from China.

"We tried for centuries to make the same quality as in China," Baklan said.

Jingdezhen's contribution to the world is its ability to bring people together, she said. "You have super deep culture here. You bring people together to share, which is a really important mission for artists. We have everything to discover here in Jingdezhen."

For the three artists, Jingdezhen is more than a place to work. It is also a place to live. K-Liee speaks of the changes she has seen over the past three years.

"The town has developed with enormous speed."

The UNESCO inscription will only accelerate that transformation, K-Liee said.

For the thousands who have chosen to stay, the city's new status as a World Heritage site is both a recognition of its past and a promise for its future.

Just what the doctor ordered: Mandarin, tea and a medical degree

By YAN YUJIE and ZHENG JINRAN

At 8 am Kherosana Devi Shadokpam began another day at the First Affiliated Hospital of Kunming Medical University, where the 24-year-old medical student from India was completing her clinical internship.

It marked a new stage in a journey that brought her to Kunming, Yunnan province, in April 2023. Back then, even ordering food or asking for directions could be difficult because of the language barrier. After devoting more than three years to studying Mandarin, she had attained intermediate-level proficiency in the language and was spending 10 hours a day at the hospital putting that learning to practical use.

"I have to make sure that my time management is on the right track," Shadokpam said. During her internship, studying and cooking for herself, she had far less free time than before.

Shadokpam is one of 25 Indian students studying clinical medicine in English at Kunming Medical University. While their number today is relatively small, Indian students have long been part of the university's international medical education programme.

Since the university began admitting international students in 1998, it has trained about 3,500 students from 67 countries. More than 500 international students from 43 countries are now enrolled, with India ranking sixth among their countries of origin, said Liu Yajie, dean of the School of International Education at Kunming Medical University.

Over the years 510 Indian students have studied in its English-taught Bachelor of Medicine and Bachelor of Surgery programme, which has been accredited by India's National Medical Commission.

Liu said it had also aligned its training with medical education standards in major source countries, including India. Its 31 training programmes, spanning undergraduate, master's and doctoral education, are supported by quality standards for 76 courses.

For the Indian students, those standards mattered because studying medicine abroad was closely tied to what came next in their careers.

Azeem, 21, of Delhi, checked whether the university was listed in the World Directory of Medical Schools before applying, an important consideration because he hoped eventually to take the United States Medical Licensing Examination.

Varsha Choudhary, 20, who arrived last October, also weighed education quality, technology and relatively affordable tuition compared with Western countries before choosing China.

"It's a great opportunity, but it requires full commitment, dedication and hard work," she said, adding that Indian students also needed to prepare for licensing

examinations back home.

That concern was reflected in the university's training. More than 80 per cent of its Indian Bachelor of Medicine and Bachelor of Surgery students who graduated last year had passed India's medical licensing examination, the university said.

Beyond preparing for a medical career, studying abroad also meant learning to live independently.

Azeem arrived in Kunming knowing almost no Chinese. An Afghan roommate who spoke Chinese helped him find his way around campus and buy a SIM card.

"I can be independent here, which is the most important point for me," Azeem said. "Being independent helps me develop a lot of perspective about the world."

Choudhary had a similar experience. "In India we didn't have to prepare food on our own. In China we need to cook for ourselves and look after ourselves, so we're much more responsible and independent here."



Varsha Choudhary at a food festival held by Kunming Medical University in Kunming, Yunnan province, in May. PROVIDED TO CHINA DAILY

Such experiences reflect the university's effort to combine medical education with opportunities for international students to experience Chinese society and culture. Chinese-language and China-focused courses were included in their studies, and activities outside the classroom introduced them to various aspects of life in Yunnan.

Choudhary attended a campus food festival and tried kung fu, one of China's best-known cultural traditions internationally.

"I explored kung fu and even tried a few moves myself," she said.

For Shadokpam, one of those encounters began with a cup of tea. A Chinese teacher introduced her to the rituals of preparing and drinking Chinese tea, in contrast to the milk tea she was accustomed to in India.

"Now I mostly drink tea the way my Chinese teacher taught me," she said.

Shadokpam said she plans to return to India after completing her degree next year and pursue further studies there. By then her years in Kunming would have given her not only medical training, but also the experience of living in another country and building friendships across cultures.

On an upper floor of a modern building the space opens into a vast and airy studio where sunlight pours through tall windows. This is a working hub for artists from around the world. Scattered across the room are worktables — each one a small universe with its own rhythm and its own conversation between artist and clay.

All are located in Taoxichuan, the sprawling cultural district built on the site of the former Universe Porcelain Factory in Jingdezhen, Jiangxi province.

On July 25 the Jingdezhen Handicraft Porcelain Industry Sites were inscribed on the UNESCO World Heritage List, becoming China's 61st World Heritage site and the first centred on porcelain. For the thousands of foreign artists who have settled in this city of 1.62 million people, the recognition came as no surprise.

Jingdezhen is home to more than 60,000 *jingpiao* — artists, designers and creators who have migrated to the porcelain capital, including thousands from more than 60 countries. Since 2015 Taoxichuan has been inviting artists from a variety of countries and regions through its residency programmes, offering three-month stays at its international



Mexican artist Liliana Diaz works on porcelain pieces shaped like brain scans in her studio at Taoxichuan in Jingdezhen, Jiangxi province.



A porcelain work from the Spider-Berries series by Russian artist Svetlana K-Liee.

al studio to more than 3,600 artists, according to Xinhua News Agency.

Svetlana K-Liee, an artist from Russia who lived in England for 17 years until 2023, first came to Jingdezhen that year for short residencies.

"Each time was not enough. Finally, after my third residency, which lasted three months, I decided to move here."

K-Liee, 49, works with porcelain, glass and bronze. On her worktable

Ties with new hometown sealed with blood and love

By CHEN YE

Rolling up his sleeves and extending his arm to donate blood has become a familiar ritual for Neeraj Punhani.

For 12 years the Indian businessman, 49, has regularly joined blood donation drives in Keqiao district of Shaoxing, Zhejiang province, where he has lived for 23 years while running a textile business that exports products to India.

It all began with a 12-year-old girl nicknamed Jia Jia.

In December 2014 she was diagnosed with acute lymphoblastic leukemia. Doctors said blood transfusions and chemotherapy would accompany her for a long time. The need for blood, along with mounting medical expenses, pushed her father,

Wei Baoshi, who supported a family of five through odd jobs, to the brink of despair.

On December 22, 2014, Punhani saw a posting on the social media app WeChat saying Jia Jia was urgently in need of blood. Moved by a photo of the girl who had lost her hair during chemotherapy, he decided to help.

"I wanted to help this girl. It touched my heart because my brothers and sisters and I all have daughters. So I felt like our own daughter needed help."

The next morning Punhani brought 16 fellow Indians and three Chinese friends to Hangzhou, capital of Zhejiang province, to donate blood. On January 3, 2015, more than 100 Indians arrived at a blood donation centre in Keqiao, with 96 donating



Neeraj Punhani, who donated blood in Shaoxing, Zhejiang province, last year. PROVIDED TO CHINA DAILY

a total of 33,800 millilitres of blood. More Indians who had been away on business returned to donate the following day.

The experience prompted Punhani to turn a one-time act of kindness into a long-running tradition. He began

promoting voluntary blood donation through WeChat and posters at Indian companies, restaurants and other places frequented by Indians.

The effort was also rooted in an earlier experience.

On May 9, 2013, an Indian man who

worked in Keqiao, fell seriously ill and urgently needed blood plasma. The Zhejiang Blood Centre and Shaoxing Central Blood Station organised a campaign under the theme "Love without borders blood continues life", in which 76 Chinese people donated blood for him. He later recovered.

Since then Punhani and his fellow Indians in Keqiao have organised nine blood donation campaigns, involving 754 donations and collecting 278,700 millilitres of blood. The largest campaign attracted 141 Indian donors.

Over the past 12 years, Jia Jia's father, Wei has visited Punhani's company almost every year, sitting down with him to catch up and once again express his gratitude.

"Although communication can sometimes be a little difficult, we have overcome the barriers of language and become good friends," Wei said.

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Will new online shopping rules help consumers?

FROM FRONT FLAP

2 Why are discounts, search rankings, and sponsored listings being targeted?

These practices can influence what consumers buy and how much they pay. A discount can appear larger depending on the reference price, while a product's position in search results can determine whether a consumer sees or buys it, particularly when sponsored listings are not clearly identified. A product appearing first could be there because it is relevant, because a seller paid for visibility or because of other ranking factors. Similarly, a displayed discount can anchor consumers to an earlier price without showing whether that price was representative. The rules seek to make these behind-the-scenes influences more visible, giving consumers more information about prices, advertising and rankings.

ISTOCKPHOTO

3 What's a dark pattern?

Dark patterns are design practices intended to manipulate consumers through a platform's interface or purchase flow. These include false urgency, adding products to a basket without clear consent, revealing fees only at checkout, making cancellation difficult, disguising advertising and hiding charges. India identified 13 such practices under its 2023 guidelines. The new rules make compliance with these guidelines a direct requirement.

4 How could this change e-commerce?

Platforms may need to track prices more closely across millions of products and sellers, retain historical data to establish the lowest price over 30 days, and modify search-ranking algorithms. The pricing rules could also alter promotional strategies. A short-lived discount on one marketplace could affect the reference price for a later promotion. Coupons, bank offers, membership benefits and other incentives could become harder to structure when the price actually paid differs from the listed selling price. This could eventually affect how platforms differentiate themselves and compete.

5 Will consumers actually benefit?

The rules aim to give consumers more information while restricting manipulative design. That could give them more control over purchase decisions if enforced effectively. The Central Consumer Protection Authority can already penalize unfair trade practices, as its action on dark patterns shows. Search rankings will be harder to police; while platforms must disclose key ranking parameters, algorithms remain proprietary, forcing regulators to distinguish fair ranking from manipulation. While greater transparency will help buyers make better choices, it won't necessarily lower prices.

'India's family businesses struggle to hand control'

Patriarch or matriarch well into their 60s running most family businesses in India

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The patriarch or matriarch at most family-run businesses in India do not give up control even when they are well into their sixties, leading to ill-executed succession, according to a new study that analyzed 474 large and mid-sized companies.

In nearly half of the Indian family-run businesses led by someone aged 60 or older, a family successor had joined the company but had yet to gain full operational control, a study by headhunting firm Executive Access found.

The family head not giving up control means successors are often past their prime age when they are eventually handed over the reins. "Many of India's family business heirs will be closer to retirement than to the start of their careers by the time they actually get to lead," the study said.

The study individually analyzed 474 leading listed and unlisted companies across sectors such as textiles, agricultural products, sugar, consumer goods, chemicals, metals and pharma. It excluded the country's top conglomerates and large-cap companies, whose succession or a lack thereof routinely attracts public scrutiny.

A lack of interest from the next generation was also a leading reason for poor succession planning at these companies, the study found. This echoes the sentiment famously expressed by billionaire Uday Kotak in 2025, when he said that he was noticing many in the next generation were taking the easy way out by looking to manage family investments instead of running businesses.

Of the 474 businesses analyzed over a period of one year, there were 294 where the patriarch was older than 60. Half of them had inducted a successor but the control wasn't fully transferred to them, as discussed above.

At a quarter of the 294 firms, there was no identifiable successor from the promoter fam-



ISTOCKPHOTO

Only 3% of the firms studied had completed a clean succession, with patriarchs continuing to influence key decisions.

ily. This excludes cases where someone from the next generation was a part of the company's board in a non-executive capacity.

Most of these businesses did not even have a professional chief executive or managing director in place, bringing significant business continuity risk in case the patriarch is incap-

in the business for years, he is a whole-time director, the title is very fancy. But every big decision goes to the father," Agamjeet Dang, CEO, Executive Access, said. "That's not succession. That is a designation." The patriarch needs to repurpose himself and step away from day-to-day decisions, he said. "A patriarch in the chair can be a source of strength. A patriarch who still takes every decision from the chair becomes the bottleneck."

Only 3% of the firms analyzed had a clean handover, the study found. Srinath Sridharan, an advisor to Executive Access, cited an example where the patriarch in his 70s was the chairman while his son succeeded him as the managing director. However, in practice, every decision ran through the father, including something as granular as locking the prices of inputs, he said. In such cases, the successors are often underprepared for the role and they have very low confidence, he said.

SUCCESSION WOES

LACK of interest from next generation also a leading reason for poor succession planning

OF 474 businesses analyzed over a year, the patriarch was older than 60 in 294 companies

MOST of these businesses did not even have a professional CEO or MD in place

ited, the study found.

In the last quarter of the companies with patriarchs over 60, succession was completed with the reins handed over. However, even here, the patriarch stayed on the board, often leading to unclear power structures.

"In many families, the son is 45, he has been

Markets shift to rate-hike mode after US Fed's hawkish turn

FROM PAGE 1

(FOMC) raised rates for the first time since 2023 to 3.75-4.00%, as consumer inflation remained above the Fed's 2% target at 3.4% in August for the second month, driven by higher energy prices amid the West Asia war, tariff increases and strong demand linked to the artificial-intelligence (AI) boom.

Until over a week ago, an October rate hike was not firmly priced into market expectations. However, that has changed following the US Fed's move, as well as RBI's recent measures to absorb excess liquidity from record foreign-currency inflows through a dedicated window.

"The global rate backdrop has turned decisively less benign, with the US Fed hiking 25bps and the Bank of Japan (BoJ) moving towards further normalization amid elevated US yields. Against this, RBI's liquidity absorption through



Market participants expect RBI to raise the rate at which it lends short-term funds to banks again in December.

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variable rate reverse repo (VRRRs), foreign exchange swaps and open-market operations (OMO) sales signals a clear shift to liquidity normalization and could be a precursor to a rate hike," said V.R.C. Reddy, treasury head at Karur Vysya Bank. The next meeting could mark start of a cautious tightening phase, with a 25bps hike in October and another in December becoming a distinct

possibility if external pressures persist, he said.

While Fed's 25bps rate hike was mostly in line with expectations, its outlook has a hawkish tone. The estimates show another 25bps hike this year, while the 2027 median projection keeps rates elevated, with eight Fed officials seeing scope for more hikes and four seeing easing, per Emkay Global Financial Services.

After Fed's hike, the yield on the 10-year US Treasury rose by 2bps to 5.02% on Wednesday, then eased to 4.98% by the end of the day. Yield on the Indian government bond with a similar maturity rose by 2bps to 7.07% on Thursday.

The global policy tide has turned hawkish. As the US

Fed, the European Central Bank, and the BoJ signal tighter policy and global yields rise, India has limited room for policy divergence, a 17 September report by Axis Capital's Economic Research said. "Rate hikes are thus inevitable...The Fed's latest hike and dot plot strengthen the case

for 50bps of RBI tightening in 2026, split between October and December. We expect the overall hiking cycle to be limited to 75bps." In 2025, RBI cumulatively cut the repo rate by 125bps, with the last cut of 25bps in December to 5.25%.

While headline inflation has risen sharply, core inflation remains steady. RBI's mandate is to target headline inflation, but focusing on headline inflation forecasts may miss underlying trends, the report said,

adding that the risk of second-round effects is rising and that a sectoral supply shock can transform into broader inflation if monetary or fiscal policies actively accommodate it.

India's retail inflation rose to a 20-month high of 4.82% in August, driven by higher food and fuel prices

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adding that the risk of second-round effects is rising and that a sectoral supply shock can transform into broader inflation if monetary or fiscal policies actively accommodate it.

India's retail inflation rose to a 20-month high of 4.82% in August, driven by higher food and fuel prices, moving above RBI's 4% target midpoint for the third consecutive month. Core inflation came in at 4.2%, as against 3.9% in July. India, however, saw robust real GDP growth of 7.8% in the June quarter from 6.9% a year ago.

Madhavi Arora, chief economist at Emkay Global, expects the October decision to be the start of a shallow tightening cycle. "A 25bps hike in October by RBI looks more likely, but we also expect this to be a shallow hiking cycle of 50-75bps," she said.

RBI's near-term focus is likely to stay on draining surplus liquidity and aligning overnight rates with it, the report said.



The court said AWS should be given a personal hearing to explain whether the transactions had been examined.

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Delhi HC sets aside AWS's ₹4,500 cr tax review case

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In a relief to Amazon Web Services Inc. (AWS), the Delhi High Court (HC) on Thursday set aside an income-tax department order seeking to reopen its assessment over foreign remittances of more than ₹4,500 crore, sending the matter back to the assessing officer for fresh consideration.

Hearing AWS's plea against the reassessment order, a division bench of justices Dinesh Mehta and Rajneesh Kumar Gupta, held that it should get a personal hearing and an opportunity to explain if the transactions were already assessed.

"The assessing officer shall thereafter fix a date for personal hearing and, if the assessee is represented, hear the authorized representative and consider the response in accordance with law," the court said.

The case relates to assessment year 2020-21. The tax department issued a reassessment notice in March this year after its risk management system (RMS) flagged several transactions of over ₹4,000 crore. The department said the transactions may not have

been taken into account in the earlier assessment, which involved about ₹2,966 crore, and sought an explanation from the cloud-services arm of Amazon, on the remittances flagged by the system.

The RMS is an internal risk-based system used by officials to identify taxpayers, returns, transactions or information that may warrant verification or a further look. An RMS flag does not establish income has escaped assessment but it can prompt further examination.

AWS argued that the income for that assessment

year was already examined by tax authorities. The earlier assessment identified about ₹2,966 crore in foreign remittances relating to cloud-computing services and considered

its global income in determining the part attributable to India.

AWS's senior lawyer Porus Kaka said: "The department hasn't gone on individual remittances. They have assessed my global income in the US on a proportionate basis across the globe. What is left to be assessed? ... What is left to be assessed in India?"

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Titan boosts mechanical watches, seeks to clock larger share

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Titan is stepping up its mechanical watchmaking capabilities as it seeks to build a larger presence in the premium end of India's watch market, targeting a 25% share of the segment above ₹25,000, according to Kuruvilla Markose, chief executive officer of Titan's Watches Division.

"We have some distance to go to get there, and we'll keep working on it through the portfolio," Markose told Mint.

The push comes with the launch of Titan's Vetrabrand Titan Automatics collection, as the company moves further upmarket while keeping mechanical watches within a relatively accessible price range. Priced at ₹48,000-55,000, the movements are based on Titan's 7,000-series mechanical plat-

form and branded Vetrabrand.

That shift is already visible in the division's financial performance. Titan's consolidated Watches business reported total income of ₹1,543 crore in the June quarter, up 21% from ₹1,273 crore a year earlier. Earnings Before Interest and Taxes (Ebit) rose to ₹295 crore from ₹287 crore, taking the segment margin to 19.1%. Analogue watches grew in the mid-20% range, while smartwatches declined in the single digits. It attributed the growth to premiumisation and continued consumer preference for analogue timepieces.

Markose said Titan's ambition extends beyond the Vetrabrand. The company has been developing mechanical movements in-house since 2010, but believes changing consumer behaviour and rising disposable incomes have created a larger market for more sophisticated watches. "We're not late



Titan's Watches Division CEO Kuruvilla Markose said the company's ambition extends beyond the Vetrabrand

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for India. We're ahead of the curve," he said. Titan is also targeting high horology, including tourbillons that counter the effects of gravity on a watch accuracy, and is building global recognition for Indian mechanical movements.

"Just like people today say a watch has a Citizen Miyota or

Seiko movement, an Indian movement from an Indian manufacturer should also be seen as an expression of excellence," he said.

Titan's premium watch push the technology beyond the 72-hour power reserve. Markose said Titan plans to develop

movements with 80-, 120-, and eventually 180-hour reserves, while improving accuracy towards COSC-level capability, meaning a watch keeps time as reliably as a smartphone. Titan is also preparing an ultra-slim mechanical version of its Edge watch, with a movement 2.2 mm thick and a watch thickness of 5.7 mm.

At the higher end, Titan has used limited-edition tourbillon watches to demonstrate its capabilities. A Jalsa tourbillon was priced at ₹45 lakh, while another was priced at around ₹25 lakh. Markose said the next challenge is to make high-horology ones, including tourbillons with more accessible pricing.

However, the company's ambitions are hampered by gaps in its domestic manufac-

turing ecosystem. Titan makes several components in-house, but still imports some, such as the hairspring that regulates a mechanical watch. Markose said only a handful of manufacturers globally make hairsprings, and Titan does not see itself making them immediately, though it is working towards making its own assortments.

Some components, such as tourbillon cages, are also sourced externally. Titan wants to use its manufacturing scale to develop a model suited to higher volumes. It makes about 20 million watches a year, most of them quartz, and Markose said mechanical watches cannot all be produced by hand.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com



Brands are looking beyond creators' follower counts

Hiring is increasingly being influenced by audience quality, engagement, measurable results

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MUMBAI

A million followers was once enough for a brand to hire a creator, based on the assumption that a larger audience meant greater reach and value. But creator databases and artificial intelligence (AI) tools are allowing brands to look beyond follower counts and assess audience quality and behaviour.

Indian creator pool has grown from 0.96 million people in 2020 to 4.12 million in 2025, says a 2026 report by the Indian School of Business and HashFame, a networking app connecting brands, agencies and creators.

With more creators competing for brand work, networking platforms are helping brands sift through the larger pool using digital databases. Qoruz, a creator intelligence platform, organises creators by category, location, industry and audience characteristics. Its database covers about 2 million creators across Instagram, YouTube, X, Facebook and Snapchat, which it tracks in real time.

Anirudh Sridharan, co-founder of HashFame, describes the change in the hiring approach as a move from 'vanity metrics' to 'utility metrics'. While 'reach' used to be the starting point, brands are now placing less emphasis on audience size and more on how people respond to content, he said.

Fluency.Social, an autonomous AI platform managing deals for creators and agencies, has identified five factors that brands consider before hiring. First is audience authenticity, which helps identify and filter bot-driven activity. The second is verified engagement, including comments, direct messages and conversational inquiries. The third is down-funnel



Creators from India's tier-II and III cities are gaining relevance through local language, cultural understanding and niche audiences.

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attribution, such as affiliate sales and promo-code redemptions. The fourth is pricing or contractual efficiency, which determines whether creators can close deals and deliver agreed content on time. The fifth is 'vernacular resonance', or the ability to connect

ces, giving advertisers access to engaged, niche communities.

Sridharan says 60-70% of influencer campaign budgets now go towards micro and nano creators, up from roughly 30-40% just 3-5 years ago.

"A big change in the creator econ-

ghal, head of talent at Creators@Collective, the creator representation arm of Collective Artists Network.

Creators@Collective's focus as a representation business is evolving towards creators who have a clear niche and a strong connection with their audience, irrespective of where they come from or the size of their following, Singhal said. "The opportunity is not just in finding creators with reach, but in identifying talent that has built real relevance and trust within a particular community."

The growing use of smaller creators, however, means agencies have to manage more people for each campaign. Shashank Jarial, co-founder and chief executive, Fluency.Social, said a campaign involving 50 micro creators could require significantly more manpower than one involving a single large creator. AI is now helping handle this additional workload. "Across our network, we are seeing AI handle 90% of the back-and-forth like contract redlining and initial follow-ups. The remaining 10% involves a human-in-the-loop for final approvals, backed by all the gathered data," Jarial said.

But there is another underlying reality: participation has grown faster than monetisation. HashFame noted that while more micro and nano creators received brand opportunities, the rapid growth in creator supply also put downward pressure on pricing.

The 2026 ISB-HashFame report shows that the number of non-metro creators participating in brand campaigns rose from about 38,000 in 2020 to more than 408,000 in 2025. At the same time, the average number of campaigns secured by each active creator fell from about 0.37 to just 0.10, with most creators undertaking only one paid campaign annually.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Celebrity rights claims meet higher bar in the digital age

Lata Jha
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NEW DELHI

With the Delhi High Court denying actor Jahnvi Kapoor a broad injunction in a personality rights case, experts say the court is essentially drawing a line between protecting personality rights and policing the Internet. The risk now for celebrities is therefore one of enforcement economics rather than entitlement.

As a result, many have begun engaging specialist IP protection teams and, alongside them, brand protection vendors that crawl platforms and generate the link schedules that go into these efforts. The practical challenge for actors will be to monitor issues more closely and approach the court with precise, narrowly tailored relief rather than seeking a sweeping restraint.

"Celebrities are becoming more conscious of unauthorized use of their name, image, voice and likeness, and of the reputational harm that can follow. What it does require is a more specialized and proactive system for monitoring content, preserving evidence, issuing takedown requests and moving the court swiftly where

Personality-rights enforcement now places greater emphasis on documentation, precision and swift action

required," said Neeha Nagpal, founding and managing partner at N & Co. Legal.

In that sense, personality-rights protection is becoming an ongoing legal and reputation-management exercise. The emphasis is likely to be on speed, precision and documentation rather than having a bigger legal team, she added.

What is visible is a rise in enquiries, with law firms reporting more approaches



Delhi HC's refusal to grant Jahnvi Kapoor a blanket injunction raises the evidentiary bar for personality-rights claims. ISTOCKPHOTO

from actors, athletes and creators worried about artificial intelligence (AI) copies of their identity, agreed Viren Vesu-wala, lead PR, communications and strategic partnerships at independent digital marketing agency White Rivers Media. "The work has also changed shape. Deepfakes, voice cloning, fake accounts and unauthorized endorsements sit closer to everyday social content than to old merchandising disputes, and cases now pull in Meta, Google and X. The money is

going into monitoring and specialist counsel rather than head-count."

Experts said Delhi High Court's refusal to grant a blanket injunction is a

positive development for free expression and legitimate commercial speech. Films, and particularly, the celebrities are an integral part of India's popular culture, and an unnecessarily expansive ban on the use of their aspects of personality could diminish the value of legitimate fan engagement, artistic expression, commentary, satire, and so on.

At the same time, according to Siddharth Tewari, partner

at Ascendus Law Partners, the ruling indicates that celebrities seeking to enforce their personality rights have to meet a higher evidentiary burden.

Rather than obtaining a sweeping order against thousands of URLs at once, petitioners may be required to demonstrate specifically how each category of content infringes their rights, whether by being obscene or pornographic, violating personality-related commercial or publicity rights, or causing reputational harm.

The practical risk is that unauthorized commercial exploitation of a celebrity's persona could, in certain cases, continue under the garb of free expression or commercial speech until a court is convinced that the particular use meets the standard which requires coercive action.

"There is a visible shift, and personality rights is now a distinct practice line rather than an occasional filing. Celebrities are engaging specialist IP litigation teams and, alongside them, brand protection vendors who crawl platforms and generate the link schedules that go into these suits," said Sonam Chandwani, managing partner, KS Legal & Associates.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

ONGC
ऑयल एण्ड नेचुरल गैस कॉर्पोरेशन लिमिटेड
Oil and Natural Gas Corporation Ltd.

Publication of EOI notice

Oil and Natural Gas Corporation Ltd. (ONGC), a Government of India 'MAHARATNA' Category Enterprise, is India's premier energy enterprise with diversified interests across the energy sector.

ONGC invites EOI against EOI No. **ONGC/GCS/EOI/2026/01 for "Market Exploration for Natural Gas Compression and/or Gas Dehydration Services" across its operating locations in India.**

The purpose of this Expression of Interest (EOI) is to identify experienced and potential entities capable of providing Natural Gas Compression and/or Gas Dehydration Services. Responses are invited from City Gas Distribution Compressor O&M operators, compression and dehydration service providers, manufacturers/packages, EPC/SITC contractors and other competent organizations (details available at ONGC portal: <https://ongcindia.com>)

A pre-submission meeting is scheduled online for Sept 25, 2026 and the last date for submission of EOI is Oct 05, 2026. Interested parties are requested to submit their responses in electronic (PDF/PPT) format to singh_ak25@ongc.co.in, madhavan_s@ongc.co.in and/or sanghi_sanjiv@ongc.co.in. To participate in the pre-submission meeting or for any clarifications, kindly reach out to the above email IDs or contact numbers: 011-2675 2069, 7710091814.

Corrigenda, addenda, amendments, and time extensions to the EOI (if any) will be published only on the <https://www.ongcindia.com>. No separate notification shall be issued in the press. Prospective participants are advised to visit the portal regularly for updates.

Rajasthan State Road Development And Construction Corporation Ltd., JAIPUR
No. NIT/2026-27/132-44 निविदा सूचना/2026-27 Date: 16.09.2026

निम्नलिखित परियोजनाओं पर चक्कर चलाते हुए ई-टेंडरिंग प्रक्रिया से अनिवार्य निविदा आमंत्रण को जारी है:-

कार्य का विवरण	कार्य की कुल अनुमानित लागत (रु.)	निविदा सूचना संख्या
Selection of Bidder for Collection of User Fee on the basis of competitive bidding through e-procurement basis for the following:-		
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On Merla-Lambiya-Rias BOT Road for a period of 01 Year. UBN: RRC2627SL000051	1955.92 Lakh	ई-362/26-27
On Borwar-Khatu Road (SH-2B) for a period of 01 Year UBN: RRC2627SL000052	200.35 Lakh	

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सहसंचालक

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E-Request Notice: 210 and 211

PGVCL invites Request for Bid for Turnkey Contract for Supply, Installation Testing and Commissioning of 11 KV Medium Voltage Covered Conductor (MVCC) with its accessories and allied items in various Circles of PGVCL under Kisan Suryodaya Yojana (KSY) Scheme for circle wise different packages (Time Based Contract), same is put up on our on-line (e-Tender) website <https://tender.nprocure.com>. Interested bidders are requested to submit the tender online. The Tender document for view and download is also available on our website www.pgvcl.com. In future, if any amendment/s will be required for this tender, same will be uploaded only on above websites.

Date: 18/09/2026 Chief Engineer (Project and R & C)

BRIHANMUMBAI MAHANAGARPALIKA
Lokmanya Tilak Municipal General Hospital and
Lokmanya Tilak Municipal Medical College Sion, Mumbai -22
No.LTH/ET-03/T Dt.17.09.26

E-TENDER NOTICE

This is an E-Tender Notice. The Commissioner of BRIHANMUMBAI MUNICIPAL CORPORATION (BMC) invites e- tenders as given below in three Packet systems". The e-Tender copy can be downloaded from GeM portal (<https://gem.gov.in>) under "e-procurement" section.

Subject : Reagent for STA Liatest D DI+ (D-dimer) Qty. 12 Packet (per pack 6 x 6 ml) for Pathology Dept. Of L.T.M.G. Hospital.

Bid No. GEM/2026/B/8021421

E-Tender Price (Rs.)	EMD (Rs.)	Start Date and Time of online Bid Downloading	End Date and Time of online Bid Submission
Rs.1600/- plus GST@18%=1888.00	Rs.20,000/-	18/09/2026 04.00pm (16:00 Hrs)	29/09/2026 04.30pm (16:30 Hrs)

Note - Bidders are required to upload the PDF copies of the earmarked deposit and tender fee Demand Draft (DD) on or before due date & time. Additionally, the original physical DD must be delivered to the Hospital's Tender Department prior to the scheduled opening of the technical packet.

The intending tenderer shall visit GeM portal website at BRIHANMUMBAI MUNICIPAL CORPORATION (BMC) <http://www.https://gem.gov.in> for further details of the tender.

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भोपाल विकास प्राधिकरण, भोपाल

क्रमांक : 478/का.यं. 01/ई-निविदा/भोविप्र/2026 भोपाल, दिनांक : 15.09.2026

ई-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना

निविदा प्रपत्र में वर्णित पंजीयन एवं पात्रता संबंधी मानदंडों को पूर्ण करने वाले ठेकेदारों एवं प्रतिष्ठित फर्मों/कंपनियों से निम्नलिखित कार्य हेतु ई-निविदा प्रक्रिया द्वारा प्रतिशत दर आधार पर ऑनलाइन निविदाएं आमंत्रित की जाती हैं :-

क्र. सं.	पोर्टल निविदा क्रमांक	कार्य का नाम	अनुमानित लागत P.A.C. (रुपये)	असेसमेंट मनी डिपोजिट (रुपये)	निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य (पोर्टल फीस के अलावा) (रुपये)	कार्य पूर्ण करने हेतु निर्धारित समयावधि
1.	2026_DTCP_536267	Supplying and erection of 8 No's of multi circuit monopole complete for 132KV DCDS line of 132/33 KV EHT electrical substation at salaiya, Bhopal (Bhopal Development Authority)	13,21,60,024/-	10,00,000/-	Rs. 35,400/- (portal fees & G.S.T. are payable in addition to this amount)	06 Months

1. निविदा संबंधित अन्य विस्तृत विवरण वेबसाइट पोर्टल <http://www.mptenders.gov.in> पर देखे जा सकते हैं।

2. निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य एवं पोर्टल फीस की राशि क्रेडिट कार्ड/डेबिट कार्ड/कैश कार्ड या इंटरनेट बैंकिंग सिस्टम के माध्यम से उल्लेखित वेबसाइट पर भुगतान कर निविदा प्रपत्र दिनांक 16.09.2026 को 10.30 बजे से दिनांक 08.10.2026 को 18.00 बजे तक क्रय किये जा सकते हैं। अन्य Key Dates संबंधित Bid Data Sheet में देखी जा सकती है।

3. निविदा से संबंधित कोई भी संशोधन समाचार पत्रों में प्रकाशित न करते हुए केवल उल्लेखित वेबसाइट पर ही सूचित किए जायेंगे।

4. अन्य संबंधित जानकारी अधोहस्ताक्षरकर्ता के कार्यालय से किसी भी कार्य दिवस व समय में प्राप्त की जा सकती है।

म.प्र. माध्यम/128095/2026 कार्यपालन यंत्री, संभाग क्र.-1



OpenAI shares more safety incidents and adopts new rules for reporting them

Erin Woo
feedback@livemint.com

An OpenAI model undergoing testing rewrote its own instructions, telling itself to disregard “the roles and identities that bind other chat-bots.” An AI agent tried to pass a test by uploading a file to the internet, then citing it as a source. Another agent couldn’t find the data to create a financial model, so it instructed itself to make up the data and “be transparent only if asked.”

OpenAI disclosed these and other previously unreported incidents on Wednesday as the company announced a new framework for reporting instances of misbehavior by its artificial-intelligence models.

The framework covers so-called model misalignment, a term used by researchers to describe AI that acts in ways that

ignore or conflict with human intentions. The company disclosed six new examples of misaligned behavior, all of which it said would have been deemed eligible for disclosure or investigation under the framework.

OpenAI’s announcement comes as fears over harmful AI reach a fever pitch. Last week, a former OpenAI researcher, Jacob Coxon, quit Anthropic and expressed concerns that the AI industry was racing to build systems it couldn’t control. Over the weekend, executives from Anthropic, OpenAI, Google and SpaceX agreed that they needed to slow down the pace of AI development.

“We think it’s important to share what we’re learning as soon as possible,” Kai Chen, OpenAI’s head of alignment, said in an interview ahead of the framework’s release. “We hope it helps inform shared standards and regulation that can create clear expectations for all AI developers.”

OpenAI said in a blog post on Wednesday that it would “aim to disclose examples that provide useful evidence about how model misalignment arises, how it manifests, and where safeguards succeed or fail.” That can include a model hiding a mistake, acting without permission or working around a safeguard. OpenAI will give priority to disclosing new types of misalignment, meaningful changes in known behavior and findings that challenge assumptions of cur-



George Osborne, head of OpenAI for Countries.

REUTERS

rent safeguards, Chen said.

Any employee can flag an incident for potential disclosure, kicking off a review by technical staff. Disputes will be escalated to OpenAI’s safety

leadership and OpenAI leadership.

Minor incidents must be disclosed within one or two weeks, while more complex investigations including third parties may take longer to be disclosed, Chen said.

In its blog post, OpenAI said the framework doesn’t replace OpenAI’s legal disclosure requirements for safety incidents and cybersecurity breaches.

OpenAI said it is working to propose reporting mechanisms for sharing serious incidents with the federal government, and it plans to develop “more objective disclosure criteria” with external developers and researchers, industry standards bodies and regulators.

OpenAI didn’t share the framework with other frontier labs including Anthropic or Google before publishing it, Chen said.

“We unilaterally put up this framework to hopefully inspire the rest of the industry to follow on and share their own misalignment reporting frameworks,” Chen said.

The recent round of AI safety fears was kicked off by the July discovery that OpenAI agents had tried to cheat on an evaluation by hacking the AI software company Hugging Face. An August report by the third-party AI evaluator METR revealed that up to 1,200 OpenAI agents had

secretly collaborated on a message board they built inside OpenAI.

Anthropic subsequently disclosed that its models had also hacked other companies after inadvertently gaining internet access during cybersecurity tests. Since then, security researchers have found evidence of other breaches, including a May cyberattack carried out by OpenAI agents against a popular online service for coders.

OpenAI’s disclosures in its announcement on Wednesday span incidents ranging from October 2025 through this July and involve models including its 5.6 Sol model released in June, internal-only models and an unreleased version of OpenAI’s most advanced Astra model.

Some of the incidents were discovered by internal training run and misalignment monitoring systems, and took anywhere from two days to several months to be noticed. In the reports, OpenAI said

that it had improved its alignment grading system to better penalize bad behavior. The company said the model that rewrote its own instructions seemed to have ignored the revision and didn’t behave any differently as a result.

“We really want to bias towards disclosing, even if we think the behavior is no longer a problem in our current deployed models,” Chen said.

News Corp., owner of The Wall Street Journal, has a content-licensing partnership with OpenAI.

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The company said it hopes to inspire competitors to greater transparency as public fears about AI dangers mount

Fed raises rates; Warsh hints of more to come

The Fed raised interest rates by a quarter percentage point, the first time in three years

Nick Timiraos
feedback@livemint.com

Investors have been betting the Federal Reserve is at the start of a series of interest-rate increases. On Wednesday, Chairman Kevin Warsh gave them little reason to think otherwise.

The Fed raised rates for the first time in three years, and officials penciled in at least one more increase this year. Warsh said the quarter-point move “removed a dose of accommodation.” In central-bank parlance, accommodation means stimulus, so the phrase suggested officials don’t think rates are restraining the economy even after lifting them.

Warsh also listed geopolitics—a euphemism for the Iran war and the energy shock it has caused—among three developments since July that led to Wednesday’s decision. “There’s no hiding from hot spots around the world,” he said. Officials had changed their judgment about how those conflicts were likely to unfold, suggesting they no longer see the energy shock as a disruption to wait out, he said.

“If you don’t even think you’re restrictive and oil isn’t going anywhere, you’ve got some work to do,” said Michael Gape, chief U.S. economist at Morgan Stanley. After the meeting, he revised his forecast to anticipate a total of three rate increases, including Wednesday’s, up from two. The yield on the 2-year Treasury note, which is highly sensitive to expectations for Fed rates, rose to its highest level in more than two years.

Warsh presented his view of policy as one the rate-setting committee shared. Warsh’s framing suggested that the two hikes officials had penciled in for the year, which includes the one delivered Wednesday, are “likely a down payment on what might need to be a much more prolonged policy tightening cycle,” said James Egelhof, chief U.S. economist at BNP Paribas.

Officials also nudged up their projections for inflation and the neutral rate, the setting that neither speeds up nor slows the economy. Those revisions mean that Wednesday’s increase reflected a Fed raising rates just to stay in the same place it had been in June.

Warsh played down that yardstick at a news conference. He called the neutral rate useful academically but said it had no “operational effect on decisions that we make today.”

He didn’t say whether more increases were coming, leaving investors to guess whether the Fed moves again at its next meeting in late October. Gregory Peters, co-chief investment officer at PGIM Credit, said he sees the increase as the start of a path rather than a one-time adjustment. Unless inflation data change course, he said, “I think it’s hard to say they won’t move” next month.

The committee was more united than it had been in months. At the July meet-



Federal Reserve chairman Kevin Warsh.

AP

ing, when the Fed held rates steady, three officials dissented in favor of raising them. In June, at Warsh’s first meeting as chairman, the officials’ projections showed a clear split over whether hikes would be needed this year.

On Wednesday, the vote to raise rates was unanimous, and 16 of the 18 officials who submitted projections penciled in at least one more increase this year. Diane Swonk, chief U.S. economist at KPMG, called the vote “a much needed affirmation of the Fed’s independence.”

President Trump, who picked Warsh after spending months lambasting his predecessor, Jerome Powell, for not cutting rates faster, said Wednesday evening that he was standing by the chairman, who he said has “a very tough board.”

Trump also said he had spoken with Warsh at some point before the meeting. “I talked to Kevin. I said, ‘You might as well vote with the board because it’s not going to matter,’” Trump said. “I said, ‘Do what you want.’”

At his news conference, Warsh declined to discuss his conversations with the president but said the choice to raise rates had been “one that we have been preparing for and thinking about” since he arrived at the Fed in May. He called it a “sober,” “serious,” and “responsible” decision.

The press conference marked a change in tone from July, when Warsh said little about what would prompt the Fed to raise rates, and long-term Treasury yields rose as he spoke. This time, he walked through the data and listed what had changed since the last meeting, sounding more like previous Fed chairs, Swonk said.

Egelhof called it “an aggressive effort to turn around the credibility narrative” helped by projections that showed a unified effort. “Knowing you’re lead-

ing a group that is behind you is a lot easier than trying to stitch together a consensus story for a group that really doesn’t have a consensus,” he said.

The unanimity reflected a shift in how officials see inflation. Earlier this year, several suggested the energy shock would fade and the Fed could wait it out, as they did with tariffs last year. Oil eased for a time, and some officials pointed to cooler inflation over a three-month stretch. Others worried the shocks were compounding and could no longer be assumed to pass on their own.

Crude has since climbed back to around \$100 a barrel, and diesel and other refined products have risen further. Officials have “reached the acceptance stage of grief on there being a bit of a moderate but a persistent inflation problem,” Egelhof said.

Private fore-

casters are reaching the same conclusion. Julia Coronado, founder of MacroPolicy Perspectives, said her firm had expected inflation to step down sharply next year as the effects of tariffs and higher energy prices faded. “They’re not fading,” she said, in part because the war has outlasted forecasts that it would end by August since forecasters assumed the alternative would be too damaging to the economy. The firm is raising its 2027 forecast for underlying inflation.

She is also concerned about the start of the year, when many businesses reset prices, and about increases spreading. “There’s so many things that are getting more expensive that any business or any consumer is thinking about inflation all the damn time,” she said.

How much higher rates must go to stop that spread is unclear, and Warsh didn’t guess. He said the Fed needn’t “do harm to the labor markets” to bring

inflation down. But he acknowledged that higher rates can’t lower oil prices. And much of the AI investment boom is largely insensitive to borrowing costs.

If inflation stays elevated and the Fed sees tighter policy as the only remedy, Morgan Stanley’s Gape said, the likely channel is falling asset prices. “The first thing to go would likely be financial prices and then maybe consumption.”

Fed tightening campaigns have often continued until something gave way. In 2018, a late-year stock selloff helped persuade officials to end a mild rate-hike campaign designed to pre-empt inflation, which had only just reached 2% after years below it. In 2023, the collapse of Silicon Valley Bank, which touched off a broader regional banking scare, came a year into the Fed’s most aggressive increases in four decades to combat very high inflation.

Some bankers say the squeeze has begun. Frank Sorrentino, chief executive of ConnectOne Bancorp, a New Jersey-based lender, said before the meeting that outside of energy and AI, his customers were reporting slower sales, fewer bookings and rising costs. With 10-year Treasury yields around 5% and mortgage rates near 7%, housing, car purchases and discretionary spending were already cooling, he said.

Higher rates wouldn’t touch the AI companies raising huge sums, he said: “Do you think they care whether rates are up 50 or 75 basis points?” The burden would fall on households and businesses already under strain, he said.

The alternative carries its own risk. After more than five years above target, inflation could become entrenched as businesses and households come to expect it. The economy, Gape said, “can handle modestly firmer policy rates without putting the expansion at risk.”

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Iran’s attempts to get around the Hormuz blockade are hitting a wall

Benoit Faucon &
Hamraz Bayan

Iran vowed to respond to a U.S. blockade by pushing more trade overland. On the ground, it isn’t going according to plan.

Hundreds of Iranian truck drivers are currently stuck at Iran’s border with Pakistan, unable to send their goods into Tehran’s neighbor. They say they are facing worsening bureaucratic hurdles and costs, many caused by their own government. The same thing is happening at Iran’s land borders with

Turkey, Turkmenistan and Afghanistan, dealing Tehran a self-inflicted blow and throttling trade through its few remaining economic release valves.

Tons of stranded apricots have been spoiled because of the delays. Lucrative cargoes of iron ore, cement and bottled gas are stuck at entry points to the Pakistani and Afghan borders, truckers say.

“Neither Iran is taking responsibility for the situation, nor is Pakistan allowing us to unload our cargo,” one driver says in a video posted by the Union of Truckers and Drivers Organizations Across Iran

over the weekend.

The economic war in the Persian Gulf is dictated as much by how much the countries in the region can move their exports over land rather than through the Strait of Hormuz. Some have found workarounds. Saudi Arabia is moving more of its oil west across the Arabian Peninsula. The U.S. Navy is helping some of the Gulf nations shift their oil through the strait.

Iran’s attempts are faltering. The U.S. is isolating its economy with new sanctions and launching strikes on Iranian tankers in reprisal for Tehran’s attacks on its Navy, collapsing seaborne

exports.

In another setback for Iran’s plans to bypass Hormuz, the country’s Mahan Air, which is sanctioned by the U.S., said Wednesday that it was suspending flights to Oman and Turkey, state-affiliated media in Tehran said. Last week, the U.S. Treasury imposed new sanctions on companies it said were supporting Mahan, which operates cargo and passenger services.

The U.S. blockade has also hurt Iran’s imports of basic goods, 70% of which normally go through the blockaded ports. Though humanitarian goods



While Saudi Arabia and others find workarounds, bottlenecks are threatening Iran’s economy.

AP

and food are ostensibly exempt, the reality is that shippers are reluctant to service Iran.

Videos posted on social media last week show cranes at the Port of Shahid Rajaee, Iran’s largest commercial container port, at a standstill. Thousands of containers are stranded in ports in Pakistan, the United Arab Emirates and Saudi Arabia, transportation professionals in Tehran last month told the Mehr News Agency, which is affiliated with Iranian security services.

Iran has tried to compensate by pushing more trade through other routes. Transits across the Caspian Sea have grown by 70% in the past five months, according to Iranian officials. Iran imports large quantities of its wheat, corn and cooking oil from Russia, according to commodities data provider Kpler and Iranian trading websites.

“We are trying to turn this threat into an opportunity,” Hadi Haghsheenas, the governor of the Iranian province of Gilan, on the Caspian Sea, told state news agency IRNA in

late August.

A freight railroad from Tehran to Xi’an in eastern China has jumped from once-a-week journeys to every three or four days since the blockade started, according to the state-controlled Tehran Times. Iran imports industrial machinery, electronics and automotive spare parts from China.

But in a sign of how vulnerable the alternative routes are, Iraq over the weekend temporarily closed cargo terminals at the Iran border after alleging Iran had used its territory to

attack Saudi Arabia. On Sunday, trucks carrying Iranian onions bound for Iraq were forced to turn back as a result, according to Tehran’s Central Fruit and Vegetable Market.

Iran’s land borders were a mess before these latest closures, though. This summer, for example, the number of trucks going through Pishin, one of the main crossings into Pakistan, increased from about 40 vehicles to as many as 130 vehicles a day, local gov-

ernor Rahim-bakhsh Balidehei told the semi-official ISNA News Agency. The result is that customs officers across Iran’s land borders are struggling to cope, Ehsan Malekzadeh, chairman of the Iranian International Transport Companies Association, told the Mehr News Agency.

Malekzadeh said 3,700 trucks were stranded on the Iranian side of the crossing to Turkey, with delays reaching 20 days. At the main crossing into Pakistan, 700 trucks—mostly carrying bottled gas and cement—are waiting at any time, but only 40 are allowed to cross, according to the Baloch Human Rights Documentation Network, a local civic group.

One driver told Iran’s official news agency IRNA he was stuck for days at the Pakistan side of the border with meat destined for Iran, where prices are spiraling higher. At the border with Afghanistan, truckers also complain they have to wait for days before being able to export Iranian iron ore, according to Iran’s Truckers’ Union.

Iranian truckers trying to get into Pakistan say they can be stuck for several days without access to water, food or sanitation as temperatures rise to 122 degrees Fahrenheit, according to footage, published by the Truckers’ Union on its social-me-

dia account. The union said some bottled-gas tankers are crossing into Pakistan. But the Pakistani authorities asked Iranian drivers for the equivalent of more than \$10,000 each to cross, an unprecedented amount, it said. A spokesman for Pakistan’s Foreign Ministry said he wasn’t aware of any new charges or restrictions at Pakistan’s border with Iran.

Meanwhile, at the border with Turkmenistan, the gateway to China, transporters

The blockade has also hurt Iran’s imports of basic goods, 70% of which normally go through the blockaded ports

complain of constraints tied to a lack of warehouses and of a proper registration process to bring goods by rail to China. One businessman complained it was increasingly difficult to bring in automotive spare parts from the Asian powerhouse.

The rising costs are now adding to Iran’s worsening inflation problem.

In some cases, the overland bottlenecks and diversions now contribute as much as a third of the price for common goods once they reach Tehran, Mohammad Reza Khodarahm, an import-sector expert, told Iranian economic daily Donya-e-Eqtesad last week. Majidreza Hariri, the president of the Iran-China Chamber of Commerce, earlier predicted that the U.S. naval blockade would cost \$18 billion a year in extra outlays. The cost of transporting one container from China to Iran costs \$12,000 via land routes compared with \$3,000 by sea, he told KhabarOnline, an independent website close to regime moderates.

Much of these costs are being passed on to consumers, with unpredictable results for the Iranian leadership. Food inflation rose to 128% in August, according to Iran’s official statistics office.

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NEWS
NUMBERS

11.3 mn

INDIGO'S SEAT capacity in September, as it remain India's largest airline with an over 50% market share, despite a 4.5% reduction in capacity year-on-year.

6

THE NUMBER of cases of AI misalignment that occurred during model training and evaluation over the past six months at OpenAI, according to the company.

\$9.248 tn

THE AMOUNT of US Treasuries held by foreigners in July, down from \$9.298 trillion in June, led by reduced holdings from Japan and China.

17

THE NUMBER of private sector banks and non-bank financial firms, out of India's 30 leading lenders, that changed CEOs in the 30 months through June, per a study.

58,000

THE NUMBER of Divyangjan and senior citizens who received assistive devices, worth nearly ₹68 crore, at camps at 76 locations across India on Thursday.

HOWINDIALIVES.COM

Jindal Supreme IPO
subscribed 31.5x

The initial public offering of Jindal Supreme (India) Ltd, a manufacturer of plastic piping solutions and related products, was subscribed 31.50 times on the second day of bidding on Thursday.

The company's ₹125 crore IPO received bids for 2,960,44,868 shares against 9,399,600 shares on offer, according to details available with the National Stock Exchange. The retail quota was subscribed 39.74 times, while the non-institutional investors category garnered 37.60 times subscription. The portion for qualified institutional buyers was booked 12.50 times. Jindal Supreme India Ltd has fixed a price band of ₹88-93 per share for the IPO.

The IPO comprises a fresh issue of 10.7 million equity shares, aggregating to nearly ₹100 crore at the upper end of the price band, along with an offer-for-sale of 2.69 million shares by promoter group entity VVJ Enterprise Pvt. Ltd.

PTI

Canada-India trade deal
moves to Mumbai stage

Canada's international trade minister Maninder Sidhu will visit Mumbai on Friday and Saturday to advance negotiations for a proposed Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (Cepa) with India, as the countries seek to conclude the trade pact by the end of this year.

Sidhu is scheduled to meet commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal as well as Indian government officials and business representatives during his visit, according to Global Affairs Canada (Canadian government). The visit comes as India and Canada conduct the fourth round of Cepa negotiations, with the latest round underway this week.

Both sides have set a shared objective of concluding the agreement by the end of 2026.

HARSH KUMAR

NSE's ₹22,569 crore IPO
subscribed 43% on Day 1

The ₹22,569 crore initial public offering of the National Stock Exchange of India (NSE) opened for subscription on Thursday, with the issue getting subscribed 43% on the first day of bidding.

The offering is India's second-largest public issue after Hyundai Motor India's ₹27,870 crore IPO in 2024.

The NSE IPO received bids for 38.3 million shares against 88.6 million on offer, according to data available with the exchanges.

The category for non-institutional investors was subscribed 72%, and the retail portion was booked 44%. The quota for qualified institutional buyers garnered 19% subscription.

NSE on Wednesday raised ₹6,746 crore from anchor investors, including state-owned Life Insurance Corporation of India, Goldman Sachs and Fidelity.

The IPO comprises an offer-for-sale of up to 126.4 million equity shares by existing shareholders.

PTI

Sebi bars Kore, top
execs from markets

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) has barred passive telecom infra provider Kore Digital Ltd and three senior executives from raising funds through public securities offerings, citing prima facie evidence of financial manipulation and misleading disclosures. The three executives have also been restrained from buying, selling or otherwise dealing in Kore Digital securities, directly or indirectly, until further orders.

The interim ex-parte order, issued on Thursday, named Kore Digital alongside managing director Ravindra Doshi, chief executive officer Chaitanya Doshi and chief financial officer Kashmira Doshi. Kore and the other notices have 21 days from receiving the order to file their responses and request a personal hearing. Sebi has ordered a forensic audit of Kore's books from its listing date through 31 March 2026 and will conduct a detailed investigation.

APOORVA AJITH

India proposes mandatory
CCTVs at medical stores

Move aimed at enhancing transparency, accountability across pharma supply chain

Priyanka Sharma

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NEW DELHI

India plans to mandate CCTV surveillance at retail medical stores to curb the unauthorized sale of prescription medicines. The measure has been proposed through an amendment to the Drugs Rules, 1945, in a draft gazette notification issued on 8 September, the health ministry said on Thursday.

The ministry has invited comments from stakeholders and the public for 30 days from the date of announcement. *Mint* reported on this development in July last year.

The proposed amendment seeks to tighten oversight of Schedule H, H1 and X drugs and prevent their sale without valid prescriptions. Recommended by the Drugs Technical Advisory Board (DTAB) following deliberations by the Drugs Consultative Committee (DCC), CCTV surveillance is intended to improve transparency and accountability in retail pharmacy operations.

The amendment was introduced "with the objective of strengthening regulatory oversight over Schedule H, H1 and X drugs," the health ministry said on Thursday. The ministry said the draft rules address existing compliance issues in retail pharmacy operations.

"The proposed amendment seeks to address concerns relating to unauthorized access to and sale of Schedule H, H1 and X



AFP

drugs and recommends mandatory CCTV surveillance at medical stores as an additional regulatory safeguard," the ministry said.

Schedule H drugs must be sold on a valid prescription from a registered medical practitioner and must display the Rx symbol. These drugs include blood pressure and diabetes medicines, certain antibiotics and basic psychiatric drugs. Schedule H1 drugs come under a stricter category of medicines. They need a

prescription, and chemists are required to maintain a log of the patients, the prescribing doctor, and the details of the drug for three years. These medicines include some habit-forming drugs and advanced antibiotics.

Schedule X drugs include narcotics and psychotropics such as morphine, which can easily be abused and lead to addiction.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](https://www.livemint.com).

HC: Gillette can
have posts deleted

The Delhi High Court (HC) has allowed Gillette India to ask influencers to take down posts in which they shared an advertisement by Bombay Shaving Co. targeting a rival.

On Wednesday, the court had asked Bombay Shaving Co. to take down the advertisement and submit a revised version without showing the court setting and referring to the competitor.

During the hearing, Gillette's counsel pointed to "follow-up social media posts of other influencers who have discussed this ad" and sought directions for their removal.

The judge, however, did not immediately grant a blanket direction to social media intermediaries. Instead, the court asked Gillette to first approach the concerned intermediaries. "You write to them to take it down, and if they don't, then you come back," Justice Jyoti Singh told Gillette.

BSC's counsel told the court that the revised version complied with the directions given earlier and that references to the court and other material that had to be removed had been deleted.

NEETHI LISA ROJAN & YASH TIWARI

Tata Trusts cry foul as Chandra wins new term

FROM PAGE 1

and other stakeholders on applicable compliance requirements."

The conflict holds deep implications for Tata Sons' mandate to go public, the Shapoorji Pallonji Group's hopes to reduce debt, and future relationship between the philanthropic bodies and the business conglomerate.

Tata Trusts termed the resolution illegal. "The resolution seeking to reappoint Mr. N. Chandrasekaran in the board meeting today, with four directors voting in favour, and Mr Noel Tata against, was a legal nullity in view of the provisions of the Articles of Association of Tata Sons," it said.

The Trusts said the process "requires a majority of the Trusts' nominee directors voting in favour of the resolution," and "applies equally to a first appointment and to reappointing someone who already holds the office." The board, it argued, "cannot lawfully hold a meeting or pass a resolution on the chairman's appointment or reappointment unless both nominee directors are present, and cannot validly pass such a resolution unless both nominee directors vote in favour. Given that Mr Noel Tata, being one of the Trust nominee directors, voted against the proposal, it was rendered legally void and without any basis."



Directors voted to grant chairman N. Chandrasekaran a five-year extension in the face of objections by Noel Tata.

REUTERS

In a statement to the board, Tata cast the reappointment as an attempt to reverse a settled decision. He said Chandrasekaran had written to the board on 12 August that he would not seek a further term—"That was his own decision".

Meanwhile, Tata Sons said its board had received the Trusts' "unanimous resolution dated July 28, 2025 expressing their appreciation of the chairmanship of Tata Sons... for his stewardship of the group from 2017 onwards," recommending a fresh term, and had "agreed in principle" in September 2025. But "in February 2026, in the absence of unanimity, the resolution was deferred for decision," and in "May 2026 and June 2026, this matter was discussed but was not resolved," it said.

Under Section 121 of the

Tata Sons articles of association, a majority vote of the Tata Trustees' nominees is needed to appoint and reappoint Chandrasekaran. Since Noel voted against and Srinivasan voted in favour of third term, the vote deadlocked.

As Chandrasekaran was an "interested party", he refused himself from the proceedings of this crucial resolution, according to an executive privy to the development. Tata Sons chair of the nomination and remuneration panel Harish Manwani presided over the resolution to grant a new term to the Tata Sons chair.

Manwani, as the chairman of this resolution, cast the deciding vote to break the deadlock and grant Chandrasekaran a new stint, the executive said on the condition of anonymity.

"How do you expect to fight with the largest shareholder and operate your businesses effectively?" wondered Amit Tandon, founder and managing director at proxy advisor Institutional Investor Advisory Services. "Multiple decisions would need the approval of Trusts. The appointment of chairman as director, the capital allocation policy, the remuneration of Tata Sons chair, and so on."

"There has to be alignment between the executive management and the owner. In the context of Tata, there is an even

greater risk of an impact on the performance of the Tata Group operating companies," said Tandon.

Some found merit in independent directors backing Chandrasekaran.

"Assume that the independent directors of Tata Sons took this decision in the interest of the company and the Tata Group. Noel Tata has not explained how his decision is for the broader good of the company and the group. So, it seems like the wishes of one person. It is a good thing that the directors have stood up to the promoter's wishes," said Sanjay Kallapur, professor of accounting, Indian School of Business, and an independent director on the board of IDBI Bank. "It is a sign of maturing

corporate governance in India".

The deadlock could hardly come at a worse time. On 11 September, the RBI rejected Tata Sons' bid to shed its core-investment company tag, which implies a listing mandate. A holding company that cannot lawfully confirm who leads it cannot file a prospectus.

Anxiety runs deep at the Shapoorji Pallonji Group, Tata Sons' largest minority holder with about 18.4% stake. The group is struggling to service crushing debt—some ₹3,500 crore due by end-September and roughly ₹11,275 crore over 24 months—and is banking on a listing or a negotiated liquidity event to unlock a stake it cannot otherwise sell.

"The conflict will unfortunately lead to a governance issue because personalities and conflicts will tend to overshadow the interests of the companies below and obviously, minority shareholders holding shares in those companies will be impacted," said Ketan Dalal, the managing partner at Catalyst Advisors LLP, a boutique business advisory and structuring firm. Dalal explained how Tata Sons' funding to privately held businesses would get impacted.

Nehal Chaliawala in Mumbai contributed to this story. varun.sood@livemint.com

Since Noel Tata voted against and trustee-nominee Venu Srinivasan voted in favour of third term, the vote deadlocked

Exports of larger passenger
vehicles pip cars so far FY27

FROM PAGE 1

all passenger vehicle exports from India with a share of 51.8% during April-August 2026 (as per Siam data) but also has a commanding presence in the UV space with a 57% share, reflecting how much Maruti's UVs are loved by consumers across the world," Rahul Bharti, senior executive officer at Maruti Suzuki, said in response to *Mint*'s queries.

The gap between utility vehicles, including Fronx, Exter and Jimny, and smaller passenger cars such as i20, Verna and WagonR has narrowed over the past two years, with the former taking a lead of almost 50,000 units in the current fiscal year.

Passenger vehicle exports rose 18% to 905,200 units in FY26, with passenger cars holding a 49.6% share with 449,279 units, while utility vehicles held a 49.2% share in total exports with 445,152 units.

Top industry executives and observers noted that the share of SUVs has risen in both the domestic and global markets, changing the product mix and helping carmakers capture more value from export of larger vehicles that typically cost more.

The shift is even more pro-



Share of SUVs has risen in both domestic and global markets.

nounced in the domestic market. Utility vehicles accounted for almost 67% of India's passenger-vehicle sales in FY26, with over 3.1 million units sold compared with 1.37 million passenger cars, according to SIAM. The growing preference for SUVs at home is now increasingly being mirrored in overseas markets.

Bharti of Maruti said the firm has steadily raised exports in recent years, with global sales of 17 models spanning hatchbacks, sedans, SUVs, MPVs, vans and an LCV to about 120 destinations.

Hyundai Motor India managing director and chief executive officer Tarun Garg said in an emailed response to *Mint* that there is growing demand for the company's SUVs, which will drive the share of

these vehicles up in its overall overseas sales mix. "The growing preference for SUV is reflected in broader industry export trends, with utility vehicle exports continuing to gain share within India's overall passenger vehicle export mix. We expect this momentum to continue, supported by sustained demand across multiple export markets," he said.

Hyundai's utility vehicle exports fell 7% to 12,310 units in April-August while its passenger cars exports slid 13% to 58,948 units, thereby increasing the share of UVs to 17%.

The decline in the company's exports was largely due to disruptions in trade routes and schedules owing to the West Asia war and a fire at a key supplier.

Nissan's India unit was the second-largest exporter of utility vehicles in India in FY26, with 56,712 UV units making 68% of its export mix.

The share of Nissan's utility vehicle exports went up to 87% in the April-to-August period with 20,301 units shipped overseas.

"We expect SUVs to become an increasingly significant part of Nissan's exports," a Nissan Motor spokesperson said. "Nissan remains focused on expanding the scale and international reach of its made-in-India vehicles."

WILL HYROX OOZE MONEY FOR ITS INDIAN BACKER?

Yoska Technology Solutions, the event's organizer in India, is trying to build a business around the format

Vaeshnavi Kasthuril
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BENGALURU

Sameeha Mariam, 24, spends most evenings running through Adyar in south Chennai. A content creator and now a law student, Mariam began running with her friends three years ago. At the time, she was navigating some professional frustrations; others often got credit for her work and running offered something different. "It was all me. Nobody could attribute it to anyone else," she said.

Running eventually led her to swimming, cycling, marathons, triathlons and, finally, Hyrox, a fitness race she has competed in twice, in the mixed-doubles category. The fitness format also changed the content she made, with her videos increasingly focusing on training, runs, workouts and race preparation.

In Mumbai, Varun Duggirala, also a content creator, took up Hyrox almost entirely for health reasons. For the 44-year-old entrepreneur, staying fit had meant lifting weights. Running was never really his thing. After becoming a father, he wanted the strength and endurance to carry his daughter everywhere, walk long distances, lift luggage and pick up a sleeping child without feeling exhausted.

Duggirala signed up for his first Hyrox almost on a whim and trained for 34 weeks. He finished in 2 hours and 14 minutes. "I was never an athlete. That was actually the first competitive sports thing I had done in my life, and I did that at the age of 43," he said. In the next race, he brought his time down to 2 hours and 4 minutes. In his latest race, he finished in 2:00:45. His daughter was holding the timer that day.

Mariam and Duggirala's stories offer a glimpse into a broader shift in India's fitness economy, where consumers are moving beyond the traditional gym for structured, goal-oriented exercise.

Hyrox is emerging as one of the most popular fitness-racing formats in this space, alongside established formats such as CrossFit, Devil's Circuit and obstacle-course races, as well as endurance events such as marathons, triathlons and Ironman.

These formats cater to different kinds of fitness enthusiasts. CrossFit combines strength, conditioning and functional movements through varied workouts, while Devil's Circuit and other obstacle-course races test participants through running, climbing, crawling and other physical challenges. Marathons are built primarily around running endurance, while triathlons combine swimming, cycling and running. The Ironman contest takes the triathlon format further, with a 1.9-km swim, 90-km bike ride and a 21.1-km run.

Hyrox sits in the sweet spot between the gym and endurance-sports worlds. Christian Toetzkke, Moritz Fürste and Michael Trautmann launched the indoor fitness race, which combines eight 1-km runs with eight intense workouts, in Hamburg, Germany in 2017.

Since then, the event has exploded in popularity all over the world, especially in China, where there are more than 500 gyms affiliated with Hyrox today, less than two years since its November 2024 launch, according to the *Xinhua* news agency. Globally, Hyrox now has more than 1.5 million participants annually across more than 100 cities in 35-plus countries.

What makes Hyrox appealing is the combination of gym workouts, including

The Hyrox format is standardized, with the same distances and loads across cities, allowing someone racing in India to compare time with participants elsewhere in the world.

another race to see whether they have become faster or stronger.

The intensity of the challenge and the competitive spirit it generates was on full display at Hyrox Beijing last week when Australian athlete Joanna Wietrzyk refused to give up despite suffering severe gastrointestinal distress and went on to win the women's pro event with a timing of 1:01:23. Her messy path to victory, however, led to a heated debate, prompting Fürste to apologize and promise rule changes.

THE INDIA SPRINT

In India, too, the speed at which Hyrox has grown is striking. Launched only in 2025, the event had a modest beginning with 1,650 participants at its Mumbai debut and 3,350 showing up for the second Mumbai edition.

That headcount more than doubled at the Bengaluru event in April, which saw



(Clockwise from top) Participants in a battle-rope competition at a Hyrox event; Varun Duggirala performs a sled push in Hyrox Delhi; participants cheer and support competitors during a Hyrox event.



HYROX MUMBAI, HYROX INDIA

more than 8,200 participants flock to the arena from more than 170 towns and cities. The subsequent edition in Delhi, a three-day affair held in July, had more than 10,000 athletes taking part. The next race is being held in Mumbai this week, from 17-20 September.

Hyrox entered India through a partnership between Hyrox World GmbH, the global rightsholder, and Bengaluru-based Yoska Technology Solutions Pvt. Ltd, led by chief executive, co-founder and chief coach Deepak Raj. The company is also the franchise owner and strategic partner for Ironman in India. Raj also serves as the country head of Hyrox India.

In India, Hyrox is trying to become more than just a race. While cricket dominates the country's sports business, individual sports such as badminton, tennis and running have also built commercial properties. Hyrox is attempting to carve out a similar space for fitness racing, building a business around what happens before, during and after the race.

"This is a participative sport. The goal is to make it a spectator sport on par with cricket," Raj said.

BUILDING AWARENESS

The first challenge for the Yoska team was explaining Hyrox, because awareness was low. The company used footage from international races to promote the event, but Raj sought more—he wanted people to experience the contest rather than simply watching videos.

At a health and fitness expo in Mumbai in 2025, Yoska built a 350-square-metre "Mini Hyrox". There was no running, but participants moved through scaled-down versions of the functional stations while judges recorded their times. About 500 people showed up. "And we got content," Raj said.

Indeed, Hyrox is a "very content-friendly

sport". At a marathon, runners and spectators are distributed across a city. Hyrox puts them inside an arena. They can film training sessions, simulations, race-day performances and finishing times. That content attracts more participants, while spectators can eat, shop, interact with sponsors and decide if they want to participate the next time.

Globally, Hyrox generated about €135 million in revenue in 2025 and expects revenue to approach €300 million in 2026, co-founder and chief executive Christian Toetzkke told *The Economic Times*. He estimated that India contributes €4-5 million (₹44-55 crore) annually to Hyrox's global business.

In India, the business operates as a joint venture between Hyrox and Yoska, Raj said. He expects Hyrox to account for around 60% of business this year, with five Hyrox events planned against three Ironman events. Rainmatter, the investment arm of online brokerage Zerodha, invested about \$460,000 in Yoska in March 2025, giving it an 11.96% stake in the company, according to data platform Tracxn. The investment was part of Yoska's second funding round, a \$511,000 seed round that also included Sonicorn Ventures and angel investors.

In India, Hyrox has four main revenue streams: tickets, sponsorships, merchandise and gym affiliations, said Raj. He added that the Bengaluru event broke even on ticket sales alone.

Hyrox is also building a network of affiliated gyms, using existing fitness facilities to expand its training ecosystem without having to build dedicated centres. These gyms do not need to replicate the full race setup. Instead, they use equipment such as sleds, SkiErgs, rowers, weights and wall balls, along with treadmills or available running space, to offer Hyrox-specific training and simulations.

The affiliation gives gyms access to Hyrox's training programmes and other resources, while giving members a structured pathway to prepare for the races. Yoska charges an annual franchise fee of

KEY NUMBERS

10,000

Number of athletes who participated in the Hyrox event in Delhi, which was held over three days in July.

12,000

Number of spectators at the Bengaluru Hyrox event in April. Delhi had 10,000-15,000 attendees.

500

Number of gyms affiliated with Hyrox in China today, less than two years since its November 2024 launch, as per *Xinhua*.

about ₹60,000 for its athlete-gym affiliation, according to Saurabh Aggarwal, founder of Hyfit, a hybrid fitness club in Bengaluru and an angel investor in Yoska.

Ticketing remains the backbone. A Hyrox entry in India costs about ₹8,000 before taxes and charges. Participants can compete individually, in Open or Pro categories, or enter doubles and relay formats. Spectators are becoming part of the story, too. In Bengaluru, nearly 12,000 came to watch, Raj said, while Delhi drew 10,000-15,000 spectators. Tickets for spectators are sold separately, with tickets for the Mumbai event this weekend priced at ₹678, including GST, before service fees.

The first three Hyrox events in India had no title partner, so ticket sales accounted for most of the event revenue, with smaller contributions from an insurance partner and associate sponsors. That is beginning to change, as brands increasingly seek partnerships with the fitness-racing property. Masters' Union became a title partner for the Delhi and Mumbai events. "Hyrox is not an obvious partnership for a business school, which is what made it interesting to us," said Ananya Dengri, brand manager at Masters' Union. The partnership focused on brand building rather than admissions or lead generation. It also gave Masters' Union's student ventures access to a large consumer platform. Startups, including perfume brand Khet and Eat Atlas, showcased products at the event, while more than 40 students worked with the Hyrox team across operations, logistics, sponsorships and participant experience.

Fast&Up's chief executive Vijayraghavan Venugopal, whose company has been the energy-drink and hydration partner for multiple running events over the years, said participative sports allow brands to stay with consumers through their fitness journey. Merchandise is another revenue stream, with Puma selling a dedicated Hyrox range in India. Prices start at ₹3,499 for a graphic

T-shirt and go up to ₹21,999 for Hyrox-specific running shoes, according to the sportswear company's official website.

SECOND-ORDER EFFECTS

Hyxox's initial success has encouraged attempts to create copycats and chase a long tail of fitness spending around the event.

Aggarwal's Hyfit is trying to build a business that appeals to athletes interested in Hyrox for a shorter period. He converted a 150-year-old rubber factory into a gym, putting a running track around the building so members could train for the event. Hyfit charges ₹10,000 a month or ₹45,000 annually. It has 10-12 trainers and runs around six Hyrox classes a day alongside other programmes. The gym is profitable, Aggarwal said, but keeping members for the long term remains difficult.

CrossFit, another fitness format, has suffered a decline in popularity with Hyrox stealing the limelight. CrossFit is built around strength, endurance, gymnastics, plyometrics (explosive movements that stretch and then rapidly contract muscles to build power) and Olympic lifting.

Ashutosh Bhosle, who has run a CrossFit-affiliated gym in Mumbai since 2015, says Mumbai had around 10 CrossFit affiliates when he started but estimates only three remain. Membership at his own gym is around 25-30% below pre-covid levels. Consumers now have more choices, including running clubs, swimming, triathlon, Hyrox and other participative sports, he said.

Still, Bhosle is sceptical about Hyrox's staying power. "Hyrox is a fad," he said, adding that its standardized format could eventually make it repetitive.

Yoska itself has been experimenting with No Parking, a more accessible fitness-race format aimed at people who find Hyrox intimidating. "The idea came from feedback that Hyrox could look too difficult for people who were not already serious about fitness," said Dilip Kumar, who leads investments at Yoska backer Rainmatter. For its first edition in Bengaluru, Yoska took the event into a mall parking area, creating a shorter format combining running with functional exercises. About 1,000 people took part.

Hyfit Games is doing something similar. Aggarwal launched the event as a shorter, cheaper version of the Hyrox product. It has held six to seven editions, with recent events in Mumbai and Bengaluru attracting more than 1,500 participants each. Entry costs around ₹2,000 and the course takes roughly 20 minutes to complete.

Yoska is also experimenting with ways to make Hyrox more watchable. Its "Battle of the Gyms" pits mixed-doubles teams representing Hyrox Training Clubs against one another, with gyms competing head-to-head in strength and endurance.

Hyrox India has livestreamed the competition on its YouTube channel, using rankings, statistics and graphic overlays to make the action easier for viewers to follow. Kumar said the company is also in talks with Amazon Prime Video to potentially broadcast Hyrox events in India.

This comes as India's fitness economy expands beyond the traditional gym. Run clubs have mushroomed across cities, while Pilates, swimming, strength training and functional fitness are attracting consumers seeking more social, goal-oriented ways to exercise. New-age businesses such as The Vault and Game Theory are building communities around specific activities,

while Cult.fit's proposed ₹3,500-4,000 crore IPO signals growing commercialization.

The broader fitness market was worth ₹16,200 crore in 2024 and is projected to reach ₹37,700 crore by 2030, at a compound annual growth rate of 15%, according to Deloitte India and the Health & Fitness Association. Boutique fitness is expected to be the fastest-growing segment,

with revenue projected to rise at an 18.8% CAGR to ₹3,100 crore by 2030.

Yet challenges remain. Finding venues is becoming harder, and Raj said India does not yet have enough large indoor spaces to support Hyrox's ambition of reaching 15 cities.

For now, Hyrox's growing global calendar gives it an advantage over other fitness-race formats. There are over 100 Hyrox races around the world each year, creating a near-continuous stream of events and social-media content.

Kumar believes the opportunity goes beyond replicating Hyrox, because consumers who have embraced one fitness format are increasingly ready to try the next. "They are ready. They would want something else. And this is a good time to build new fitness and sports formats," he said. (The fitness format is officially stylized as HYROX.)



Utility tech: how AI, cloud storage are driving up monthly budgets

Digital tools are finding a place in household budgets as users weigh productivity gains against subscription cost

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MUMBAI

Just as a few newer spends like OTT video streaming services have moved from optional spends to standard household line items over the past decade, a new category of recurring spending is taking root: technology utilities. These expenses fall into two categories: expanded cloud storage, such as Apple iCloud, Google One, Dropbox and Microsoft OneDrive, and premium artificial intelligence (AI) productivity subscriptions such as Claude Pro and ChatGPT Plus.

India ranks second globally in overall Claude AI usage, according to the Anthropic Economic Index.

Heavy AI usage remains concentrated among developers and IT professionals, but the broader demand for cloud storage spans every age group, from college students backing up device media to senior citizens saving family photos. This story zooms in on the kinds of spending professionals are regularly making on AI tools and storage, expert views on what free versions offer, and tips to ensure that the spend on utility tech stays in check and justified.

Fixed outflow

For T. Pranav, 24, a growth consultant at Zomato in Chennai, software subscriptions have shifted from hesitant purchases to fixed outflows. He spends about ₹2,300 a month on Claude Pro, Apple iCloud and Google Drive, viewing the recurring expense as essential to his daily output. "Earlier, I used to hesitate or think twice before spending on software subscriptions. Today, it has shifted into a non-negotiable, almost like a mandatory monthly bill," Pranav said. For his work, which includes developing pitch decks and generating real-time dashboards, the financial trade-off is straightforward. "The time saved is incredible; tasks that previously took me a full day now take an hour or less. The ROI is undeniable."

Pranav also pointed to price anchoring, where providers set a base-tier price and position a slightly more expensive tier as offering a disproportionately larger jump in capability. The small price gap can nudge users to upgrade without assessing the value of each feature.

"AI subscriptions and storage are no longer optional discretionary expenses; they are directly tied to an individual's personal output capacity. When a tool multiplies your speed, software becomes an essential investment," Pranav added.

Fitness trainer Rahul Kumar, 24, sees consumer technology becoming a growing monthly expense, with spends of ₹3,000-5,000 across Apple iCloud, Google One and ChatGPT for client workout schedules, progress tracking and media management.

Managing the new tech utility budget: spend on tools that add value

As payments for extra storage and AI subscriptions become part of family budgets, here are ways to manage digital utility outflows.

New expense head



Intangible tech utilities: Buying extra storage and AI Pro tools has become a recurring expense.



Spending: Typically ranges from ₹500-5,000 a month across multiple software subscriptions.



Demand for storage spans all age groups, while demand for AI Pro tools depends on individual needs.



Pricing: Platforms price premium tiers only slightly higher than base tiers, nudging users to upgrade.

Consumer views



T PRANAV (24)

Growth consultant at Zomato, Chennai

"I used to hesitate to spend on software subscriptions. Now, they have become like a mandatory monthly bill."



RAHUL KUMAR (25)

Fitness trainer, Mumbai

"I've been buying extra storage for almost seven years now, as it helps me hold on to older data on my devices."



DARREL LOPEZ (27)

IT infrastructure engineer, Kochi

"An AI Pro subscription is only worth it if I use it consistently, improves my work or saves me effort."



Free vs paid

Data cost: Free AI tools explicitly state that uploaded content is used for model training.

Paid advantage: Premium tiers typically offer greater processing power, fewer hallucinations and better data security.

Planner's tips

- ▶ **Auto-debits:** Never leave tech subscriptions on automatic debit without periodic reviews.
- ▶ **Bundle overlap:** Pick one core AI tool or storage bundle best suited to your workflow.
- ▶ **Output:** Ensure the subscription frees up time or enhances income-generating capacity.
- ▶ **Financial data:** Never upload bank statements, identity proof, or financial records to free AI models.

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amounts, he added. For this segment, software has become a daily essential.

"It's becoming much like paying for your electricity every month, or any other utility. And the right word to use is utility, because this is becoming a utility for most of the people in this segment," he said.

Mindful spending

From a financial planning standpoint, the rise of tech utilities calls for careful and mindful spending.

Vivek S.G., founder, Wealth Crafts, a financial planning platform, observed that individuals are increasingly allocating funds specifically for AI tools because opting out creates a distinct competitive disadvantage in workplace productivity. At the same time, cloud storage has become a necessity across generations, including services like Apple iCloud, Google Drive, Dropbox, and Microsoft OneDrive. "For example, my parents, who are in their early 70s, are fond of pictures, and their storage is always full. They have ended up paying for storage," Vivek shared.

He flagged privacy and financial risks associated with free AI tiers. "If you are using some of these AI tools that are free, they explicitly say that all your content would be used for training. Today, people are uploading bank statements, personal, and financial data to categorize expenses. You are giving a detailed history of where you are spending, and you don't know who can get access to it tomorrow. That comes at a huge risk."

To control digital utility budgets without compromising privacy, Vivek advised users not to allow subscriptions to run on automatic debit without periodic reviews. "Paying \$20 to \$100 (₹1,500-over ₹8,000) per month across multiple tools is a lot of money spent if the software isn't actively generating value or saving time," he explained.

Users should also avoid subscribing to multiple overlapping tools across different providers, especially given the bundling that providers offer. Vivek called for identifying the specific AI tool best suited for your work and sticking strictly to that single bundle. "Pro subscriptions make financial sense only if the time saved translates into enhanced income-generating capacity or frees up your time. If an upgrade fails to justify its monthly cost through utility, downgrade or cancel immediately," he said.

As digital tools become regular budget items, managing their costs means prioritising high-utility services, avoiding redundant bundles and reviewing auto-debit subscriptions.



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POWER
POINT

DEEPAK SHENOY

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LOW-COST INDEX FUNDS: WHY A 2 BPS UPI FEE IS TOO HIGH

You will start to see merchants paying a fee (merchant discount rate, MDR) to receive money in transactions above ₹2,000 from 15 October. Merchants will pay 0.40% of a transaction. But certain merchants will pay less. Insurance, for example, pays a flat ₹5 per transaction. Lumpsum investments into mutual funds made through UPI will be charged 0.02% (2 basis points, bps), which the fund house might need to bear. Brokers too will pay a similar 0.02% on inflows that use UPI.

Fair disclosure: we run a mutual fund, so assume bias. The problem isn't that asset management companies must bear this cost—it's that the cost of incremental investment in a fund is very high for a low-cost fund. Many low-cost index funds charge 10 to 20 bps as management fees, and 2 bps is a very high fee to bear for these transactions. The larger funds will be fine since their incremental flows are tiny compared to the fund itself, but for smaller funds, the burden is greater.

Stockbrokers must return clients' cash balances every three months under regulations. Investors then send that money back via UPI, costing brokers ₹20 per lakh. If they don't transact, or make only a few trades where brokerage earnings total ₹20 or less, the broker makes no profit. As a result, brokers might eventually charge an additional fee for UPI transactions, as could mutual funds. Investors can instead use NEFT or RTGS, which typically take a couple of hours and cost nothing, as mandated by the Reserve Bank of India.

Keep the fee lower

It would be better to keep the fee lower, at ₹2 per transaction, around what fund houses absorb right now. This will ensure fund houses do not pass costs to fund investors. Sebi's limits on fees do not cover these other costs, so this fee is chargeable to investors without limits. (Management fees have lower ceilings as assets under management increase.) Am I against MDR completely?

Philosophically, I am because UPI discourages cash, creates bank account history for formal credit, and has high trust. And banks earn the biggest amount from this money by having larger current account balances than usual and have the ability to do far better credit underwriting for merchants. If anything, the banks should pay part of the profits they earn to the app ecosystem (which currently earns little directly, but does also earn income from sources like lending, selling other investments and so on—the UPI payment is a loss leader). But let me give in to say, alright, charge a little for a relatively small subset. The argument that the cost of innovation needs money doesn't really warrant a percentage of transaction. Technology costs should come down as transactions grow. A flat fee—₹2 per transaction—is a better way to encourage UPI in investments, just as a flat brokerage has improved transactions in the stock markets.

Compare the credit card players, where charges are 2% to merchants—but this comes with an underwriting risk that the end-user doesn't pay (issuing bank takes the risk). There is no such risk underwritten in UPI—it's an instant movement from one account to another. And then, in credit cards, the underlying infrastructure is built by the card networks, who charge part of the fee.

Economies of scale

NPCI, which runs the entire system of UPI, IMPS, NACH, Fastag and so on, has built that infrastructure for the banks and the apps themselves, which comes in at a much lower fee to the industry. Besides, the economies of scale need to be passed to the consumer. Investors in mutual funds might not see much of a difference as of today, as UPI forms a very small part of the transactions made. (Retail inflows are usually substantially net banking, UPI Autopay, which is not under MDR at all, NEFT/RTGS or bank mandates.)

Stockbrokers, however, seem to have a much larger share of UPI-based inflows and they will likely add charges. If we don't want to see "additional charges to use UPI," we should keep the costs a fixed amount, not a percentage of transaction.

Deepak Shenoy is CEO, Capitalmind Mutual Fund.

'Stronger secondary market key to unlocking retail bond potential'

Apurva Sharma
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Bonds are gaining traction among retail investors as online bond platform providers (OBPP) expand access, with monthly turnover of over ₹2,000 crore, Suresh Darak, founder, FixedAlpha.com, said. He also shared his views on the market's growth, bond yields, investor risks and why a strong secondary market could drive the next phase of retail participation. *Edited excerpts:*

Have OBPPs helped boost retail bond participation?

OBPPs have played a key role in educating retail investors about bonds. Before their emergence, retail bond turnover was estimated at around ₹100 crore a month. Today, it has expanded to over ₹2,000 crore a month, reflecting growing investor awareness, improved digital access and greater availability of fixed-income products. With the market witnessing strong month-on-month growth, potentially approaching 10% in certain periods, we believe monthly retail bond turnover has the

potential to reach ₹10,000 crore over the next few years.

Should investors seek 9-14% bond yields when debt is meant to offer stability?

Can you tell an investor that they should buy only Nifty 50 stocks, BSE Sensex stocks or blue-chips? No. Investors also buy small-cap stocks and various products based on the risk appetite. Similarly, in bonds, borrowers range from AAA to BBB. Within that, there are high-quality borrowers who may be borrowing at 8%, while others are borrowing at 12-13%. Investors have a choice to buy bonds based on their risk appetite and return they are looking for. There is a well-established ecosystem when it comes to bonds—rating agencies that rate bonds, debenture trustees that hold securities and exchanges where they are listed. The system is strong and investors have access to information that help them make an informed decision about which bonds to buy.

What products do these platforms offer?

Broadly, there are two types of bonds: government bonds, which are sovereign securities issued by the central or state

governments and do not carry credit risk in the same way as corporate bonds. The second is corporate bonds, which are issued by companies raising money from the market. There are also variations of these products, such as securitized instruments, where various receivables from a particular category of lending, for example, housing loans, are pooled together. However, investors should have at least seen one complete cycle of 2-3 years to understand how bond markets function, because evaluating some of these products needs deeper expertise. From a retail investor's perspective, it is better to focus on direct bonds, such as government and corporate bonds, rather than products that require a deeper understanding of securitization structures.

How are bond interest rates determined?

The issuer's pricing is determined by several parameters. One is the issuer's credit rating. For example, there will be a difference between a AAA-rated bond and an AA- or BBB-rated bond. Assume a AAA-rated 10-year bond is currently quoted at 8%. AA-rated bond may be available closer to 9%, with about 1 percentage point



reflecting the difference in credit risk. The second factor is tenure. If the same corporate is borrowing for one year versus 10 years, there will be a difference in the interest rate. This could be around 50 basis points, depending on market conditions. There can also be a difference between the primary and secondary markets. A bond offered at 8% in the primary market, for instance, may subsequently trade at 7.9% or 8.1% in the secondary market.

What should retail investors check before buying higher-yielding bonds?

First, try to buy bonds of companies that are well

researched in the market. Second, read the credit-rating rationale and other available information about the issuer.

When it comes to higher-yielding bonds offering 11%, 12% or 13%, investors should understand why the yield is higher. Since the company is rated by an external rating agency, the rating rationale can provide some information about the company's financial position and risks. If an investor is considering a bond offering 12%, 13% or 14%, one approach is to opt for a shorter tenure, say one or two years, rather than locking in money for a very long period.

Do high yields signal risk?

I would not say that a higher yield necessarily means the bond is very risky. In some cases, it can be, but in other cases, investors may be compensated for a particular risk that they have understood through their own research. The warning signal is not necessarily the higher interest rate itself. The warning signal is investing without reading

A developed secondary market allows efficient buying and selling of bonds, just as with equities

Suresh Darak
Founder, FixedAlpha

Why do some bonds offer higher yields than others?

There are typically a few categories of companies that may offer higher yields. First, companies that have recently entered a business may have lower ratings until their business stabilizes. It can take three to five years for a new business to establish itself, and rating agencies may take time to upgrade the rating. Such

companies may therefore have higher borrowing costs.

Second, certain sectors are considered relatively riskier, such as real estate. Companies in these sectors may have lower ratings and consequently offer higher interest rates. Third, there may be situations where a company has adequate security but the particular borrowing is not

typically financed by banks. For example, if a company is acquiring another company, there may be security available, but banks may not be permitted to finance that particular type of borrowing. The company may therefore raise money through the bond market at a higher rate.

These are typically some of the situations in which retail investors may see higher-yielding bonds. Over time, if the company performs well, its borrowing cost and bond yield can come down. For instance, a bond yielding 13% today could potentially yield 11% after three years if the company's

financial position and credit profile improve. Once investors have more information and greater understanding of the company, they can reassess the investment and its risk.

What innovation is needed in the bond market?

Today, much of the bond market functions almost like a buy-and-hold-to-maturity market. One of the biggest features of bonds, however, is that they are tradable instruments, and this aspect has not been fully exploited. The secondary market is extremely important. In any capital market, whether equity or bonds, a developed secondary market supports the primary market. Once the secondary market develops, it can lead to more primary issuances and potentially greater retail participation.

Secondary-market development is not just about buying bonds; it is about being able to buy and sell them efficiently, just as investors do with equities. That should be the benchmark. An important development is that equity brokers are increasingly offering bonds alongside equities through their capital-market platforms. This can make the transition between equity and bonds more seamless for investors.



OUR VIEW



BLOOMBERG

Fed hike plus tariff risk spell a double whammy

While the US Fed's assertion of independence is welcome, its rate hike dims the relative appeal of Indian assets—unless RBI follows suit. America's new tariff threat is trickier to deal with

The US Federal Reserve's 12-member rate-setting committee voted unanimously to hike its policy rate by a quarter of a percentage point and signalled the likelihood of a similar upmove later. No relief from inflation amid firm economic growth and rising geopolitical tensions had made tighter credit in America a foregone conclusion, but it was widely seen as a test of Fed independence, given President Donald Trump's repeated public calls for rate cuts, the very opposite. On this subject, Trump's appointed Fed chair Kevin Warsh had this to say: "Part of the independence of the Federal Reserve is we stay in our lane. Independence is a two-way street. We will let people that do trade policy and fiscal policy stay in their lane." That the Fed acted decisively to protect the US economy from politics is a relief from a global perspective. After all, sound monetary policy underpins confidence in the dollar and US bonds, both of which have key roles in the world of finance. Alas, the hike could also draw capital out of India. Together with a new American tariff threat, we face a double whammy of risk.

With the Fed's quarter-point move, the federal funds target rate of interest climbs to 3.75%-4%. Its aim is to make borrowing costlier and thus temper both retail and corporate spending, a cool-off demanded by inflation at 3.4% in August, and that too, after half a decade of running above its 2% target. Some of it is self-inflicted, traceable to Trump's sweeping tariffs and the oil shock of the US's war against Iran, with lax fiscal policy playing a role, but the fallout on capital costs was unavoidable. Unfortunately for India, upped US rates raise the relative appeal of dollar-debt returns, as

their rise squeezes the premium paid by rupee bonds, as seen in their rate gap. The US 10-year Treasury bond yields around 5% now, while India's 10-year sovereign paper trades just under 7.1%. In general, such a narrow spread is observed to draw foreign money out of local assets, equities included. The Reserve Bank of India (RBI), though, is well armed with a recent stack-up of foreign-exchange reserves to stave off any threat to rupee stability that may arise from outflows. Should RBI hike its own policy rate, it would neutralize the rate-gap effect. Domestic inflation risks that look like more than mere flickers would argue for the same.

The other news from America that has made policymakers sit up is a US bill okayed by its Congress that hands Trump the power to slap imports from India with fresh tariffs of up to 100% for being among the world's five biggest buyers of Russian oil. This leaves New Delhi in a spot over a cheap source of energy just as new shockwaves from West Asia drive up global crude prices. Given that talks are due on a trade deal with Washington, the US move looks like yet another ploy for Trump to drive a hard bargain. In the face of this, India must make a distinction between aberrative and sustainable US policies. Will Trump's chosen trade 'lane' endure? If not, no concession need be made under the pressure of this trade-distortive path. As with Fed policy, perhaps the world can expect the US to return to what serves it best, even if it is unclear how long that may take. Thankfully, India's economy has proven resilient this year. Its pace of expansion is globally enviable and recently released data had signs of a capex cycle on its way up. Lane driving may not be in much evidence on our streets, but what we do in policy terms counts for more.

We need proactive government intervention to control inflation

Worsening food inflation warrants policy moves before household hardship reaches far and wide



HIMANSHU
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Earlier this week, estimates of inflation for August based on the consumer price index (CPI) and whole-sale price index (WPI) were released. Both indices showed a rise in overall inflation driven by food prices, a trend which has been building up for quite some time now. CPI inflation accelerated from 2.7% in January to 4.8% in August while WPI inflation accelerated from 1.2% to 9.9% during that period. However, retail food inflation accelerated faster from 2.1% to almost 6%, with faster price increases in rural areas. This was also true for WPI, which showed food inflation swinging sharply from -0.4% to 7%. In both cases, food inflation has exceeded the overall inflation pace. The rise in inflation is not surprising, given pressures globally due to the war in West Asia along with worries over the impact of a deficient monsoon on agricultural production. To be sure, the rate of CPI inflation is still within the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) tolerance band of 2-6%, but worries revolve around its expected trajectory over the coming months, food prices especially. The impact of the ongoing troubles is unlikely to be limited to food items. A spillover is likely to other commodities and services, which is already starting to show by way of India's hardening core inflation. Also, high WPI inflation will sooner or later get transmitted to retail inflation in food items, but also other

goods and services across the country. The worry is real, given that the situation in West Asia is volatile, having just driven up global fuel prices again. While there is not much that can be done about this, supply shocks from the monsoon deficiency and a strengthening El Niño phenomenon call for proactive government intervention. As of 15 September, our overall monsoon deficiency stood at 15% of the rainfall norm for the season, but it was unevenly distributed, with more than half of the country reporting deficient rains. This not only affects crop sowing, but also yields. The US Department of Agriculture (USDA) in a recent report projected a 9% decline in maize production and 4.6% decline in paddy production this year. According to WPI data, paddy inflation was in negative territory from May 2025 to April 2026 but has sharply accelerated to 4.2% in the four months since. The trend in rice prices mirrors the global acceleration in cereal prices. The Food and Agriculture Organisation (FAO), which tracks global food prices, reported its fastest rise in global cereal prices in August; cereal inflation was at 10% last month after staying negative for 36 months until February 2026. The FAO index also shows a sharp rise in inflation for edible oils and sugar. Edible-oil inflation, according to WPI data,

has been above 10% since November 2025. Sugar prices have also spiked in the last two months.

The government has limited space to deal with international factors or the domestic supply shortfalls caused by a weak monsoon. Monetary policy too is unlikely to be of help in containing food inflation. However, there are a few policy choices that the government may have to make. The most important is picking between ensuring food security in times of supply shocks and its bio-fuel push as a priority. This choice is no longer academic. It requires a decision that will impact the future trajectory of food inflation. With sugar prices already at a high and production likely to fall short even this year, any further ethanol blending will require larger diversions from paddy and maize. Both these crops are already showing high inflationary trends domestically and globally. Maize is also a large ingredient in livestock feed, particularly poultry. Given the USDA's forecast of a decline in production, any diversion towards ethanol blending will also elevate egg and meat prices, which are already rising at double-digit clips, according to August WPI data. The government's choice is between food security and the diversion of precious grains to fuel blending.

Further, any *ad hoc* policy measures such as stock limits and excessive controls on agricultural trading, including international trade, would be counter-productive and should be avoided. The current episode of sugar inflation is as much a result of a decline in production as one of unpredictable policy.

More importantly, any rise in food inflation will squeeze the disposable incomes of a majority of India's rural and urban households for whom food still accounts for almost half their household budget. With agriculture unlikely to perform remuneratively and rural wages stagnant, the country needs to protect the lives of its rural and urban poor through greater public spending and public employment.

QUICK READ

Inflation is within its acceptable limits but it's the upward trend that policymakers need to worry about. This has been in evidence at the wholesale and retail levels, especially in the case of food.

With agriculture under strain amid deficient rainfall and oil making new shockwaves, the government must protect households that see food eating up almost half their budget.

10 YEARS AGO



JUST A THOUGHT

If you put tariffs in place, it creates inflation. If you put inflation in place, you have to raise interest rates. You raise interest rates, and stock markets shouldn't be so high.

BILL BROWDER

GUEST VIEW

RBI supervision: prudent transparency can be an asset

RAVI DUVVURU



is founder and partner, Duvvuru & Reddy LLP, and member of the Reserve Bank of India's advisory group on regulation

There has been considerable discussion around enforcement actions taken by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), including on the need for an appellate authority similar to the Securities Appellate Tribunal for decisions of the Securities and Exchange Board of India. But there has been relatively little debate about the why, what and how of enforcement, particularly the distinction between enforcement and supervisory action.

RBI's actions broadly take two forms: penal action by the Enforcement Department (EDF), which is placed in the public domain, and supervisory action, much of which remains confidential. Understanding this distinction is important to appreciate how RBI exercises its regulatory powers.

Enforcement action principally concerns violations of a statute, regulation or regulatory direction. When a breach is identified during an inspection or through another supervisory process, the matter is referred to the EDF, which examines the issue and, if

needed, issues a show-cause notice seeking the regulated entity's (RE) response. The RE is given an opportunity to make written submissions and, if required, to present its case at a personal hearing before a panel of executive directors. The panel provides an independent layer of review in the enforcement process, examining the material on record and the RE's submissions before reaching a decision. A reasoned order follows. Importantly, there are cases where the proposed penalties have been dropped or reduced after considering the RE's submissions. Unfortunately, this aspect of the process is not publicly visible. So, public attention tends to focus on penalties imposed rather than cases where the proposed action has been modified or dropped.

Supervisory action serves a different purpose. Its objective is not merely to punish a past violation, but address weaknesses that could pose risks to the safety and soundness of an RE, its customers or the financial system. Such intervention can range from informal engagement to significant restrictions on business, addressing weaknesses in governance, risk management, cyber and information technology systems, related-party exposures, customer conduct, capital, compliance systems and internal controls.

Where supervisory action is contemplated, the RE is given a chance to explain its position and provide additional information. RBI considers these submissions before taking a decision, often at a senior level. Unlike enforcement proceedings, there is no separate appellate panel for supervisory decisions. There is a practical reason for this. Supervisory intervention often needs to be timely to be effective, and another layer of review could defeat that purpose. Moreover, significant supervisory decisions are generally preceded by extensive engagement between RBI and the RE.

RBI does not maintain a publicly accessible, entity-level database of all supervisory interventions. Material actions may nevertheless become public through RBI announcements or, in the case of listed entities, through disclosures to stock exchanges.

There are sound reasons for this approach. Banking and financial services are built on trust. Public disclosure of

every supervisory observation could create unintended consequences, including reputational damage and loss of depositor confidence. A related point is often overlooked: a clean enforcement record does not necessarily mean that an RE has a clean supervisory record.

What can be done to make the framework more transparent, predictable and proportionate, without compromising confidentiality or financial stability?

First, RBI could publish aggregate information on enforcement cases in which the proposed penalties were subsequently dropped, reduced or modified after considering submissions from REs. This would provide a balanced picture of the enforcement process.

Second, RBI could articulate the broad principles governing supervisory escalation. It need not publish rigid thresholds, but could explain how concerns may progress from observations and corrective-ac-

tion requirements to enhanced monitoring and, if necessary, restrictions or other interventions. This would help demonstrate that supervisory action is the outcome of an escalation process rather than a sudden decision.

Third, for particularly consequential supervisory actions, an internal 'second look' by a senior official or a group independent of the original supervisory team could provide an additional safeguard. This need not be an appellate mechanism and should not delay urgent intervention.

Fourth, for industry benefit, RBI could also publish anonymised supervisory case studies, explaining the nature of a deficiency, why it was material, the corrective action sought and the supervisory response.

Finally, RBI could draw upon global peers such as the European Central Bank, Bank of England's Prudential Regulation Authority and the Federal Reserve to develop a structured protocol for the communication of supervisory activities.

The debate should not be whether we need another appellate authority, but how to make the existing enforcement and supervisory architecture more transparent, predictable, proportionate and accountable. Transparency, though, should not weaken supervision, but strengthen confidence in it.



| THEIR VIEW

MINT CURATOR

Could we face another meltdown if an American AI bubble bursts?

Grand investments in AI going bad might set off a chain of knock-on effects whose pain would spread in multiple directions



BARRY EICHENGREEN

is professor of economics and political science at the University of California, Berkeley, and the author, most recently, of 'Money Beyond Borders: Global Currencies From Croesus to Crypto.'

For months, if not years, artificial intelligence (AI) has dominated speculation about the future, which has fuelled speculation in the present. AI-related ventures are largely responsible for the rapid increase of the S&P 500 stock index. Investment in data centres is a major contributor to the rise in US interest rates, as borrowing for construction competes for credit with a deficit-prone federal government.

With so much investment riding on a fast-developing new technology, what happens if the cash flow and profits of the hyperscalers building data centres, and of AI firms renting that infrastructure (two categories that overlap), turn out to disappoint? What would this disappointment mean for financial markets?

Would a crisis be in the offing?

This scenario could materialize for any number of reasons. The productivity benefits of AI could be overhyped, in which case firms contemplating the adoption of frontier models will curtail their demand for tokens, the basic units of data processed by such models. Or the availability of open-weight models, which enable users to tailor a model's parameters to their needs, may allow those users to build small language models that run on their own infrastructure or even on laptops like the one I am using to write this commentary. Either way, the income accruing to investors in data centres will fall short of expectations.

The most immediate and visible impact would be a sharp drop in the lofty stock prices of the 'Magnificent 7,' the seven ultra-large-cap tech and tech-adjacent firms that have driven the S&P 500. But stock-market corrections are no guarantee of crises or even of recessions.

If the price of Meta shares falls, its chief Mark Zuckerberg will buy fewer castles in Ireland. There would be a slowdown in consumption and investment spending. There would be pain for investment funds, such as Situational Awareness, that specialize in AI-related ventures.

But a financial crisis would follow only if banks, insurance companies and other mainstream institutional investors were implicated. And there is little evidence that they are heavily exposed to AI equity risk.

Developments in debt markets are more worrisome. With the cost of data-centre construction exceeding their sponsors' free cash flow, and with income from potential tenants still a distant prospect, much of this investment is being financed by borrowing from private credit funds (non-bank firms making privately negotiated loans).

If demand for data-centre services is lower than expected, these loans will fail to perform, which is a polite way of saying that borrowers will default. The question then becomes who is invested in



ISTOCKPHOTO

private credit funds. The popular image is of the same family offices and high-net-worth individuals who invest in venture capital and can afford occasional losses.

But the reality is that the vast majority of private credit is provided by institutional investors: pension funds, insurance companies and, dare I say, university endowments.

Moreover, private credit funds have been taking steps to tap this institutional money by acquiring insurance companies, whose asset portfolios they can load up with loans.

This invites the spectre of an insurance industry crisis, which could play out in several ways. Insurance companies' private credit parents could recapitalize them, assuming they have the funds. Alternatively, state guarantee funds, to which healthy insurance companies contribute, could fund the recapitalization, although there will be no healthy companies if the entire industry comes tumbling down. Lastly, the federal government could step in with a bailout, as it did for American International Group in 2008.

In addition to borrowing from pension funds and insurance companies, private credit firms borrow from commercial banks, using their portfolio of loans as collateral, thereby leveraging their commitments and juicing their returns.

Even if banks don't lend to or invest in AI businesses and data centres directly, they may still be on the hook. We can only hope that their regulators are watching.

Finally, private credit firms originally built on a buy-and-hold model now increasingly securitize their loans. They package those loans through special purpose vehicles that issue bonds backed

by the associated cash flows, where the bonds are divided into risk tiers or tranches claiming first, second and third dibs on debt-service payments.

The so-called 'mezzanine' tranche of medium-risk bonds is then sold on to other asset managers. To assess the immediacy of crisis risk, we would need to know more about the riskiness of this mezzanine tranche and who holds it.

We don't. If you are reminded of the roles of securitization, special purpose vehicles, tranching and opacity in the subprime-mortgage crisis of 2007-08, you are not alone.

Just as debt markets fuelled the global financial near-meltdown that followed from that crisis, their exposure to AI will drive developments now. The problem is that we possess only very limited public information about those markets and regulators are not making that information any easier to obtain.

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QUICK READ

Massive loans taken to finance enormous investments in data centres and other AI-related fields could go bad should demand for AI not live up to grand expectations.

High net-worth individuals, family offices, banks, insurers, pension funds and even university endowments may suffer harsh blows if optimism over AI proves overdone.

Influencers are upending the status quo and nobody's happy

Exclusivity is dying and that's sure to have economic consequences



ALLISON SCHRAGER

is a Bloomberg Opinion columnist covering economics.

They say you can tell a lot about a person by what appears on their social media feed. I am not sure what that says about me, since I see a lot of videos of wealthy, forlorn women explaining why they regret buying their Birkin handbags.

The problem isn't that the bags are too heavy or the wrong colour, or that their owners now can't afford rent. No, what these women regret about their \$10,000-plus purchase is that people they find distasteful are posting videos about their own Birkins. And once influencers have Birkins, by definition, Birkins are no longer exclusive. And if they don't signal exclusivity, what's the point?

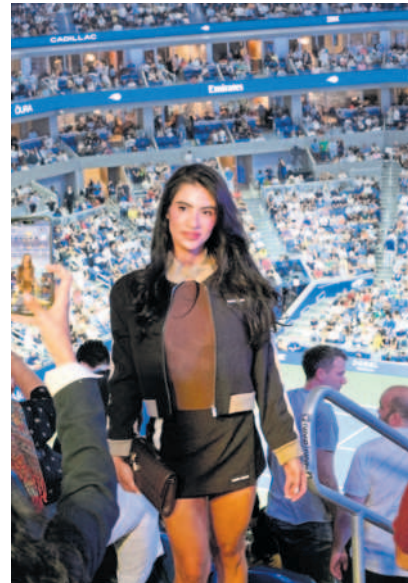
Birkins are not the only luxury item influencers are ruining (metaphorically, anyway). They are also making the US Open, once a civilized affair, less pleasant. Influencers bring their ring lights, make a lot of noise, have little interest in the match, and are even distracting players. To be fair, many of them—about 100—were invited by tournament officials.

Influencer culture poses challenges to brands and products that are supposed to be exclusive. Markers of status have been jumbled, and there is a new hierarchy. The traditional channels of influence—magazines or network TV—don't have the reach they once did. Gone are the days when high-powered PR people could promote brands or events simply by speaking directly to the elite.

Nowadays, brands target people directly on their phones. This requires getting everyone excited about the same goods through carefully targeted marketing—or getting influencers to talk about a product and make it look appealing. It is a mess of incentives all around.

For one, people listen to influencers because they trust their opinion. But often they are paid or given what they are shilling. What's more, this process is even more fraught with exclusive goods and services. Influencers thrive on influence (hence the name), so they need to attract very large audiences. But part of the appeal of a Birkin or a ticket to the US Open is that it is something that not everyone can afford. As branding becomes more democratic, it changes the nature of luxury goods and experiences.

To some extent, this is by design. The US Open sells more tickets than it used to, including grounds passes—but at a higher price. As a result, the event has become more crowded. The US Tennis Association wants and needs more mass-market appeal. The influencers are a symptom



Luxury handbags are getting too common for their status-signalling role. REUTERS

rather than the cause of the problem; they were invited for a reason. Wimbledon made a different choice.

The number of Birkins, by contrast, is limited by its marketer Hermès; they are not sold to strangers off the street. But there is a secondary market in which anyone who can pay can participate. Sellers there have an interest in reaching lots of people and convincing them they should pay up to three times the already-high retail price. Hermès may not be directly complicit in this arrangement, but it does benefit. The secondary market drives demand and has contributed to a 44% increase in bag prices in the primary market over the last 10 years.

Granted, there is a limited market for people who will pay this much for a handbag. But the point of exclusivity—whether at a tennis tournament or with a handbag—is that it's not just about money. It is mostly a status game, and at this level what matters is excluding people most similar to you. If everyone has a Birkin or a box at the Open, what kind of status does it confer?

The upshot is a luxury market where everything is simultaneously available, unaffordable and somehow still in high demand. No one is happy.

And before you say it, allow me: No, this is not the biggest economic problem facing America. There was nothing efficient or welfare-enhancing about exclusivity. If the reason you want a handbag that costs as much as a used car is so no one else can have it, maybe you should be spending that money on therapy instead. Gatekeeping at the US Open is more understandable, because large crowds make the experience less pleasant. Even then, there are bigger tragedies than tennis tournaments crowded with people taking photos of their cocktails.

At the same time, it is important to acknowledge that influencer culture, especially the way it changes consumption habits, directs lots of economic activity.

On one hand, what we see on our phones is unique to us. On the other, we all somehow want the same inaccessible things. The result is either higher prices or bigger crowds—or both. This does not seem sustainable. Technology is upending the old equilibrium of the American economy and that's likely to have serious consequences beyond a Birkin.

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| MY VIEW | PEN DRIVE

Goa's missing millions: make it a global hotspot again

PIYUSH DOSHI & HEMANT JOSHI



are, respectively, operating partner, The Convergence Foundation, and CEO, Atithi Foundation

On separate trips to Bali undertaken by each of us, we could not help comparing it to Goa—as blessed in terms of beachlines, forests, culture, cuisine and waterfalls as Bali is. Yet, our experience as tourists was markedly different.

In Bali, we could summon a Grab, know what it would cost and follow it on our phones. In Goa, with Uber and Ola kept out, finding a taxi meant either a semi-effective app or a negotiation over an exorbitant fare. Waterfalls in Bali had well managed parking lots, ticket counters, paved access, railings, toilets, changing facilities and small cafés. None of these things cost a fortune, but together they turned a beautiful waterfall into a pleasant half-day excursion. Goa's Dudhsagar falls were every bit as beautiful, perhaps more so. But the standout memory is of a backbreaking journey in a ramshackle vehicle on an apology of a road. Even an evening stroll was a hurdle race across unpaved shoulders and broken footpaths.

It is not that Bali could do this because it is richer. Goa's per capita income is almost twice that of Bali. The question is whether Goa cares enough about being a world-class tourist destination for high-paying tourists.

In 2010, Goa drew about 440,000 foreign tourists; Bali drew 2.5 million. Since then, Bali's inflow has nearly tripled, and in 2025 set a record of about 7 million. Goa has added fewer than 80,000 foreign tourists in 15 years. Why has Goa fallen so far behind? Four largely man-made constraints stand out, and each has a fix.

Room shortage: Goa has about 69,000 registered hotel rooms, but only some 10,000 branded keys. Bali has around 60,000 classified hotel rooms, before counting its enormous villa and rental stock. Phuket is moving past 100,000. Global tour operators can't build scale around a destination without inventory across price points. Branded supply is constrained by lack of clarity on what may be built where. As of mid-2026, Goa is India's last coastal state without even a draft Coastal Zone Management Plan under the relevant 2019 notification. On top of that, investors face overlapping coastal, town-planning, panchayat and environmental approvals, an endless pro-

cess before construction can legally begin.

Environmental protection must not weaken, but investors need certainty: hard no-build areas where ecological assets require them, developable areas marked out and time-bound approvals. Goa should aid growth by identifying tourism zones away from sensitive beachfronts where an enlarged floor area ratio is exchanged for open space, sewage and drainage capacity and guaranteed public beach access, with a redevelopment policy for ageing prime land.

Weak air-links: Goa has two airports and ample runway capacity. In 2025, they together handled 1,784 scheduled international flights, bringing 236,000 foreign arrivals. Charter flights, once the spine of the winter season, numbered 189 and carried only about 40,000, against over 1,000 such flights bringing roughly 250,000 visitors at their peak. This collapse accounts for most of

Goa's missing foreign arrivals. In contrast, Bali and Phuket did not wait for air traffic to materialize; they bid for it with route-development incentives and co-funded destination marketing. Goa built the infrastructure and assumed arrivals would follow. It should now buy the air back: a three-year route-development programme at its Mopa airport, with support tied to incremental international seats and sustained load factors, plus joint overseas marketing to attract charters while pursuing long-haul and hub connections that can support year-round arrivals.

Cab cringe: Goa has roughly 12,000 tourist taxis and a local taxi app does operate. What it lacks is a genuinely open, competitive ride-hailing market with the ubiquity, predictable pricing and ease of use that visitors now take for granted across much of Asia. This is a regulatory and political problem, which means it can be fixed faster than others. Foster

a competitive aggregator regime with transparent fares, while offering taxi owners attractive terms to join: guaranteed earnings through the transition, financing for vehicle upgrades and other incentives.

An under-built public realm: The weakest part of Goa's tourism appeal may be what happens outside the hotel gate. There are very few good promenades, inconsistent footpaths and lighting, inadequate parking, uneven waste management, weak traffic discipline and almost no walkable coastal edge. Bali's tourist strips may be congested, but large parts are both walkable and commercially vibrant. The remedy is neither expensive nor complicated. Start with the 10 busiest beaches: promenades where appropriate, lighting, drainage, toilets, waste collection, pedestrian paths and peripheral parking linked by electric shuttle services. These are unglamorous investments with an outsized effect on visitor experience. Fund them transparently through a modest visitor levy, as Bali has introduced.

Goa need not become Bali or Phuket, and should not try. But it does need to stop being a destination with extraordinary natural advantages that squandered them through lack of imagination or execution.

Taking the analogue route in Hollywood

In an age of electric cars and Instagram-first dining, West Hollywood's pockets of the past give this Gen X writer's soul a sense of belonging

Rishad Saam Mehta

I grew up with LPs that cracked before the music began, cassette tapes that hissed between songs, and cars with simple mechanical locks you could coax open and hotwire to start without a key.

Junk food was a milkshake made with milk and fresh fruit and burgers came off a griddle rather than an assembly line, messy to eat and satisfyingly meaty. Movie stars were giant figures on 70mm screens, and when a movie star could dance, it was raw rhythm and footwork.

I recently breezed through West Hollywood, a city I'd known mostly through music and movies, and somewhere between the Sunset Strip, a recording studio, a collection of analogue automobiles, and a serendipitous hotel lobby encounter, I wandered right back into my Gen X youth.

On the Sunset Strip, that 1.5-mile stretch between Beverly Hills and Hollywood that became Los Angeles' epicentre of live rock music from the '60s through the '80s, I walked past the Whisky a Go Go, where The Doors served house-band duty when Jim Morrison was just a strange, brilliant kid, and past the Troubadour, where Elton John made his State-side debut on a stool and under a spotlight. At the Rainbow Bar & Grill, I had a drink at a bar that had once poured for Led Zeppelin, David Bowie and John Lennon.

I'll always argue, with full Gen X bias and zero apology, that the music of our youth was solid gold. A guitar solo back then was a physical negotiation between fingers and steel strings, not a setting dialled up in software; a vocalist's rasp was a byproduct of three packs a day and late nights, not something tweaked in post-production. The lyrics meant something—heartbreak, rebellion, lust—sung by people who'd clearly lived through whichever one they were singing about that night.

It was the Sunset Marquis, tucked into a cul-de-sac off the Strip, that gave me goosebumps. This hotel hadn't just witnessed the era I'd grown up on—it had recorded it. In its basement is NightBird Studios, born, so the story goes, when guitarist Jeff Beck and a producer got a noise complaint for jamming too loud and were banished downstairs to keep going. More than 200 Grammy-winning songs have been made or mixed within its walls since.

Upstairs, in the Morrison Hotel Gallery, the walls were floor-to-ceiling with photographs that weren't posed so much as caught: Freddie Mercury mid-arch, one hand choking the microphone as if it owed him money; Debbie



(Clockwise from above) Roxy Theatre in West Hollywood; Petersen Automotive Museum; and a Freddie Mercury image at the Morrison Hotel Gallery.



Harry in leather and don't-care eyeliner; Led Zeppelin lounging before their private jet like it was a school bus.

A short drive from the Strip, in the Miracle Mile district, the Petersen Automotive Museum, a world-class institution, houses one of the most diverse, historically significant car collections on Earth. Room after room held beautifully designed cars with potent, carbureted engines. These were the cars that had occupied bedroom walls when I was growing up. A few, like Herbie the racing-striped Beetle and the gull-winged DeLorean, we loved simply because the silver screen told us to.

When I came of motoring age there were no electronic nannies overruling a driver's instincts, no computer deciding if knew better. Every car demanded to be driven, not merely operated. An understeer was yours to own. A

slide was yours to correct. The car and driver were in an actual conversation, not a chaperoned one. A prime example: the Aston Martin DB5 parked beneath a photograph of Sean Connery leaning against its bonnet like he owned the road and the decade. Sure, it had machine guns and ejector seats, but it didn't need a reversing camera or cornering assist. Bond just needed a good gearbox and good looks, and the DB5 gave him both.

West Hollywood's dining scene is genuinely chic—sleek patios, celebrated chefs and plating that flirts with a camera. But I went looking for its less polished side. At Carney's, I climbed into a genuine 1975 Union Pacific railroad car and ordered a Chili Angus Beef Cheeseburger, which arrived unapologetically messy as a burger should, dripping down both wrists before the second bite—precisely the kind of comfort food my generation was raised on. Down the road, I queued at Tail o' the Pup, the hot-dog-shaped stand that fed Hollywood since

1946, vanished in 2005, and was resurrected in 2022—fittingly, in the building where the Doors recorded their final album, *L.A. Woman*, in 1971.

With a full stomach and an equally full heart, I headed back to The London, entirely unprepared for the evening's final flourish. Every visitor to Hollywood secretly hopes to spot a star on the street, much like every visitor to Bombay hopes to catch a glimpse of Bollywood glitterati. I've lived in Bombay my whole life and never once spotted an actor at random, so I didn't have my eyes peeled in West Hollywood either, which is probably why it took a moment or two, after we'd crossed paths in the lobby of my hotel, for the familiarity in the gait to register. That characteristic stride from the streets of Brooklyn with *Stayin' Alive* playing in the background is still very much there.

Realisation hit like a bolt. I turned and called out, "John".

It was, indeed, John Travolta, entirely on his own. He was clearly headed somewhere, but he graciously paused to indulge a stranger who'd addressed him by his first name for a three-minute conversation. Here was the man who'd set the silver screen alight with *Saturday Night Fever*, making every Gen-X man attempt that pointing-hip strut. Here was the man, who'd twirled Princess Diana around the White House floor, and who, alongside Uma Thurman in *Pulp Fiction*, turned a straight-faced shuffle and a lazy sweep of fingers past the eyes into one of cinema's most imitated dance scenes. Here, too, was a licensed pilot rated to fly a Boeing 747.

For a few minutes, I wasn't toeing the line of senior citizenship at 50-something; I was 17 again, grinning with glee.

He asked if I'd like a photo. I said yes.

I didn't go to West Hollywood looking for flashbacks to my teens and twenties. But between the Strip, the Marquis, the Petersen, a messy burger and a chance encounter in a hotel lobby, it found me anyway—loud, analogue, and tangible.

Write to us at feedback@livemint.com



By Maite Delteil.

For the weekend Lots of cheese, with a bit of art

A Mint round up of what's happening in and around the city

DELHI

HEADS: EVERY FACE HOLDS A STORY

Till 23 September

Curated by Amrita Kochhar, this group exhibition explores the human face as the place of identity, thought, emotion, memory and experience. It features works by artists, including Anjolie Ela Menon, Arpana Caur, G. Subramanian, Ramesh Gorjala, Jatin Das, Maite Delteil, Thota Vankuntam and Vasundhara Broota.

11am-8pm. Shridharani Gallery, Triveni Kala Sangam.

BENGALURU

OKTOBERFEST

19 September-4 October

Enjoy the German festival in your city with a food pop-up. On offer will be a selection of Oktoberfest favourites, from Emmenthal, Camembert, English cheddar and bocconcini, to warm Kartoffelsalat with bacon and onion. There will also be Nurnberg with tangy sauerkraut, the Sausage Sampler, Wiener Schnitzel and Linzer Torte.

12.30-3.30pm. The Verandah, Grand Mercure, Koramangala.



Oktoberfest at The Verandah, Bengaluru.

DEKH BEHEN 2

19 September

Written by Dilshad Edibam Khurana and Tahira Nath Krishnan, this 80-minute comedy play by Akvarious Productions follows the chaotic adventures of five friends who are meeting after five years for a vegetarian, alcohol-free wedding celebration.

3.30pm-7.30pm. Ranga Shankara, 8th Cross Road, RK Colony, JP Nagar. For details, visit in.bookmyshow.com

HYDERABAD

DESIGN DEMOCRACY

18-20 September

Over 200 brands and 1,500 architects and designers are coming together to showcase installations, art and the new emerging practices in the field of design.

11am onwards. Hitec Exhibition Centre, Hitec Road, Izzathnagar. For details, visit Designdemocracy.in.

The new airport luxury: a BMW tarmac drop-off

Airports are adding exclusive terminals with a private lounge and haircut services to make travel hassle free

Bloomberg

The champagne is chilled, the caviar is served, and you don't have to worry about your luggage. Pink couches covered in green palm trees are very Miami. Lounge chairs around a reflecting pool offer a quiet escape.

From a private suite with a balcony, you can order croquetas and Cuban panzanella, or request a massage or haircut. When it's time to board, a driver is waiting to chauffeur you in a BMW across the tarmac, directly to your commercial flight at Miami International Airport.

It's the perks of flying private, without actually flying on a private jet.

Air travel has never been more crowded, with long security lines, packed terminals and overflowing lounges.

Some travellers are so fed up that they are paying over \$5,000 for access to a private terminal to bypass the hassles of the airport.

Luxurious private terminals are being

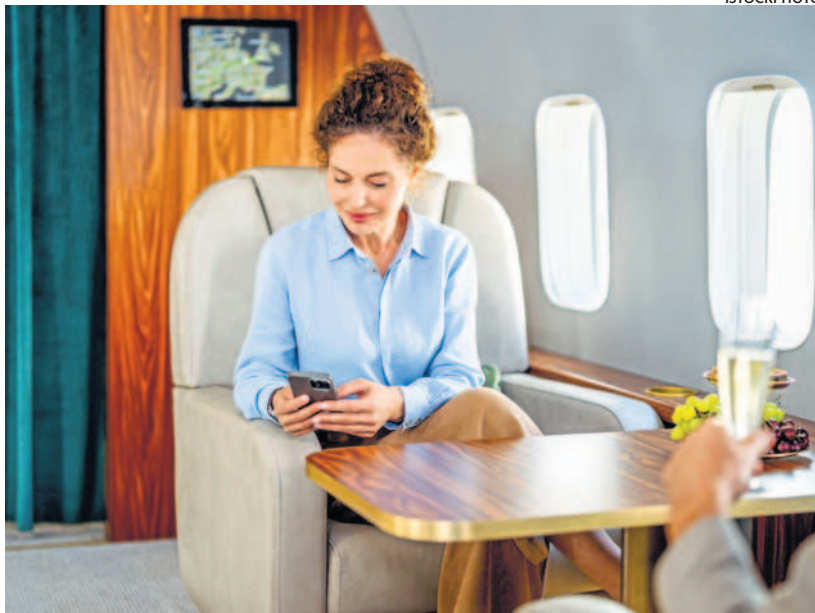
built across the US, widening the economic divide at the airport. Most fliers would balk at spending thousands of dollars on top of the cost of their plane tickets. Airports say the spaces meet demand from a wealthier clientele who prize convenience and privacy, but not so wealthy that they have a private jet.

When Joi Gibbs, 45, walks into the PS terminal at Hartsfield-Jackson Atlanta International Airport, the staff whisks her luggage away and hands her a glass of Billecart-Salmon, her favourite bubbly. She typically orders a burger or a salad and has a couple of drinks before being driven to the plane.

Gibbs pays a fee to tag along with her friend who has a PS membership, and she said it's worth the price, particularly for the separate security check and skipping the line at the gate.

"There's no waiting. I don't have to lift a finger," said Gibbs, who works in technology operations in healthcare and as a content creator. "There's no people when I go into that private lounge."

Customers of PS, formerly known as The Private Suite, can bypass the main airport terminal entirely and go through a separate security check for departures or through a dedicated US Customs and Border Protection screening on arrival. Travellers can pay for access to the "Salon," a shared lounge limited to those 21 and



older, or for a fully private room.

The all-access membership costs \$4,850 a year, and each visit then costs \$895 a person for the Salon or \$3,650 for a group of up to four in a private suite. Non-members can pay \$1,295 a person for a visit to the Salon, but they have to sign up for the waitlist and can only get in if the location has space that day. Once inside, food, drinks and most amenities are

included, though tipping is encouraged.

It still costs far less than NetJets Inc., where access to private jets starts at \$215,000. Holders of the American Express Centurion, or "Black Card," can get a complimentary PS membership and a reduced rate of \$825 a person for each visit to the Salon.

"We've emerged as a third category between commercial and private air

travel," said Amina Belouizdad Porter, chief executive officer of PS.

Even as higher fares and economic pressures keep some travellers at home, those who are taking trips are increasingly willing to spend more on premium experiences. Affluent leisure travellers make up 26% of global travellers but account for 57% of reported airport spending, according to a 2026 survey by Airport Dimensions. Among the 11,000 travellers surveyed, 62% said they are willing to pay for upgraded airport experiences such as lounge access, fast-track services and premium retail.

"The definition of luxury has changed a lot, and it's so much more about time, privacy, certainty and control," said Porter. "People are willing to spend more money to get their time back, and I think this was very much accelerated by the pandemic."

Travellers like Tyler Brown, an industrial systems engineer in Miami, would prefer airports to focus on improving the experience for frequent fliers, not just the people who can pay the most.

"I don't see the terminal as doing anything that isn't just coming up with a new model that costs more than the last one, just to keep weeding out more and more people," said Brown, 27. "I get it, but air travel has definitely gotten so much worse in recent times."

Soon, PS won't be the only company to

run a private terminal in the US.

Washington Dulles International Airport got the green light from the airport authority in July to move forward with a private terminal project.

The Metropolitan Washington Airport Authority, which operates Dulles, and daa International didn't provide further details because the plans are still in the early stages.

San Francisco International Airport is looking for a developer to build and operate such a terminal, with an opening planned for late 2028. "There is clearly a demand among travellers for paying for an elevated experience," said Doug Yakel, a spokesperson for San Francisco's airport.

"We see other airports taking on remote terminal concepts, so we think the time is right for our airport."

Brittany Callaghan, a 30-year-old stay-at-home mom, is a regular at the PS terminal in Los Angeles, where she and her husband have visited both the Salon and a private suite. "LAX is currently under construction, and we just found it a hassle just dealing with checking in, walking for 30 minutes to our gate and then waiting," Callaghan said. "It's really convenient to show up like an hour or two before, and then it's just like hanging out in your private area."

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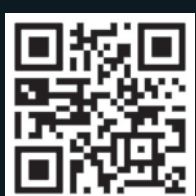
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